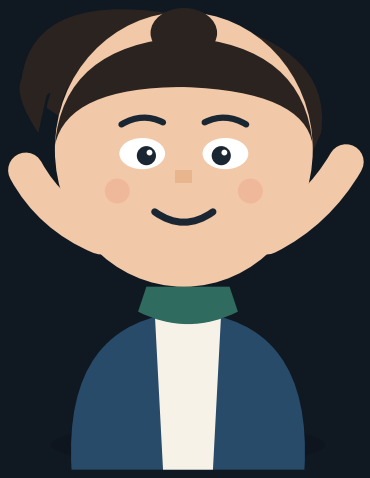
THE COMPLETE MANDARIN COURSE

你好中文

Nǐ hǎo, Zhōngwén! — from first tones to fluent expression



A Self-Study Textbook for Adult Learners

Stage A1 to Stage C2 · Simplified Characters · Hanyu Pinyin

English explanations that gradually give way to Chinese

A1 | A2 | B1 | B2 | C1 | C2

With recurring learning companion Lin Yǔchén

你好中文

The Complete Mandarin Course

A self-study textbook for English-speaking adults

Six stages: A1 · A2 · B1 · B2 · C1 · C2

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First edition. All example dialogues are fictional.

About This Course

What this book is

你好中文(Nǐ hǎo, Zhōngwén!) is a complete self-study course in standard Mandarin Chinese, written for adults who speak English and know nothing about the language yet. It takes you from your very first tone to advanced reading, discussion, and formal writing. Every unit contains a dialogue or reading set in a real-life situation, vocabulary, grammar explanation, exercises with a full answer key, and a practical communication task.

What this book is not

This book is a learning tool, not a certificate. Working through all six stages will build real proficiency, but completing a textbook — any textbook — does not by itself certify your level or grant a qualification. If you need recognised certification (for work, study, or visas), sit a formal assessment such as an HSK or ACTFL/CEFR-aligned test after preparing with external mock exams. The A1–C2 labels in this book are progression bands modelled on the Common European Framework's way of describing levels; they are our own teaching stages, not an official CEFR certification and not an HSK equivalence claim.

A note on HSK

The Hanyu Shuiping Kaoshi (HSK,汉语水平考试) is China's standardised Chinese proficiency test. Its structure has changed over the years: the older HSK 1–6 system was reformed, with a newer framework introducing levels HSK 1–9. Because different books and apps use different HSK frameworks, this book deliberately avoids mapping its stages to HSK

levels. Where we mention HSK at all, we treat it only as a separate external exam you might later choose to take.

Language and script

Mandarin (普通话Pǔtōnghuà, "the common speech") is the standard spoken language of mainland China and one of the official languages of Singapore; it is mutually intelligible with Taiwan's standard Guóyǔ (国语) and closely related to Malaysia's Huáyǔ (华语). Chinese writing is shared across many spoken varieties: a reader in Beijing, Guangzhou, and Taipei can read the same newspaper, even though the spoken varieties differ enormously. Mainland China and Singapore write simplified characters (简体字), while Taiwan, Hong Kong, and Macau generally use traditional characters (繁體字). This book teaches simplified characters, because that is what most learners of mainland-standard Mandarin need first; Stage B1 and later show you how to recognise common traditional forms, and the reference section includes a simplified–traditional comparison guide.

What "Chinese" means

"Chinese" is a family of languages. Mandarin is by far the largest, but Cantonese, Shanghainese (Wu), Hokkien (Min), Hakka, and others are living languages spoken by hundreds of millions. They share a writing system and much vocabulary but are not mutually intelligible when spoken. When people say "I'm learning Chinese," they almost always mean Mandarin, and that is what this book teaches.

Regional and cultural variety

Mandarin is spoken across many communities — mainland China, Taiwan, Singapore, Malaysia, and diaspora communities worldwide. This book deliberately draws its dialogues and readings from a range of these communities, from a breakfast shop in Xi'an to a night market in Taipei to a campus in Singapore. Culture and history appear inside the language lessons — you will learn measure words while ordering noodles, time expressions while preparing for the Mid-Autumn Festival, and narrative structures while reading the story of the Zheng He voyages — not in separate culture chapters.

Pinyin

Hanyu Pinyin (汉语拼音) is the standard romanisation of Mandarin. You will learn it thoroughly in Stage A1: initials, finals, the four tones plus the neutral tone, and the tone-change rules. Pinyin is a ladder, not a crutch: this book gives you full pinyin at first, then gradually reduces it so that by Stage B2 you are reading real Chinese text the way Chinese readers do.

Sources for historical and cultural claims are given in unobtrusive notes at the foot of the relevant pages. Language descriptions follow

mainstream reference grammars (e.g. Yip & Rimmington, Chinese: A Comprehensive Grammar; Li & Thompson, Mandarin Chinese: A Functional Reference Grammar).

Meet Your Learning Companion



Lin Yǔchén (林雨晨) will be with you through the whole book. She is a fictional thirty-something guide, born in Xi'an, living between Beijing and Singapore, a translator by profession who loves tea, train travel, and bad puns in two languages. She has short dark hair, a jade-green scarf, a navy jacket, and a permanent half-smile of someone who has explained tones to foreigners many times and still finds it funny. She introduces activities, flags the traps (and there are many), cheers your progress, and occasionally tells you a story from her own life.

She appears in two forms: her full figure in unit scenes, and her small face in the tip boxes marked “Lin says”. Treat her tips as the voice of a patient tutor who has marked thousands of exercise books.

How to Use This Book

The shape of each unit

Every unit — from A1 to C2 — has the same skeleton: (1) clear objectives, (2) a dialogue or reading in context, (3) vocabulary, (4) pronunciation or character work, (5) accessible grammar explanation with worked examples, (6) exercises with a complete answer key at the back, and (7) a practical communication task you do on your own. Revision units close each stage, and each stage ends with an end-of-level assessment.

Listening without supplied audio

This book ships as a self-contained text: no recordings are bundled with it, and we will not pretend otherwise. Every dialogue and listening-style exercise is therefore accompanied by its full script, which you use in three ways. First, read the dialogue aloud yourself, slowly. Second, use Mandarin text-to-speech (TTS) as a substitute for recorded audio: both iOS and Android have built-in Chinese TTS voices, and most major translation apps can speak Chinese text aloud; paste the dialogue characters into the app and listen repeatedly. Third, self-record: read each line aloud, record yourself on your phone, and compare with the TTS output. These are honest substitutes for supplied audio, clearly labelled as such; nothing in this book invents recordings, links, or QR codes.

Speaking practice without a partner

Independent speaking is built into every unit: role-play prompts where you play both parts, response drills with model answers, self-recording tasks, and “say it out loud” moments marked throughout. Speaking aloud, even alone, is what

trains your mouth — silent study does not.

Characters

You will learn to recognise characters from Unit 1 and to write them with correct stroke order. The stroke models in this book show the character in its finished form with the official stroke count; work through each stroke in the order given in the unit text, using the numbered steps. Handwriting practice grids appear in most A-stage units. Typing Chinese (pinyin input) is taught in Stage A2 — in real life you will type far more than you will write by hand.

Suggested schedules

Three realistic schedules are given below. Whichever you follow, keep two habits: study a little every day rather than a lot once a week, and always do the unit's communication task before moving on. Do not skip revision units; they are where loose knowledge becomes solid.

Assessment

Each stage ends with an assessment covering listening-style comprehension (via the printed scripts), reading, grammar, writing, and speaking. Closed-answer exercises have complete answer keys. Speaking and writing tasks have annotated model responses and marking criteria so you can judge your own work honestly. Score your end-of-stage assessments; if you fall below the stated pass guide for a section, revise that section before proceeding.

Suggested Study Schedules

Intensive	90+ min	6–7 days/week, 1 unit/2–3 days	3–6 weeks	Study leave, immersion

If you already know some Chinese

Start at Unit 1 anyway, but move fast: do the exercises of each unit and, if you score comfortably, advance. Use the Stage A2 assessment at the end of Stage A1 as a placement check — if you clear it, jump to Stage A2 and repeat. Learners with passive knowledge (heritage learners) usually find Stages A1–A2 fast and hit their real learning curve at B1.

Progress checklist habit

After each unit, rate yourself 1–5 on the unit objectives before you look at the answers. Keep the ratings on a page at the back of the book. Any objective below 3 after the revision unit needs a second pass — not the whole unit again, just that objective's exercises and communication task.

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STAGE A1

基础

Foundations

— greet people, introduce yourself and others, and exchange basic personal information

— master Hanyu Pinyin: initials, finals, the four tones, the neutral tone, and key tone changes

— count, tell time, talk about family, food, and daily routine in simple sentences

— read and write the first 120 characters, and type Chinese with pinyin input

Stage A1 assumes zero knowledge of Chinese. Take it slowly: pronunciation habits formed now are the ones you keep forever.

UNIT 1

你好！

Greetings, names, and why tones matter

In this unit you will learn to:

- greet people and respond to greetings
- ask someone's name and give your own
- say you are learning Chinese
- pronounce the four tones and hear the difference

Dialogue: first day in class

雨晨

你好！

Nǐ hǎo!

Hello!

马克

你好！我是马克。你呢?

Nǐ hǎo! Wǒ shì Mǎkè. Nǐ ne?

Hello! I'm Mark. And you?

雨晨

我是林雨晨。我是老师。

Wǒ shì Lín Yǔchén. Wǒ shì lǎoshī.

I'm Lin Yǔchén. I'm the teacher.

马克

太好了！我学中文。

Tài hǎo le! Wǒ xué Zhōngwén.

Wonderful! I'm learning Chinese.

雨晨

欢迎你！

Huānyíng nǐ!

Welcome!

Pinyin: the four tones

Mandarin is a tonal language: the pitch pattern of a syllable is part of the word itself, just as its consonants and vowels are. The same sounds with different tones are different words. Pinyin marks tones with diacritics over the main vowel:

Pinyin	Tone	How to say it	Example
mā	first tone 阴平	high and level — like holding a sung note	妈mā (mother)
má	second tone 阳平	rising — like an English “huh?” said politely	麻má (hemp)
mǎ	third tone 上声	dips low and rises	马mǎ (horse)
mà	fourth tone 去声	falls sharply — like a firm “No!”	骂mà (to scold)
ma	neutral tone 轻声	light and quick, unstressed	吗ma (question particle)



Listen to the sequence mā má mǎ mà ma carefully with TTS (paste妈麻马骂吗into any Chinese voice).

The classic beginner mistake is treating tones as emotion or emphasis. They are not: tone is the consonants and vowels of pitch. Māma骂马is not something you want to call your mother.

Grammar:是and the “X是Y” pattern

The verb是(shì,“to be”) links two nouns. It never changes for person or tense — no“am/is/are”to worry about:

我是马克。	Wǒ shì Mǎkè.	I am Mark.
我是老师。	Wǒ shì lǎoshī.	I am a teacher.

她是雨晨。 Tā shì Yǔchén. She is Yǔchén.

Note that Chinese has no word for “a/an”:我是老师means “I am a teacher”. Personal pronouns:我wǒ (I, me),你nǐ (you),他tā (he),她tā (she).

Vocabulary

A	1
你好	nǐ hǎo
我	wǒ
你	nǐ
他	tā
她	tā
是	shì
老师	lǎoshī
学生	xuésheng
学	xué
中文	Zhōngwén
太…了	tài…le
欢迎	huānyíng
吗	ma

Characters:你好

Each Chinese character is written with a fixed number of strokes in a fixed order. The two characters below are your first.

Write each one five times in the grids, saying its pinyin and tone aloud as you write.

你 好

你(nǐ,“you”): 7 strokes. Left part亻(the “person” radical, itself 2 strokes), right part尔. Mnemonic (a story to remember it by, not its real history): a person亻 standing under a little roof of strokes, paying attention to you.

好(hǎo,“good”): 6 strokes. Left part女(“woman”), right part子(“child”) — woman and child together, a joyful picture.

This is in fact close to the character's genuine ancient etymology; it was composed from女and子from the start.



From now on, every character story labelled“mnemonic”is a memory aid I made up. When a character's real origin is known and reliable, I'll say“etymology”instead. Knowing which stories are true matters — invented etymology is everywhere in Chinese teaching, and you deserve to know the difference.

Exercises

1. Add tone marks to these pinyin syllables:

   1. ni hao (hello)

   2. wo shi Make (I am Mark)

   3. xu Zhongwen (learn Chinese)

2. Fill in the correct pronoun:

   1. ___是老师。(He is the teacher.)

   2. ___是学生。(I am a student.)

   3. ___很好。(You are well.)

3. Translate into Chinese (write characters and pinyin):

   1. Hello!

   2. I am a student.

   3. She is the teacher.

Communication task

Record a 20-second self-introduction: greet, give your name, say you are learning Chinese. Use only sentences from this unit. Listen back and check your tones against TTS before recording a second take.

UNIT 2

你是哪国人?

Countries, nationalities, and asking questions with吗and呢

In this unit you will learn to:

- say where you are from and ask others
- form yes/no questions with吗
- ask short return questions with呢
- read numbers 0–10 and say a phone number

Dialogue: where are you from?

雨晨

马克，你是哪国人?

Mǎkè, nǐ shì nǎ guó rén?

Mark, which country are you from?

马克

我是美国人。你呢?

Wǒ shì Měiguó rén. Nǐ ne?

I'm American. And you?

雨晨

我是中国人，西安人。

Wǒ shì Zhōngguó rén, Xī'ān rén.

I'm Chinese, from Xi'an.

马克

你在北京工作吗?

Nǐ zài Běijīng gōngzuò ma?

Do you work in Beijing?

雨晨

对，我在北京工作，也在新加坡工作。

Duì, wǒ zài Běijīng gōngzuò, yě zài Xīnjiāpō gōngzuò.

Right, I work in Beijing and also in Singapore.

Grammar: making questions

Chinese has no verb conjugation and no“do/does”for questions. To ask a yes/no question, add吗(ma) to the end of a statement — exactly the same words, plus one particle:

你是学生。	Nǐ shì xuésheng.	You are a student.
你是学生吗?	Nǐ shì xuésheng ma?	Are you a student?
他工作。	Tā gōngzuò.	He works.
他工作吗?	Tā gōngzuò ma?	Does he work?

To bounce a question back (“And you?”), use呢(ne) alone after the topic:你呢?

“Which country person?”:哪国人(nǎ guó rén). To answer, put the country name in place of哪:我是英国人“I am British.”Country names are mostly built from a character or two plus国(guó,“country”):中国Zhōngguó (China),美国Měiguó (USA),英国Yīngguó (UK),法国Fǎguó (France),德国Déguó (Germany),日本Rìběn (Japan),韩国Hánguó (South Korea).

“哪国人”questions are everyday small talk in China, but they can feel blunt to Westerners. Nobody is demanding your passport — it's the same register as“where are you from?”in English. Answer as broadly or specifically as you like; saying just我是中国人is perfectly natural.

Numbers 0–10

A	1
零	líng
一	yī
二	èr
三	sān
四	sì
五	wǔ
六	liù
七	qī
八	bā
九	jiǔ
十	shí

Phone numbers are read digit by digit, using零for 0 and幺(yāo) as a clearer alternative for一in long number strings (airlines, phone numbers).

Characters:中国人



中(zhōng,“middle”): 4 strokes, a box pierced by a vertical line — the country that called itself the Middle Kingdom,中国 Zhōngguó,“Middle Country”. Etymology: the character has depicted a banner or a central strike through a target since oracle-bone times; its“middle”meaning is ancient and genuine.

国(guó,“country”): 8 strokes, a jade玉inside a boundary口— a territory holding treasure. Simplified only: the traditional form

國contains或instead, historically depicting a weapon戈guarding a boundary. Both are true etymologies of their respective forms.

人(rén,“person”): 2 strokes — a walking human seen from the side. One of the oldest characters, and a radical you will see inside hundreds of others.

Exercises

1. Turn these statements into questions with吗:

   1.他是老师。

   2.你学中文。

   3.她在新加坡工作。

2. Match country to Chinese:

   1.美国— a.法国

   2.英国— b.韩国

   3. France — c.美国

   4.韩国— d.英国

3. Write these numbers in Chinese characters:

   1. 3

   2. 5

   3. 10

4. Translate:

   1. Which country are you from?

   2. Are you a student?

   3. I am British, and you?

Communication task

Write a four-line dialogue between yourself and a stranger: greeting, “which country person?”, your answer, and “And you?”. Read it aloud, playing both parts.

UNIT 3

一二三四五

Tone changes, counting things, and your first measure word

In this unit you will learn to:

- apply the two great tone-change rules:一and不
- count from 11 to 100 with the十-composition system
- use the measure word个with the number pattern
- ask“how many?”with几

Pinyin: tone changes (tone sandhi)

A tone written in the dictionary is not always the tone you pronounce. Two characters change predictably depending on the tone of what follows. This is rule-governed, not sloppiness — every native speaker does it.

Rule 1:一(yī,“one”)

一is first tone (yī) when counted or alone:一、二、三… Otherwise it changes: before a fourth-tone syllable it becomes second tone (yí):一个yí ge… wait —个is neutral; see the pattern in real words:一样yíyàng (the same). Before first, second, and third tones it becomes fourth tone (yì):一天yì tiān (one day),一年yì nián (one year),一碗yì wǎn (one bowl).

Rule 2:不(bù,“not”)

不is fourth tone (bù) except before another fourth tone, where it becomes second tone (bú):不好bù hǎo (not good) but不

是bú shì (not be).

Rule 3: third-tone sandhi

When two third tones meet, the first becomes a second tone in pronunciation:你好is written nǐ hǎo but pronounced ní hǎo. The written tone marks stay as dictionary tones; your mouth applies the rule. In a run of three or more third tones, speakers typically leave only the final one as a true dipping tone.



Do not memorise these rules as lists today. Just learn these four phrases perfectly —不是bú shì,不好bù hǎo,你好ní hǎo,一个yí ge — and the rules will feel obvious when we state them again in the revision unit.

Your ear learns faster than your notebook.

Numbers 11–100 and the measure word 个

A	1
十一	shíyī
二十	èrshí
二十一	èrshíyī
五十五	wǔshíwǔ
一百	yìbǎi
几	jǐ
个	ge
多少	duōshao

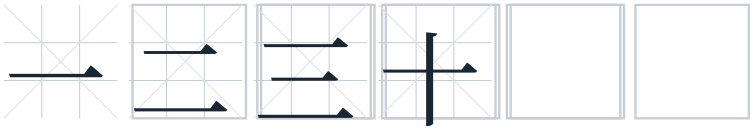
Chinese builds numbers by multiplication and addition, not by new words:十一shíyī = 10+1;二十èrshí = 2×10;五十五 wǔshíwǔ = 5×10+5. You now know every number up to 99 using ten words.

You cannot say a bare number with a noun. Chinese uses measure words (量词) between the number and the thing counted:三个学生sān ge xuésheng“three (units of) students”.个(ge) is the default measure word used when no more specific one applies — learn it now, and the idea; specific measure words (本for books,杯for cups,碗for bowls) arrive in

两个老师	liǎng ge lǎoshī	two teachers
十一个学生	shíyí ge xuésheng	eleven students
几个问题?	jǐ ge wèntí?	how many questions?

Note两(liǎng) — not二— is the word for “two” when counting things:两个not二个.二is used in numbers and mathematics (十二twelve),两for “two of something”.

Characters:一二三and十



一、二、三are pictographic — one, two, three horizontal strokes.十is the ancient form of a tally or a crossing point. These four characters appear in more compounds than almost any others.

Exercises

1. Mark the tone change in each phrase (write the pinyin you would actually pronounce):

   1.一样(the same)

   2.不好(not good)

   3.很好(very good, third-tone pair很hěn +好hǎo)

   4.一年(one year)

2. Write these numbers in characters:

1. 15

2. 40

3. 99

3. Insert个where needed:

1.三___学生

2.五___老师

3.两___问题

Communication task

Count aloud from 1 to 30, recording yourself. Then count people you know:我有两个老师，十个学生朋友… invent freely. Check your一and两usage.

UNIT 4

这是我家人

Family, possession with的, and the verb有

In this unit you will learn to:

- name family members
- express possession with的
- use有(“have”) and its negation没有
- say who someone is with a relative clause pattern:这是我妹妹

Dialogue: photos on a phone

马克

这是谁?

Zhè shì shéi?

Who is this?

雨晨

这是我爸爸。这是我妈妈。

Zhè shì wǒ bàba. Zhè shì wǒ māma.

This is my dad. This is my mum.

马克

你有兄弟姐妹吗?

Nǐ yǒu xiōngdì jiěmèi ma?

Do you have brothers or sisters?

雨晨

我有一个妹妹，没有兄弟。

Wǒ yǒu yí ge mèimei, méiyǒu xiōngdì.

I have one younger sister, no brothers.

马克

你妹妹也有工作吗?

Nǐ mèimei yě yǒu gōngzuò ma?

Does your sister also have a job?

雨晨

有，她是医生。

Yǒu, tā shì yīshēng.

Yes, she's a doctor.

Grammar:有, negation with不vs.没有, and的

有(yǒu) means“to have”or“there is”. Its negation is irregular: you say没有(méiyǒu), not不有.是negates with不(不是 bú shì).

A	1
有	yǒu
没有	méiyǒu
不	bù
的	de
谁	shéi
这	zhè
那	nà
爸爸	bàba
妈妈	māma
哥哥	gēge
姐姐	jiějie
弟弟	dìdi
妹妹	mèimei

The particle的(de) marks possession, like English “'s”: 我的老师wǒ de lǎoshī “my teacher”; 马克的书Mǎkè de shū “Mark's book”. Chinese kinship words distinguish older from younger siblings, because historically the family hierarchy mattered deeply; 哥哥gēge (elder brother) and 弟弟dìdi (younger brother) are different words, not one word plus an adjective.



A note on culture inside the language: Chinese relatives' titles are famously precise — your mother's brother and your father's brother have different names (舅舅vs叔叔), and cousins get kin terms too (表哥, 堂弟). You don't need these yet; I mention it because learners always ask. In everyday urban speech, many people under 40 simplify and use 叔叔/阿姨 for any older adult and 哥/姐 as friendly address among strangers. Language follows how people actually live, not how textbooks categorise.

Grammar: questions with 谁 and 什么

这是谁?	Zhè shì shéi?	Who is this?
这是什么?	Zhè shì shénme?	What is this?
你有几个妹妹?	Nǐ yǒu jǐ ge mèimei?	How many younger sisters do you have?

Characters: 家 and related radicals



家(jiā, “home, family”): 10 strokes — a roof宀over a pig豕. Under the roof of an old farmhouse, the pig was the wealth. This is genuine etymology: the character has shown a pig under a roof since the earliest writing.

女(nǚ): 3 strokes. 子(zǐ): 3 strokes. You met them inside 好 in Unit 1 — characters are built from characters.

Exercises

1. Fill in有or没有:

1.我___一个哥哥。

2.他___工作。

3.你___中文书吗?

2. Rewrite with的:

1.我+老师→ ___

2.马克+手机→ ___

3.我妈妈+朋友→ ___

3. Translate into Chinese:

1. This is my younger sister.

2. Do you have an older brother?

3. I don't have a phone (手机).

Communication task

Describe a photo of your family or of friends in five sentences:这是…，这是…，我有…个…，他没有… . Say it aloud three times, faster each time.

UNIT 5

你在做什么?

Daily routine and the particle 了 with time words

In this unit you will learn to:

- talk about what you do every day
- say at what time things happen
- form basic past statements with 了
- ask what someone did yesterday

Dialogue: a normal Tuesday

马克

你每天几点起床?

Nǐ měitiān jǐ diǎn qǐchuáng?

What time do you get up every day?

雨晨

我七点起床，八点吃早饭。

Wǒ qī diǎn qǐchuáng, bā diǎn chī zǎofàn.

I get up at seven, eat breakfast at eight.

马克

你昨天做什么了?

Nǐ zuótiān zuò shénme le?

What did you do yesterday?

雨晨

我昨天工作了，晚上学英语。

Wǒ zuótiān gōngzuò le, wǎnshang xué Yīngyǔ.

Yesterday I worked, and in the evening I studied English.

马克

今天呢?

Jīntiān ne?

And today?

雨晨

今天我休息！

Jīntiān wǒ xiūxi!

Today I'm resting!

Grammar: time words first, then了

Chinese puts time expressions at the beginning of the sentence, before the verb — not at the end as English often does:我七点起床literally“I at-seven get up”. Learn these order words as a pair with their positions:

我七点起床。	Wǒ qī diǎn qǐchuáng.	I get up at 7:00.
昨天我工作了。	Zuótiān wǒ gōngzuò le.	Yesterday I worked.
今天我休息。	Jīntiān wǒ xiūxi.	Today I rest.

了(le) is not a past tense. It is an aspect marker: it signals that an action is completed or that a situation has changed.

With a time word like昨天(“yesterday”) it usually corresponds to English past tense, but you will meet了in present contexts too (“it's raining now”:下雨了— a new situation). Do not attach了to every past verb the way you would“-ed”in English; we revisit this properly in Stage A2.



了is the most misunderstood character in beginner Chinese. Rule of thumb for now: use it when a finished action matters to the conversation.我昨天工作了answers“what did you do?”;我昨天工作sounds like you're correcting someone's assumption. Small particle, big difference.

Telling the time

A	1
点	diǎn
分钟	fēnzhōng
现在	xiànzài
早上	zǎoshang
中午	zhōngwǔ
下午	xiàwǔ
晚上	wǎnshang
昨天	zuótiān
今天	jīntiān
明天	míngtiān
每天	měitiān
起床	qǐchuáng
吃早饭	chī zǎofàn
睡觉	shuìjiào
休息	xiūxi
工作	gōngzuò
学习	xuéxí

Times are built on the same logic as numbers:七点qī diǎn“7 o'clock”,七点半qī diǎn bàn“7:30”,八点一刻bā diǎn yíkè“8:15”(一刻“a quarter”),差五分九chà wǔ fēn jiǔ“five to nine”. The 24-hour clock is standard for timetables: 十四点shísì diǎn“14:00”.

Characters:时间

时间

时(shí,“time”): 7 strokes — the sun日beside a temple寺, where time was measured. This composition is genuine etymology for the character's original sense of“season”.间(jiān): the sun seen through the crack of a door门— light through a doorway, a space in time. Also genuine:门+日is the real origin of间.

Exercises

1. Put the time word in the right place:

   1.我工作(昨天) → ___

   2.我学中文(每天) → ___

   3.他休息(今天) → ___

2. Add了where the action is completed:

   1.昨天我休息。

   2.我昨天吃早饭。

   3.今天我工作。

3. Write the times in Chinese: 7:00, 7:30, 8:15, five-to-nine.

Communication task

Describe your yesterday in five sentences with times:我七点起床，八点吃早饭… Record it; then describe today and

tomorrow. Note where you used 了 and where not.

UNIT 6

我们吃什么?

Ordering food, real measure words, and prices

In this unit you will learn to:

- order food and drink in a restaurant
- use the common measure words杯、碗、个、瓶
- ask prices and pay
- handle polite请and要

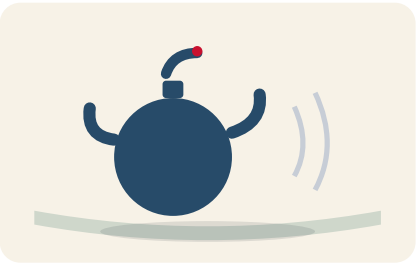
Dialogue: a noodle shop in Xi'an

服务员

欢迎！请坐。想吃点什么?

Huānyíng! Qǐng zuò. Xiǎng chī diǎn shénme?

Welcome! Please sit. What would you like to eat?



马克

我要一碗biángbiáng面。

Wǒ yào yì wǎn biángbiángmiàn.

I'd like a bowl of biangbiang noodles.

雨晨

我要一碗羊肉泡馍，谢谢。

Wǒ yào yì wǎn yángròu pàomó, xièxie.

I'd like a bowl of yangrou paomo, thanks.

服务员

喝什么?

Hē shénme?

To drink?

马克

两瓶冰峰!

Liǎng píng Bīngfēng!

Two bottles of Bingfeng!

服务员

好，一共三十八块。

Hǎo, yígòng sānshíbā kuài.

OK, 38 yuan altogether.

Setting: a small noodle restaurant in Xi'an, Lin's home town. Biángbiáng noodles (biángbiáng面) are a famous wide, belt-like Shaanxi noodle — the character biáng is so complex it cannot be typed in ordinary systems and is usually written by hand.羊肉泡馍is Xi'an's lamb soup with torn flatbread.冰峰is a local orange soda that has been bottled in Xi'an since the 1950s.

Grammar: measure words you will actually use

Each kind of thing has its own measure word. The pattern is always: NUMBER + MEASURE WORD + NOUN.

A	1
碗	wǎn
杯	bēi
瓶	píng
本	běn
件	jiàn
条	tiáo
块	kuài
位	wèi

Prices:块(kuài) is the everyday word for the yuan, China's currency (formally元yuán; in speech everyone says块). 毛(máo) is a tenth of a yuan (formally角jiǎo). “How much?” is多少钱?

Politeness:请qǐng (“please / to invite”) and要yào (“want, would like”).请坐“please sit”;我要…“I'd like…”. To offer something to someone else, use请吃/请喝— the pattern请客qǐngkè“to treat someone (pay for them)” is basic social currency among friends in China; the person who invites usually pays, and friends take turns.



Regional table manners vary hugely. In Xi'an people slurp noodles quite happily; in a fancy Shanghai restaurant that would raise eyebrows. In Taiwan you'll be offered餐巾纸(napkins) and the bill arrives without asking; in mainland restaurants you usually call the waiter over — or scan the table QR code, which has become the normal way to order in the 2020s. Ask, watch, imitate.

Characters:吃and喝



吃(chī,“to eat”): 6 strokes, the mouth口bending over something.喝(hē,“to drink”): 12 strokes — mouth口+曷as the sound component.碗(wǎn): stone/glaze石+宛; ceramic and stone share this component family.

Exercises

1. Choose the measure word (碗/杯/瓶/本/件/条):

1.一___茶

2.两___书

3.三___衬衫

4.一___水

5.四___鱼

2. Translate the order:

1. I'd like a bowl of noodles.

2. Two bottles of water, please.

3. How much is it altogether? (一共)

3. Mark the true statements about the dialogue:

1. Lin ordered biangbiang noodles.

2. Mark ordered two bottles of soda.

3. The meal cost 38 yuan.

Communication task

Role-play both sides of a restaurant scene from your own town's cuisine, in Chinese: greeting, order with measure words, drinks, price, thanks. Record it once as the customer and once as the waiter.

UNIT 7

我喜欢我的工作

Likes, dislikes, and adverbs很and都

In this unit you will learn to:

- say what you like and dislike with喜欢
- intensify with很、太、非常
- use都(“all”) and也(“also”) in the right place
- describe your job and hobbies simply

Dialogue: after class

马克

你喜欢你的工作吗?

Nǐ xǐhuan nǐ de gōngzuò ma?

Do you like your job?

雨晨

我很喜欢。我可以翻译，也可以教课。

Wǒ hěn xǐhuan. Wǒ kěyǐ fānyì, yě kěyǐ jiāo kè.

I like it a lot. I can translate and also teach.

马克

你平时做什么?

Nǐ píngshí zuò shénme?

What do you usually do?

雨晨

我喜欢看书、喝茶。周末我都去爬山。

Wǒ xǐhuan kàn shū, hē chá. Zhōumò wǒ dōu qù páshān.

I like reading and drinking tea. At weekends I always go hiking.

马克

我不喜欢爬山，我喜欢看电影。

Wǒ bù xǐhuan páshān, wǒ xǐhuan kàn diànyǐng.

I don't like hiking; I like watching films.

雨晨

我们都喜欢中文！

Wǒmen dōu xǐhuan Zhōngwén!

We all like Chinese!

Grammar: adverbs go before the verb

English says“I also like tea”; Chinese says我也喜欢茶—也(“also”) comes before the verb. All adverbs of this kind (也also,都all,很very,不not) occupy the slot immediately before the verb, never after it. One verb, one adverb slot, in a fixed order: subject + time +也/都+不/很+ verb.

我也喝茶。	Wǒ yě hē chá.	I also drink tea.
我们都喝茶。	Wǒmen dōu hē chá.	We all drink tea.
我不喝茶。	Wǒ bù hē chá.	I don't drink tea.
我很喜欢茶。	Wǒ hěn xǐhuan chá.	I like tea very much.

喜欢(xǐhuan) takes a noun or a verb phrase directly:我喜欢看书“I like reading (books)”. Negation is不喜欢. To ask“do you like…?”, add吗.

A trap:很in“我很喜欢”is real“very”. But in the pattern他很好(“he is well/fine”),很is often just a rhythm filler that

softens a bare adjective — it does not mean “very”. 你好 does not contain 很 at all. This filler usage is extremely common; notice it and don't over-translate it.

Vocabulary: work and free time

A	1
喜欢	xǐhuan
不喜欢	bù xǐhuan
很	hěn
非常	fēicháng
太…了	tài…le
也	yě
都	dōu
可以	kěyǐ
翻译	fānyì
看书	kàn shū
喝茶	hē chá
爬山	páshān
电影	diànyǐng
周末	zhōumò
平时	píngshí



都 can mean “both” with two people and “all” with many — Chinese doesn't distinguish them. 我们都喜欢中文 works for two of us or a whole classroom.

Characters: 喜欢的组成



喜(xǐ): 12 strokes — the top 吉(“auspicious”) over a mouth and hands; a traditional character for joy. 欢(huān): simplified from 歡, “to rejoice”; 又 here is a simplification of a phonetic component. Mnemonic: joy 吉 + a cheerful mouth — a happy face written in strokes.

Exercises

1. Put也/都/不/很in the correct slot:

   1.我___喜欢咖啡。

   2.我们___学中文。

   3.他___喝茶。

   4.她___喜欢爬山。

2. Answer with full sentences:你喜欢你的工作吗？你喜欢周末做什么？

3. Translate:

   1. We both like tea.

   2. I don't like films very much.

   3. She can also translate.

Communication task

Prepare a 60-second spoken“my week”: what you do, what you like, one thing you dislike, one thing you love. Use也,都,很,非常at least once each. Record and self-score against the model in the answer key.

UNIT 8

现在几点?

Dates, days of the week, and typing Chinese

In this unit you will learn to:

- say the year, month, day and weekday
- read and write a date in Chinese order
- understand how characters are typed with pinyin input
- recognise the most common radicals by shape

Dialogue: making a plan

马克

今天是几月几号?

Jīntiān shì jǐ yuè jǐ hào?

What's the date today?

雨晨

十月二十三号，星期四。

Shí yuè èrshísān hào, xīngqīsì.

October 23rd, Thursday.

马克

下星期六你有空吗?

Xià xīngqīliù nǐ yǒu kòng ma?

Are you free next Saturday?

雨晨

有空！我们去看电影?

Yǒu kòng! Wǒmen qù kàn diànyǐng?

Free! Shall we go see a film?

马克

好，下午两点?

Hǎo, xiàwǔ liǎng diǎn?

Great, 2 pm?

雨晨

好，我请你喝咖啡。

Hǎo, wǒ qǐng nǐ hē kāfēi.

Great — coffee is on me.

Dates: biggest unit first

Chinese writes dates from large to small: year, month, day, weekday.二〇二五年十月二十三号，星期四. The same order governs addresses (country, city, street, number) and names (family name first). When you see a Chinese date written numerically — 2025.10.23 — you now know how to read it out.

A	1
年	nián
月	yuè
号	hào
日	rì
星期一	xīngqīyī
星期二	xīngqīèr
星期三	xīngqīsān
星期四	xīngqīsì
星期五	xīngqīwǔ
星期六	xīngqīliù

A	1
星期天	xīngqītiān
有空	yǒu kòng
请	qǐng

In Taiwan the weekday is週一/禮拜一etc.; in mainland speech礼拜四is a common informal variant of星期四. Same language, different local habits.

Typing Chinese: pinyin input

You will type Chinese far more often than you will write it by hand. On phones and computers, the standard method is pinyin input (拼音输入法): you type the pinyin of a word without tone marks — “nihao” — and a candidate menu offers 你好among the possible matches. Practical facts you need:

- Type whole words, not single characters: nihao gives你好directly; typing ni and hao separately is slower.
- You rarely need tone marks; the input system ranks candidates by frequency.
- You do need to recognise characters: the menu gives you choices, and homophones are everywhere (yī has dozens of matches).
- For ü, type v: nü (woman) is typed nv.
- Punctuation: the Chinese full stop is。 typed from the punctuation key or a dedicated menu; a good input method switches automatically between Chinese and Latin punctuation.
- Character recognition (手写) input — drawing on the screen — is built into phones and is the standard way people look up the biáng of biángbiáng面.



Turn on a Chinese keyboard today and type the sentences you have learned. Learners who type from the start remember characters dramatically better — typing is a recognition workout, and recognition is 90% of reading.

Radicals: the alphabet of characters

Every character contains one component that hints at its meaning field, called the radical (部首). Dictionaries are organised by radical. You already know several as characters in their own right:

A	1
亻	rén
口	kǒu
女	nǚ
宀	mián
日	rì
氵	shuǐ
木	mù
饣	shí

Exercises

1. Write in Chinese: October 23, Thursday; next Saturday; 2 pm.
2. Match radical to field:氵/木/口/女— water, wood, mouth, woman.
3. Say the date of your next birthday in Chinese, out loud, then type it.

Communication task

Write a short message inviting a friend to do something next week: propose the day, the time, the activity, and offer to treat them. Type it with a Chinese keyboard, then read it aloud and record it.

Revision

复习：巩固与自测

Consolidate Stage A1 before you climb higher

How to use this revision unit

Work through it slowly, with your notes closed. For each section, say your answer aloud before checking. Anything that feels shaky gets a second pass tonight, and again in three days — spaced repetition beats cramming, and it beats rereading.

Pronunciation check

Read these aloud, recording yourself. Then paste the characters into a Chinese TTS voice and compare. Each line hides a classic trap.

妈麻马骂吗

five tones on ma: level, rise, dip, fall, neutral

不是bú shì

不becomes second tone before a fourth tone

一个yí ge

一becomes second tone before neutral个

一年yì nián

一becomes fourth tone before non-fourth tones

很好hěn hǎo

two third tones in a row: first becomes rising

西安Xī'ān

apostrophe separates syllables — Xī + ān, not Xīān

女nǚ /绿lǜ

ü after n and l is written with the umlaut

去qù /需xū

after j, q, x, y the ü loses its dots in writing: ju, qu, xu, yu

Grammar you must own before A2

- Statement: subject + time +也/都+不/很+ verb + object. Nothing after the verb except the object.
- 是links nouns; it does not link adjectives (他很高, never NOT他是很高).
- 有negates with没有; everything else with不.
- Yes/no questions: add吗. Return questions: topic +呢?
- Numbers + measure word + noun, always:三个学生, never NOT三学生.两for“two of”,二in numbers.
- Possession and description: X的Y (my teacher, the red one).
- 了marks completion or change, not“the past”as such.
- Time words come first:我七点起床, not NOT我起床七点.

Character check

Cover the pinyin and English columns in your notes and read these aloud. Any character you cannot name gets rewritten

five times, tonight.

你 好 中 国 人 家 大 小 一 二

三 十 日 月 水 火 口 女 子 吃



Notice what you did: 120 characters, four tones, measure words, and you can already order noodles in Xi'an. That is not nothing. A2 is where this skeleton gets flesh — you'll be telling stories about your weekend by the end of it.

Assessment

Stage A1 Assessment

Do it closed-book, in one sitting, then mark it

Part 1 · Listening-style comprehension (script)

No audio is supplied with this book. Read the script below aloud once at natural speed, then answer from memory before re-reading. Better: paste the script into a Chinese TTS voice and listen twice without looking, then answer.

服务员

你好！几位?

Nǐ hǎo! Jǐ wèi?

Hello! How many people?

雨晨

两位。我们要两碗面，一杯茶。

Liǎng wèi. Wǒmen yào liǎng wǎn miàn, yì bēi chá.

Two. We'd like two bowls of noodles and one tea.

服务员

一共二十六块。

Yígòng èrshíliù kuài.

26 yuan altogether.

雨晨

谢谢！明天你有空吗?

Xièxie! Míngtiān nǐ yǒu kòng ma?

Thanks! Are you free tomorrow?

马克

明天是星期天，我有空。

Míngtiān shì xīngqītiān, wǒ yǒu kòng.

Tomorrow is Sunday, I'm free.

1. Answer in English:

1. How many people are eating?

2. What do they order?

3. How much does it cost?

4. What day is tomorrow?

Part 2 · Reading

阅读：马克的星期六。马克七点起床，八点吃早饭。上午他学中文，下午他和林雨晨去看电影。晚上他们喝茶。马克很喜欢星期六。

2. True or false:

1. Mark gets up at 8:00.

2. He studies Chinese in the morning.

3. He sees a film with Lin Yǔchén.

4. He works in the evening.

Part 3 · Grammar

3. Correct the errors:

1.我起床七点。

2.他是很高。

3.我不有中文书。

4.三学生来。

5.昨天我看书吗？(as a statement: Yesterday I read a book.)

4. Translate into Chinese:

1. Are you free on Saturday?

2. I have two older sisters and one younger brother.

3. She is not Chinese; she is British.

4. What time do you eat dinner? (晚饭)

Part 4 · Writing and speaking (self-assessed)

Write 8–10 sentences introducing yourself: name, nationality, family, job or studies, daily routine, likes and dislikes. Then read it aloud twice and record it. Mark with the criteria in the answer key; the annotated model response shows what A1-quality work looks like.

Pass guide: Parts 1–3 at 80% or better, and a writing sample that would be understood by a patient native speaker

without clarification. Below that, redo the weak units — not the whole stage.

STAGE A2

生活

Everyday Life

— talk about the past in detail: experiences, trips, and changes

— describe people, places, and weather; make comparisons

— shop, bargain, and handle directions

— understand aspect markers了/过/着and the把construction's first steps

— recognise around 300 more characters and read short adapted texts

Pinyin starts thinning here: dialogues keep full pinyin, but readings give pinyin only for new words.

UNIT 1

我去年去了云南

Experiences with过and travel stories

In this unit you will learn to:

- narrate a past trip in connected sentences
- use过for experiences (“have ever done”)
- distinguish completed了from experienced过
- handle dates and durations

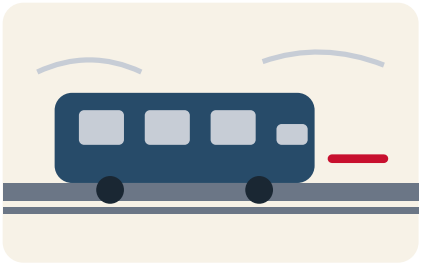
Dialogue: the trip to Yunnan

马克

你去过云南吗?

Nǐ qùguo Yúnnán ma?

Have you ever been to Yunnan?



雨晨

去过。我去年十月去的，玩儿了两个星期。

Qùguo. Wǒ qùnián shí yuè qù de, wánr le liǎng ge xīngqī.

Yes. I went last October and travelled for two weeks.

马克

我还没去过。你看了什么?

Wǒ hái méi qùguo. Nǐ kàn le shénme?

I haven't been yet. What did you see?

雨晨

我去了大理和丽江，看了洱海，吃了很多米线。

Wǒ qùle Dàlǐ hé Lìjiāng, kànle Ěrhǎi, chīle hěn duō mǐxiàn.

I went to Dali and Lijiang, saw Lake Erhai, and ate lots of rice noodles.

马克

坐火车还是坐飞机?

Zuò huǒchē háishì zuò fēijī?

By train or by plane?

雨晨

坐高铁去，回来坐飞机。

Zuò gāotiě qù, huílai zuò fēijī.

High-speed rail there, plane back.

Grammar:过— the experience marker

Place过(guo) after the verb to say you have done something at least once in your life:我去过云南“I have been to

Yunnan (at some point)”. It is not about when — it is about the fact that the experience exists in your history.

我去过云南。	Wǒ qùguo Yúnnán.	I have been to Yunnan.
我没去过云南。	Wǒ méi qùguo Yúnnán.	I have never been to Yunnan.
你吃过烤鸭吗?	Nǐ chīguo kǎoyā ma?	Have you ever eaten roast duck?

Compare the two past markers side by side:

A	2
我去了云南。	Wǒ qùle Yúnnán.
我去过云南。	Wǒ qùguo Yúnnán.
我看了那个电影。	Wǒ kànle nàge diànyǐng.
我看过那个电影。	Wǒ kànguo nàge diànyǐng.

Duration: time words like两个星期follow the verb with玩了/住了/学了:我玩儿了两个星期. A useful pattern for“how

long”: verb + 了 + duration + (了).



过and了are not rivals — they answer different questions. “Did you finish watching it?” →看了. “Have you ever seen it?” →看过. When in doubt, ask yourself: completed event, or life experience?

Culture inside the trip: Dali, Lijiang, and the Erhai lake

Dali (大理) is the historic seat of the Bai people and was the capital of the Kingdom of Dali, which lasted from 937 until its conquest by the Mongols in 1253. Lijiang (丽江), the old town of the Naxi people, is a UNESCO World Heritage site (listed 1997) famous for its canal-crossed streets and the Naxi's Dongba script — the only living pictographic writing system still in ceremonial use. Yunnan cuisine is famous for米线(rice noodles); the best-known version,过桥米线 “crossing-the-bridge noodles”, comes with a scalding broth into which you slip raw ingredients yourself at the table.

Vocabulary: travel

A	2
去	qù
过	guo
还没	hái méi
去年	qùnián
玩儿	wánr
两个星期	liǎng ge xīngqī
火车	huǒchē
高铁	gāotiě
飞机	fēijī
还是	háishì
很多	hěn duō
米线	mǐxiàn

Characters

去过车

去(qù): 5 strokes.过(guo): 6 strokes — the walking radical辶_plus a phonetic.车(chē): 4 strokes, a cart seen from above with its axle — simplified from the more pictorial車. Etymology:車really did depict a chariot;车is its simplified outline.

Exercises

1. Choose了or过:

   1.我昨天___北京。

   2.你___吃北京烤鸭吗？(have you ever…)

   3.我们看___那个电影，很好看。(we watched it and…)

   4.我从来没___去上海。(never have been)

2. Answer in Chinese:你去过哪些地方？你吃了什么？

3. Translate:

   1. Have you ever taken a high-speed train?

   2. I went to Dali last October and stayed two weeks.

   3. I've never eaten crossing-the-bridge noodles.

Communication task

Record a 90-second story of a real trip: where, when, how long, how you travelled, two things you did, one thing you ate.

Use both 了 and 过 at least twice each.

UNIT 2

比一比

Comparisons and describing people

In this unit you will learn to:

- compare two things with比
- say how big a difference is
- describe people's appearance and personality
- use越来越for ongoing change

Dialogue: two cities

马克

北京和西安，哪个城市比较大?

Běijīng hé Xī'ān, nǎge chéngshì bǐjiào dà?

Beijing and Xi'an — which city is bigger?

雨晨

北京比西安大得多。

Běijīng bǐ Xī'ān dà de duō.

Beijing is much bigger than Xi'an.

马克

人也多吧?

Rén yě duō ba?

More people too, right?

雨晨

对，人多得多，但是西安的历史比北京长。

Duì, rén duō de duō, dànshì Xī'ān de lìshǐ bǐ Běijīng cháng.

Right, many more people, but Xi'an's history is longer than Beijing's.

马克

北京的变化越来越快。

Běijīng de biànhuà yuèláiyuè kuài.

Beijing changes faster and faster.

雨晨

是啊，地铁也越来越多。

Shì a, dìtiě yě yuèláiyuè duō.

Yes, and there are more and more metro lines.

Grammar:比and degrees of difference

The comparison pattern is: A +比+ B + adjective. Note what is missing: no“is”, no“-er”, no“than”after the adjective. The adjective comes last and stays bare.

北京比西安大。	Běijīng bǐ Xī'ān dà.	Beijing is bigger than Xi'an.
地铁比汽车快。	Dìtiě bǐ qìchē kuài.	The metro is faster than the car.
今天比昨天冷。	Jīntiān bǐ zuótiān lěng.	Today is colder than yesterday.

To state the size of the gap:比…大得多(“bigger by a lot”),比…大一点儿(“a bit bigger”),比…大两倍(“bigger by two times”). To say two things are equal: A跟B一样(adjective):他跟我一样高“he's as tall as me”.

Ongoing change:越来越+ adjective —“more and more”:越来越贵“more and more expensive”. For“the more X, the more Y”, a different pattern (越…越…) exists; you will meet it in Stage B1.

Describing people

A	2
高	gāo
矮	ǎi
胖	pàng
瘦	shòu
漂亮	piàoliang
帅	shuài
聪明	cōngming
热情	rèqíng
安静	ānjìng
有意思	yǒu yìsi
变化	biànhuà
地铁	dìtiě



Chinese small talk comments on appearance more directly than English small talk:你胖了“you've gained weight”can be a friendly observation, not an insult. You don't have to say it — but don't be wounded when someone says it to you after a festival week.你瘦了“you've lost weight”is nearly always meant as praise.

Characters



Exercises

1. Rewrite with比:

   1. Xi'an is older than Beijing. (历史)

   2. The plane is faster than the train.

   3. Today is a bit colder than yesterday.

2. Complete with越来越:

   1.天气___冷了。

   2.中文___有意思了。

   3.他___高了。

3. Describe two friends: one taller, one quieter, one as clever as you. Four sentences, all with comparison patterns.

Communication task

Compare your city with a Chinese city you know of, in six spoken sentences: size, people, food, transport, history, pace of change. Use比three times and越来越once.

UNIT 3

天气怎么样?

Weather, seasons, and making arrangements

In this unit you will learn to:

- describe weather and seasons
- use会for predictions and能/可以for ability
- make and change arrangements
- read a simple weather forecast

Dialogue: planning a picnic

雨晨

明天天气怎么样?

Míngtiān tiānqì zěnmeyàng?

What's the weather like tomorrow?

马克

天气预报说明天会下雨。

Tiānqì yùbào shuō míngtiān huì xià yǔ.

The forecast says it will rain tomorrow.

雨晨

那野餐不行了。我们改去博物馆吧?

Nà yěcān bùxíng le. Wǒmen gǎi qù bówùguǎn ba?

Then no picnic. Shall we go to the museum instead?

马克

好。博物馆里有空调！

Hǎo. Bówùguǎn li yǒu kōngtiáo!

Good. The museum has air conditioning!

雨晨

哈哈，对。周末会降温，你多穿点衣服。

Hāhā, duì. Zhōumò huì jiàngwēn, nǐ duō chuān diǎn yīfu.

Ha, true. It'll get colder at the weekend — wear more clothes.

马克

知道了，妈妈一样！

Zhīdào le, māma yíyàng!

Got it — you're just like my mum!

Grammar:会/能/可以— three“can”s

A	2
会	huì
能	néng
可以	kěyǐ

会for weather and forecasts is the“will”of prediction:会下雨“it will rain”,不会太冷“it won't be too cold”.会also means a learned skill:我会说中文“I can speak Chinese”(because I learned it) — never我能说中文for that sense.

Weather and seasons

A	2
天气	tiānqì
下雨	xià yǔ
下雪	xià xuě
晴	qíng
阴	yīn

A	2
刮风	guāfēng
热	rè
冷	lěng
凉快	liángkuai
暖和	nuǎnhuo
潮湿	cháoshī
干燥	gānzào
春天	chūntiān
夏天	xiàtiān
秋天	qiūtiān
冬天	dōngtiān
温度	wēndù
降温	jiàngwēn

China's climates span tropical Hainan to Siberian Harbin, so“Chinese weather”does not exist as one thing. Beijing has four sharp seasons and dry winters (rain concentrates in July–August); Guangzhou is humid with a long summer and almost no winter; Kunming is called春城“the Spring City”for its mild year-round climate; Harbin hosts a famous ice festival each January precisely because its winters are reliably below −15°C. Local festivals follow local climates, not a national template.

Grammar: suggestion with吧

Adding吧(ba) to a statement softens it into a suggestion:我们去博物馆吧“let's go to the museum (shall we?)”. It also marks a conclusion you've just reached:那不行了吧“then that won't work, I suppose”.

Characters



雨(yǔ): 8 strokes — raindrops falling from a sky line, a genuine pictograph.天(tiān): 4 strokes —“one一+ the big one大”, the

great one overhead. 气(qì): 4 strokes — clouds of vapour, simplified from氣which showed steam rising from rice cooking.

Exercises

1. Choose会/能/可以:

   1.我___说中文。

   2.这里___拍照吗？(permission)

   3.明天___下雨。

   4.他不___吃辣。

2. Translate:

   1. What's the weather like today?

   2. It will snow tomorrow.

   3. Let's go to the museum instead. (吧)

3. Describe your local weather in four seasons, one sentence each.

Communication task

Record a weather-and-plan conversation with yourself in both roles: forecast, reaction, alternative plan, one piece of friendly advice. Use会twice and吧once.

UNIT 4

请给我三斤苹果

Shopping, bargaining, and the polite麻烦您

In this unit you will learn to:

- shop for food and ask prices
- use这么/那么for degree
- ask for help politely
- understand weights斤and markets

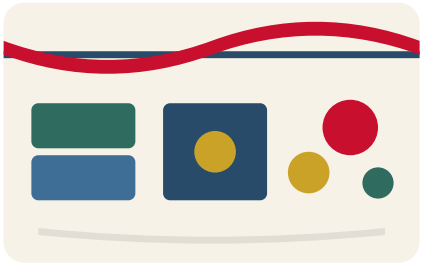
Dialogue: the wet market

马克

师傅，苹果怎么卖?

Shīfu, píngguǒ zěnme mài?

Boss, how are the apples sold?



摊主

八块一斤，很甜。

Bā kuài yì jīn, hěn tián.

Eight yuan a jin, very sweet.

马克

这么贵？便宜一点儿吧?

Zhème guì? Piányi yìdiǎnr ba?

So expensive? A bit cheaper?

摊主

六块，不能再少了。

Liù kuài, bù néng zài shǎo le.

Six yuan — can't go lower.

马克

好，麻烦您给我三斤。

Hǎo, máfan nín gěi wǒ sān jīn.

OK, three jin please, sorry to trouble you.

摊主

一共十八块，扫码还是现金?

Yígòng shíbā kuài, sǎomǎ háishì xiànjīn?

18 yuan total — scan or cash?

Culture inside the dialogue: the wet market

Traditional open-air food markets (菜市场，“vegetable markets”) remain the daily shopping venue for many Chinese households; supermarket chains have grown since the 1990s and app-based grocery delivery boomed in the late 2010s, but fresh markets survive because shoppers value picking each tomato.斤(jīn) is the traditional weight unit, standardised in modern China to exactly 500 grams; markets quote prices per jin. Mobile payment (扫码，“scanning the code”) overtook cash in mainland cities during the late 2010s; in Taiwan and Hong Kong cash and stored-value cards remain common. Addressing a vendor as师傅(“master”, a respectful term for any skilled worker) or老板(“boss”) is normal politeness.

Grammar:这么/那么and bargaining language

这么(zhème,“so”, near) and那么(nàme,“so”, far or already-known) intensify an adjective:这么贵！ “so expensive!

”. The classic bargaining sequence you just read is worth memorising as a chunk:

怎么卖?	zěnme mài?	how much (per unit)?
便宜一点儿吧。	piányi yìdiǎnr ba?	a little cheaper, come on.
不能再少了。	bù néng zài shǎo le.	can't go any lower.
成交。	chéngjiāo.	deal.

Politeness:麻烦您(“sorry to trouble you”) is a formal, warm way to make a request;您(nín) is the polite “you”, used with strangers, elders, and customers.请给我…“please give me…”handles most transactions.

Vocabulary: shopping

A	2
怎么卖	zěnme mài
斤	jīn
贵	guì
便宜	piányi
甜	tián
麻烦您	máfan nín
您	nín
扫码	sǎomǎ
现金	xiànjīn
菜市场	càishìchǎng
一点儿	yìdiǎnr



Bargaining is normal in tourist markets and largely absent in supermarkets or chain stores. The line between them is easy to read: prices printed on a tag are firm; prices shouted from a stall are a conversation.

Characters



买(mǎi, buy) and卖(mài, sell) are a famous pair: the same frame with and without the “out” stroke十on top — buying brings things in under the net, selling sends them out. Etymology: the网-like component is genuine; the mnemonic contrast is worth

keeping 菜(cài): the grass radical 艹over 采— gathering plants, the original sense of “vegetable”.

Exercises

1. Bargaining role-play prompts — reply to each:

   1.十块一斤。(too expensive)

   2.便宜一点儿吧？(refuse politely)

   3.怎么卖？(you are the vendor, tomatoes, 5 yuan/jin)

2. Insert这么/那么/一点儿:

   1.今天___热！

   2.他昨天___忙。

   3.请给我两___苹果。

3. Translate:

   1. How much is this per jin?

   2. Sorry to trouble you, give me half a jin of tea. (半jìn)

   3. Cash, please.

Communication task

Record a market scene playing both buyer and seller: three rounds of bargaining ending in a deal, with polite forms throughout. Then do it again 20% faster.

UNIT 5

中秋节快到了

Festivals, time before/after, and越来越events

In this unit you will learn to:

- talk about upcoming festivals and preparations
- use快…了and就要…了for “soon”
- use以前/以后/的时候for time relations
- write a short festival greeting message

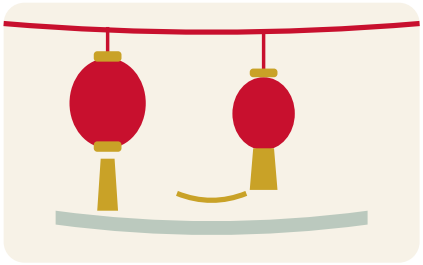
Dialogue: preparing for Mid-Autumn

马克

中秋节快到了，你回家吗?

Zhōngqiūjié kuài dào le, nǐ huí jiā ma?

Mid-Autumn Festival is almost here — are you going home?



雨晨

要回去。我星期五晚上就出发。

Yào huíqù. Wǒ xīngqīwǔ wǎnshang jiù chūfā.

Yes. I'm setting off Friday evening.

马克

你买月饼了吗?

Nǐ mǎi yuèbǐng le ma?

Have you bought mooncakes?

雨晨

买了两盒：一盒豆沙的，一盒蛋黄的。

Mǎile liǎng hé: yì hé dòushā de, yì hé dànhuáng de.

Two boxes: red-bean ones and egg-yolk ones.

马克

中秋节的时候你们做什么？

Zhōngqiūjié de shíhou nǐmen zuò shénme?

What do you do at Mid-Autumn?

雨晨

晚上一起吃饭，然后看月亮、吃月饼。

Wǎnshang yìqǐ chīfàn, ránhòu kàn yuèliang, chī yuèbǐng.

We eat dinner together, then watch the moon and eat mooncakes.

Culture inside the festival: Mid-Autumn and the moon

Mid-Autumn Festival (中秋节) falls on the 15th day of the 8th lunar month, when the moon is full — in the modern Gregorian calendar that lands somewhere between early September and early October. It has been celebrated at least since the Tang dynasty (618–907) and became an official public holiday in mainland China in 2008. The full moon stands for family reunion: the word圆(“round”) echoes团圆(“reunion”). Mooncakes (月饼) are dense pastries stamped with patterns; fillings vary by region — Cantonese-style with egg yolk, Suzhou-style flaky and savoury, Beijing-style with a harder crust. The folk tale most told at Mid-Autumn is of嫦娥(Cháng'é), who drank an elixir and rose to the moon, leaving her husband后羿(Hòuyì) on earth; he laid out her favourite fruits under the moon, and families have laid out offerings under the full moon ever since, in the story's telling. Similar festivals with shared roots are celebrated in Vietnam (Tết Trung Thu) and across East and Southeast Asia.

Grammar:快…了/就要…了/的时候/以后

“About to happen”:快+ verb/phrase +了(Mid-Autumn is almost here:中秋节快到了), or the stronger就要…了(中秋节就要到了).“Before/after/when”: a time phrase +以前(before) /以后(after) /的时候(at the time of) — these come before the clause they modify, and the phrase can be an event, not just a clock time:

吃饭以后我们看月亮。	Chīfàn yǐhòu wǒmen kàn yuèliang.	After eating we watch the moon.
中秋节的时候我回家。	Zhōngqiūjié de shíhou wǒ huí jiā.	At Mid-Autumn I go home.
睡觉以前我要喝茶。	Shuìjiào yǐqián wǒ yào hē chá.	Before sleeping I'll drink tea.



Festival greetings are a genre of their own. The standard Mid-Autumn wish is中秋快乐！“Happy Mid-Autumn!” — and if you're writing to family,阖家团圆“may the whole family be reunited” is the classic phrase. For Spring Festival you will need a different set entirely; we do those in Unit 8.

Vocabulary: festivals and preparations

A	2
中秋节	Zhōngqiūjié
月饼	yuèbǐng
月亮	yuèliang
回家	huí jiā
出发	chūfā
盒	hé
豆沙	dòushā
蛋黄	dànhuáng
以前	yǐqián
以后	yǐhòu
的时候	de shíhou
然后	ránhòu
团圆	tuányuán

Characters



月(yuè): 4 strokes — a crescent moon, one of the oldest pictographs; it also means “month”, because the lunar month is one moon.中you know;节(jié): the bamboo radical竹above 卩— originally a joint of bamboo, hence “node, festival”(a festival is a joint in the year's flow).

Exercises

1. Complete with快…了/的时候/以后:

   1.春节___到了。

   2.吃饭___，我们吃月饼。

   3.我小___学英语。(when I was small)

2. Translate:

   1. Mid-Autumn is almost here.

   2. After dinner we watch the moon.

   3. I bought two boxes of mooncakes: one red-bean, one egg-yolk.

3. Write a 3-sentence greeting message to a friend for Mid-Autumn, including one wish.

Communication task

Record yourself describing how your family celebrates a favourite festival: when, preparations, food, what you do

together, one thing you love about it. Use的时候,以前/以后, and快…了.

UNIT 6

你在哪儿工作?

Directions, places, and the“在+ place”pattern

In this unit you will learn to:

- ask for and give directions
- describe where things are with在…上/里/旁边/对面
- say where you work and live with在
- read a simple map label

Dialogue: finding the teahouse

马克

请问，茶馆在哪儿?

Qǐngwèn, cháguǎn zài nǎr?

Excuse me, where is the teahouse?

路人

就在银行旁边，超市对面。

Jiù zài yínháng pángbiān, chāoshì duìmiàn.

Right next to the bank, across from the supermarket.

马克

怎么走?

Zěnme zǒu?

How do I walk there?

路人

往前走，红绿灯右转就到了。

Wǎng qián zǒu, hónglǜdēng yòu zhuǎn jiù dào le.

Go straight ahead, turn right at the lights and you're there.

马克

远吗?

Yuǎn ma?

Is it far?

路人

不远，五分钟。

Bù yuǎn, wǔ fēnzhōng.

Not far — five minutes.

Grammar: location with在+ place + position word

Chinese says where something is with在+ place + position:在桌子上“on the table”,在银行旁边“next to the bank”,

在学校对面“across from the school”. The position word comes after the place — the reverse of English word order.

Learn these position words as a set:

A	2
上	shàng
下	xià
里	lǐ
旁边	pángbiān
对面	duìmiàn
前面	qiánmiàn
后面	hòumiàn
左/右	zuǒ/yòu
附近	fùjìn

Where an activity happens uses在+ place before the verb:我在北京工作“I work in Beijing”,我们在茶馆喝茶“we drink tea in the teahouse”. Direction verbs (走go,转turn) take往+ direction:往前走“go forward”,往右转“turn right”. 就(jiù) is doing quiet work in this dialogue:就在…“it's right at…”,就到了“you'll be right there”— it signals “immediately/right nearby”. Its opposite,才, implies lateness or“only then”— you will meet it again in B1.

Vocabulary: places and directions

A	2
请问	qǐngwèn
茶馆	cháguǎn
银行	yínháng
超市	chāoshì
红绿灯	hónglǜdēng
右转	yòu zhuǎn
左转	zuǒ zhuǎn
往前走	wǎng qián zǒu
远	yuǎn
分钟	fēnzhōng
路	lù
怎么走	zěnme zǒu



In most mainland cities nobody says请问to a stranger without smiling — but the word genuinely softens an interruption, especially when you're about to launch a foreign-accented question. Pair it with不好意思(“sorry to bother you”) and you will be forgiven almost anything.

Characters



Exercises

1. Describe positions using在…position:

   1. the cat / the table / under

   2. the bank / the supermarket / next to

   3. my home / the school / across from

2. Give directions from your home to the nearest shop, in three Chinese sentences with往…走/转.

3. Translate:

   1. Excuse me, where is the bank?

   2. It's right next to the supermarket, across from the teahouse.

   3. Not far — ten minutes on foot.

Communication task

Record an directions exchange playing both a lost visitor and a local: ask, receive a three-step route, confirm distance.

Then draw a tiny map of your own street and describe it aloud in Chinese.

UNIT 7

我身体不舒服

Health, the subjectless“feeling”sentences, and advice

In this unit you will learn to:

- describe symptoms simply
- give advice with应该and多verb
- understand越来越-style change in a body context
- handle a pharmacy interaction

Dialogue: at the pharmacy

马克

我这两天头疼，还有点儿咳嗽。

Wǒ zhè liǎng tiān tóuténg, hái yǒudiǎnr késou.

I've had a headache these two days, and a bit of a cough.

药剂师

发烧吗?

Fāshāo ma?

Do you have a fever?

马克

有一点儿，三十七度八。

Yǒu yìdiǎnr, sānshíqī dù bā.

A little — 37.8.

药剂师

你多喝水，多休息，别吃辣的。

Nǐ duō hē shuǐ, duō xiūxi, bié chī là de.

Drink more water, rest more, don't eat spicy food.

马克

要吃药吗?

Yào chī yào ma?

Should I take medicine?

药剂师

先吃这个药，多喝热水。两天以后还发烧，就去医院。

Xiān chī zhège yào, duō hē rè shuǐ. Liǎng tiān yǐhòu hái fāshāo, jiù qù yīyuàn.

Take this medicine first, drink plenty of hot water. If you still have a fever after two days, go to a hospital.

Grammar:多/别+ verb and先…再…

Advice patterns are wonderfully compact:多+ verb (“more do it”:多喝水“drink more water”),少+ verb (“less do it”:少熬夜“stay up late less”),别+ verb (“don't”:别吃辣的“don't eat spicy things”),先…再… (“first… then…”): 先吃药，再去医院“take the medicine first, then go to hospital.”Note how辣的—“spicy ones”—turns an adjective into a noun with的; you will meet this again and again.

Body symptoms use the part + verb compound:头疼(head + ache)“headache”,肚子疼“stomachache”,咳嗽“cough”,发烧“have a fever”. To ask“where does it hurt?”:哪儿疼？To state degree:有一点儿(“a bit”) softens,很(“very”) strengthens.

Culture inside the pharmacy: hot water and hospitals

多喝热水—“drink more hot water”— is a standing joke and a genuine folk comfort in mainland China, where thermoses of hot (not iced) water are a default in offices and homes; the habit follows ideas about balance in traditional medicine.

Pharmacies (药店) dispense over-the-counter advice freely and are often the first stop before a hospital visit. Chinese hospitals work differently from Western clinics: patients register, queue for a doctor, pay per service, and large hospitals are busy from dawn — for minor illness, a community clinic (社区医院) is the faster choice. In Taiwan and Hong Kong the systems differ again, with mixed public and private provision. None of this is medical advice — when actually ill abroad, seek local professional care.

Vocabulary: health

A	2
头疼	tóuténg
肚子疼	dùzi téng
咳嗽	késou
发烧	fāshāo
感冒	gǎnmào
药	yào
药店	yàodiàn
医院	yīyuàn
多喝水	duō hē shuǐ
休息	xiūxi
应该	yīnggāi
先…再…	xiān…zài…
别	bié

Characters



头(tóu): 5 strokes — a head with its two big points, ancient and pictorial.药(yào): the grass radical艹(herbal medicine began with plants) over约.医(yī): an arrow矢in a box with a small blade — treating wounds; the traditional form醫adds酉(wine/alcohol) beneath, the disinfectant of the ancient world. Both forms carry the same etymology.

Exercises

1. Give advice with多/少/别:

   1. (friend has a cold) water
   2. (friend stays up late) sleep
   3. (friend eats too much candy) candy

2. Translate:

   1. I have a headache and a bit of a fever.
   2. Drink more hot water and rest more.
   3. Take the medicine first, then go to the hospital.

3. Role-play: describe two symptoms to a pharmacist and follow their advice.

Communication task

Record a pharmacy scene in both roles: symptoms, degree, advice with先…再…, one follow-up question. Use有一点儿

and 刚at least once each.

UNIT 8

新年快乐!

Spring Festival, wishes, and the last A2 structures

In this unit you will learn to:

- offer festival wishes and respond
- use要…了for imminent events
- handle就and才in time sense
- read an adapted folk story with partial pinyin

Dialogue: New Year greetings

雨晨

新年快乐！万事如意！

Xīnnián kuàilè! Wànshì rúyì!

Happy New Year! May everything go as you wish!

马克

谢谢！你也身体健康！

Xièxie! Nǐ yě shēntǐ jiànkāng!

Thanks! And may you stay healthy!

雨晨

春节你回家吗?

Chūnjié nǐ huí jiā ma?

Are you going home for Spring Festival?

马克

要回了。火车票很难买，我排了很久的队。

Yào huí le. Huǒchēpiào hěn nán mǎi, wǒ páile hěn jiǔ de duì.

I am. Train tickets are hard to get — I queued for ages.

雨晨

什么时候出发?

Shénme shíhou chūfā?

When do you set off?

马克

二十九号才走，三十就到家了。

Èrshíjiǔ hào cái zǒu, sānshí jiù dào jiā le.

I don't leave until the 29th, and I'll be home on the 30th.

Culture inside the festival: Spring Festival

Spring Festival (春节，“the Spring Festival”) is the lunar new year, falling between late January and mid-February. It is the largest annual human migration on earth: hundreds of millions of people travel home for the reunion dinner (年夜饭) on New Year's Eve — the railway system sells well over a billion tickets in the travel period around it. Customs vary by region and family: sweeping the house before the festival but not on the first day (so as not to sweep away the luck), red envelopes of money (红包, hóngbāo) given by elders to children, red couplets (春联) pasted by doorways, and fireworks at midnight — a tradition whose ancient purpose was to frighten off a beast called年in the folk tale. The zodiac animal changes each year (鼠rat,牛ox,虎tiger,兔rabbit,龙dragon,蛇snake,马horse,羊goat,猴monkey,鸡rooster,狗dog,猪pig).“Happy New Year”at this festival is新年快乐or恭喜发财(“wishing you prosperity”, borrowed from Cantonese-speaking communities and now heard everywhere). The

lunar calendar also drives festivals in Korea and Vietnam, with shared roots and distinct local customs.

Grammar:就vs才— the two arrows of time

就(jiù) points at earliness or immediacy:三十就到家了“I'll be home on the 30th already (early!)”.才(cái) points at lateness or delay:二十九号才走“I don't leave until the 29th (late, after much waiting)”. English has no matching pair; the feeling is“so soon”versus“not until”. They also mark sequence (就=“then right away”), and quantity scales (才=“only”). Watch how they colour these:

他八点就来了。	Tā bā diǎn jiù lái le.	He came as early as eight.
他十一点才来。	Tā shíyī diǎn cái lái.	He didn't come until eleven.
票很便宜，才十块。	Piào hěn piányi, cái shí kuài.	Tickets are cheap — only ten yuan.

Wishes follow a template: [occasion] +快乐“happy [occasion]”(新年快乐,生日快乐,中秋快乐), or a four-character blessing such as万事如意“may all things go as you wish”or身体健康“good health”. Four-character blessings (成语-like phrases) are a whole register of Chinese goodwill; collect them like stamps.

Reading: the beast called年(adapted folk tale, new words glossed)

很久很久以前，有一个怪兽，名字叫“年”。每年冬天最后一天，“年”都来村子里，人们很害怕。有一个老人说：“年怕红色，怕火光，也怕大的声音。”所以人们在门上贴红纸，点灯，放炮。“年”来了，看见红色，听见炮声，就跑了。从那以后，人们在春节的时候穿红衣服，贴春联，放鞭炮。这就是春节的传说之一。

Gloss:怪兽guàishòu monster ·最后zuìhòu last ·害怕hàipà to fear ·红纸hóngzhǐ red paper ·点灯diǎn dēng light lamps ·放炮fàngpào set off firecrackers ·声shēng sound ·从那以后cóng nà yǐhòu from then on ·传说chuánshuō legend ·之一zhīyī one of. Folk tales have many versions; this is one common telling of the“beast Nian”story, recorded in modern folklore collections.

Vocabulary

A	2
新年	xīnnián
春节	chūnjié
快乐	kuàilè
身体	shēntǐ
健康	jiànkāng
回家	huí jiā
火车票	huǒchēpiào
排队	pái duì
很久	hěn jiǔ
红包	hóngbāo
春联	chūnlián
鞭炮	biānpào

Characters



Exercises

1. Choose就or才:

   1.他五点___起床了。(early)

   2.我们十点___上课。(not until)

   3.这个只___五块。(only)

2. Match the wishes to occasions:新年快乐/生日快乐/中秋快乐/恭喜发财— birthday, lunar new year, mid-autumn, prosperity wish.

3. Retell the Nian story in four Chinese sentences, spoken, from memory.

Communication task

Write and record a 15-second New Year voice message to a Chinese friend: greeting, one wish, one piece of personal news. Then write a second one for a formal contact (a teacher) and note what you changed.

Revision

复习：能做与不能做

Consolidate Stage A2

Structures you must own before B1

- 了(completed) vs过(experienced):看了“watched it (and finished)”;看过“have seen it (before)”.
- 比comparisons: A比B + adjective. Difference:得多/一点儿/倍. Equality: A跟B一样.
- 会(learned skill; future certainty) vs能(ability/circumstance) vs可以(permission).
- 快…了/就要…了: about to happen.的时候/以前/以后: time relations before the clause.
- 就(early/soon;“right then”) vs才(late/“not until”;“only”).
- 在+ place + verb: where an activity happens.在+ place + position word: where something is.
- 多/少/别+ verb for advice;先…再… for sequence.
- 这么/那么+ adjective for degree;越来越+ adjective for ongoing change.

Speaking drill: both roles

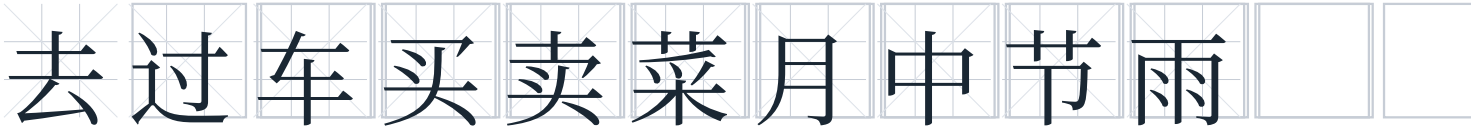
Perform these three scenes aloud, playing both parts, recording yourself. Replay each recording and note one thing to fix (a tone, a particle, a word order).

- Market: buy a jin of apples, object to the price, settle at six yuan, pay by scanning.
- Pharmacy: two symptoms, one question about medicine, advice sequence with先…再….

- Directions: a visitor asks where the teahouse is; you give a three-step route and estimate the time.

Character check

Read these aloud, then write from memory the five you find hardest:





If Stage A1 gave you the skeleton and A2 the flesh, B1 gives you the nervous system: opinions, reasons, excuses, and stories with connectives. Everything from here on assumes you can make a sentence without thinking about its parts — so if any A2 structure still needs thinking, patch it now.

Assessment

Stage A2 Assessment

Closed-book, one sitting

Part 1 · Listening-style comprehension (script)

Use the script as described in Stage A1's assessment: read aloud at speed, or use Chinese TTS, and answer without looking.

导游

明天我们去大理古城，早上八点出发。

Míngtiān wǒmen qù Dàlǐ gǔchéng, zǎoshang bā diǎn chūfā.

Tomorrow we go to Dali old town; we set off at 8 a.m.

游客

坐什么车？要多长时间？

Zuò shénme chē? Yào duō cháng shíjiān?

What transport? How long does it take?

导游

坐大巴，两个小时就到了。

Zuò dàbā, liǎng ge xiǎoshí jiù dào le.

Coach — two hours and we're there.

游客

中午很热吧？

Zhōngwǔ hěn rè ba?

It'll be hot at noon, right?

导游

比北京凉快多了。别忘了防晒霜！

Bǐ Běijīng liángkuai duō le. Bié wàngle fángshàishuāng!

1. Answer in English:

1. What time do they leave?

2. What transport, and how long?

3. How does the guide compare the weather with Beijing?

Part 2 · Reading

小林在西安住了三年。刚来的时候，她不会说中文，买东西很难。现在她的中文越来越好，还学会了讨价还价。上个月她坐高铁去了大理，吃了过桥米线。她说：“西安的历史比北京长，但是变化越来越快。”

2. True or false:

1. Xiaolin has lived in Xi'an for two years.

2. She couldn't speak Chinese when she arrived.

3. She has learned to bargain.

4. She has never taken a high-speed train.

Part 3 · Grammar

3. Fill in就/才/了/过/比/越来越as needed:

1.我去___云南，没去___西藏。

2.他七点___来了。(early)

3.十点___开始上课。(not until)

4.上海___我家的大。(comparison)

5.天气___冷了。

4. Translate into Chinese:

1. I've been to Dali but I've never been to Lijiang.

2. The metro is much faster than the bus.

3. It's about to rain; let's go inside.

4. Excuse me, where is the nearest pharmacy?

Part 4 · Writing and speaking (self-assessed)

Write a paragraph (10–14 sentences) about a trip you have taken: when, how long, transport, two activities, food, one comparison with home, and one“more and more”observation. Record it. The answer key gives an annotated model and criteria.

Pass guide: Parts 1–3 at 80%+; the writing communicates events in order without the reader needing to guess.

STAGE B1

交流

Connections

— hold real conversations: opinions, reasons, plans, and polite disagreement

— narrate connected stories with因为/所以,虽然/但是, and result complements

— handle the被passive, the把disposal, and verb result directions上去/下来

— read adapted real texts and recognise common traditional characters

— understand registers: formal vs casual, and where chengyu fit

At B1 the scaffolding starts coming down: dialogues lose English glosses; readings lose full pinyin.

UNIT 1

我觉得不行

Opinions, agreement, and polite disagreement

In this unit you will learn to:

- state and support an opinion with我觉得and因为…所以…
- agree and disagree politely
- soften statements with可能and好像
- discuss a simple plan with others

Dialogue: which restaurant?

马克

明天公司聚餐，去吃火锅还是粤菜?

Míngtiān gōngsī jùcān, qù chī huǒguō háishì Yuècài?

Tomorrow is the company dinner — hotpot or Cantonese?

雨晨

我觉得火锅好，大家可以一起聊天。

Wǒ juéde huǒguō hǎo, dàjiā kěyǐ yìqǐ liáotiān.

I think hotpot is good; everyone can chat together.

同事

可是小王不能吃辣。

Kěshì Xiǎo Wáng bù néng chī là.

But Xiao Wang can't eat spicy food.

雨晨

那去吃粤菜吧。粤菜比较清淡。

Nà qù chī Yuècài ba. Yuècài bǐjiào qīngdàn.

Then Cantonese. It's comparatively light.

同事

好，可是有点儿贵吧?

Hǎo, kěshì yǒudiǎnr guì ba?

OK, but isn't it a bit expensive?

雨晨

没关系，我请客!

Méi guānxi, wǒ qǐngkè!

No matter — it's on me!

From this unit on, dialogues keep pinyin but drop the English gloss line — you should be able to read them with the vocabulary table and the grammar notes. Re-read each dialogue twice: once for structure, once aloud for rhythm.

Grammar: connecting causes and concessions

Three connective pairs do most of the work of conversation at this level. They all follow the same principle: the connective comes before the clause it marks, and the second member of the pair cannot be left out in formal writing.

B	1
因为…，所以…	yīnwèi…, suǒyǐ…
虽然…，但是…	suīrán…, dànshì…
如果…，就…	rúguǒ…, jiù…

因为他不能吃辣，所以我们吃粤菜。Yīnwèi tā bù néng chī là, suǒyǐ wǒmen chī Yuècài.

Because he can't eat spicy food, we'll eat Cantonese.

虽然有点儿贵，但是很好吃。Suīrán yǒudiǎnr guì, dànshì hěn hǎochī.

> Although it's a bit expensive, it's delicious.

如果你不吃辣，就点清汤锅。Rúguǒ nǐ bù chī là, jiù diǎn qīngtāng guō.

> If you don't eat spicy, order the clear broth pot.

Note that Chinese happily uses both members of each pair in one sentence (虽然…但是…), where English would use only one (“although… but…” is wrong in English, right in Chinese).

Register: agreement and disagreement

Direct disagreement sounds ruder in Chinese offices than in English ones. The softening ladder, from softest to firmest:

好像有点儿贵。“It seems a bit expensive.”(distancing with好像— you're not asserting)

可能不行吧。“Probably won't work, I'd say.”(可能+吧— opinion as probability)

我觉得粤菜更好。“I think Cantonese is better.”(ownership with我觉得)

我不同意。“I disagree.”(formal, firm — boardroom, not dinner)



The ladder matters.我觉得不行is fine over dumplings;我不同意is for meetings. Chinese workplace culture is not a monolith — tech start-ups in Shenzhen argue differently from state-owned bureaus — but the softening ladder travels well everywhere in the Chinese-speaking world.

Vocabulary: opinions and dining

B	1
觉得	juéde
因为	yīnwèi
所以	suǒyǐ
虽然	suīrán
但是	dànshì

B	1
如果	rúguǒ
可是	kěshì
可能	kěnéng
好像	hǎoxiàng
没关系	méi guānxi
聚餐	jùcān
火锅	huǒguō
粤菜	Yuècài
清淡	qīngdàn
请客	qǐngkè

Characters



Exercises

1. Join the pairs with因为…所以… /虽然…但是… /如果…就…:

1.他不能吃辣。我们吃粤菜。

2.火锅很好吃。太辣了。

3.明天下雨。我们不去公园。

2. Soften each blunter sentence:

1.这个太贵了！(seems)

2.我不同意。(think)

3.不行。(probably +吧)

3. Translate:

1. I think hotpot is better, but Xiao Wang can't eat spicy food.

2. Although it's expensive, it's my treat.

3. If everyone agrees, we'll book the Cantonese place.

Communication task

Hold a spoken“team dinner debate”with yourself in three roles: one proposes hotpot, one defends Cantonese (someone can't eat spicy), one suggests a cheaper option. Use each connective pair once and the softening ladder at least twice. Record it.

UNIT 2

我把手机忘在家里了

The把construction, and losing things

In this unit you will learn to:

- use把to move objects around: disposal and handling
- use把with result complements (放到、带给、忘在)
- describe losing something and getting it back
- handle被for things that happen to you

Dialogue: the lost phone

马克

糟糕，我把手机忘在出租车上了！

Zāogāo, wǒ bǎ shǒujī wàng zài chūzūchē shàng le!

Disaster — I left my phone in the taxi!

雨晨

别急。你把发票给司机了吗？

Bié jí. Nǐ bǎ fāpiào gěi sījī le ma?

Don't panic. Did you give the receipt to the driver?

马克

没有。我把发票扔了。

Méiyǒu. Wǒ bǎ fāpiào rēng le.

No. I threw the receipt away.

雨晨

那麻烦了。你的手机被别人拿走了怎么办?

Nà máfan le. Nǐ de shǒujī bèi biérén ná zǒu le zěnme bàn?

That's trouble. What if someone has taken your phone?

马克

我应该把发票放在钱包里。

Wǒ yīnggāi bǎ fāpiào fàng zài qiánbāo li.

I should have put the receipt in my wallet.

雨晨

先给出租车公司打电话吧。

Xiān gěi chūzūchē gōngsī dǎ diànhuà ba.

Call the taxi company first.

Grammar:把— the disposal construction

English lets you mention an object and then do nothing with it:“I forgot my phone (in the taxi)”. Chinese uses把when the object gets moved, changed, or disposed of — the pattern is: subject +把+ object + verb + something that happens to the object (a result, a place, a direction). The verb cannot be bare; something must complete it.

我把手机忘在出租车上了。Wǒ bǎ shǒujī wàng zài chūzūchē shàng le.

I left my phone in the taxi. (忘在+ place)

请把书放在桌子上。Qǐng bǎ shū fàng zài zhuōzi shàng.

Please put the book on the table. (放到/在)

他把发票扔了。Tā bǎ fāpiào rēng le.

He threw the receipt away. (扔+了)

我把作业做完了。Wǒ bǎ zuòyè zuò wán le.

I finished the homework. (做完)

请把盐递给我。Qǐng bǎ yán dì gěi wǒ.

Pass me the salt. (递给)

我把门关上。Wǒ bǎ mén guān shàng.

I'll close the door. (关上)

When NOT to use把: for statements of mere existence or perception, and for verbs that don't affect the object (我喜欢这本书, not把). A quick test: if you can naturally add “away / into / onto / up / down / to so-and-so” to the English verb, Chinese probably wants把.

Grammar:被— the passive

被(bèi) marks the agent in a passive, mainly for situations with a consequence — often an unwelcome one. In speech, the passive is often expressed by让or叫instead:手机被人拿走了or手机让人拿走了. Chinese uses the passive far less than English; if the agent doesn't matter, just drop it:手机丢了(“the phone's gone lost”).

手机被人拿走了。Shǒujī bèi rén ná zǒu le.

The phone was taken by someone.

他被公司派去上海。Tā bèi gōngsī pài qù Shànghǎi.

He was sent to Shanghai by his company.

我的自行车叫人偷了。Wǒ de zìxíngchē jiào rén tōu le.

My bike got stolen.

Culture inside the dialogue: receipts and lost property

The taxi receipt (发票) is not just paper: it carries the vehicle number, and taxi companies run lost-property services through it. In mainland cities, official taxi invoices are also used for expense reimbursement at work, which is why the receipt habit is stronger than among many Western travellers. Ride-hailing apps have largely replaced street-hailing in big cities since the mid-2010s, and in-app lost-property messaging has made the phone-left-in-taxi problem mostly a phone-left-in-a-car problem. In Taiwan, a lost item handed to a convenience store will often find its way to the owner — a small service culture worth knowing about.

Vocabulary

B	1
把	bǎ
被	bèi
忘	wàng
糟糕	zāogāo
出租车	chūzūchē
发票	fāpiào
扔	rēng
钱包	qiánbāo
拿走	ná zǒu
怎么办	zěnme bàn
应该	yīnggāi
递	dì
偷	tōu

Characters

把 被 忘

把(bǎ) originally depicted holding something in the hand — its“handle/dispose of”grammar sense grew from that literal grip.

被(bèi) was a bedding cover; things happen to you as a blanket falls on you — a metaphor centuries old. Both etymologies are genuine.

Exercises

1. Rewrite with把:

   1.我忘在taxi里了+手机→ ___

   2.请放the book在桌子上→ ___

   3.他扔了the receipt → ___

2. Rewrite with被/叫/让:

   1. Someone stole my bike. →我的自行车___

   2. The company sent him to Shanghai. →他___

3. Translate:

1. Please pass me that cup.

2. I threw the old phone away.

3. What should we do if the luggage gets taken by someone else?

Communication task

Record a two-minute“lost item”story: what you lost, where, what you did (three把sentences), how it ended (one被sentence). Retell it faster the second time.

UNIT 3

西安的兵马俑

Directions and complements上去/下来/出来; a historical reading

In this unit you will learn to:

- use directional complements:上去、下来、出去、回来
- describe a historical site and a visit
- read an adapted historical passage
- use次数and多次for frequency

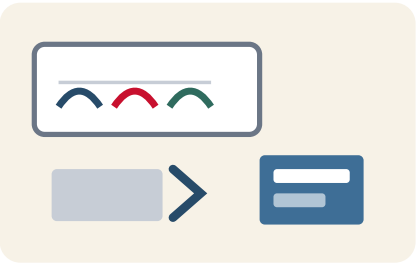
Dialogue: at the Terracotta Warriors

马克

人太多了，我们排了半个小时的队！

Rén tài duō le, wǒmen páile bàn ge xiǎoshí de duì!

Too many people — we queued half an hour!



雨晨

所以我很早就想上来了。

Suǒyǐ wǒ hěn zǎo jiù xiǎng shàng lái le.

That's why I wanted to come up early.

马克

一号坑比二号坑大得多。

Yī hào kēng bǐ èr hào kēng dà de duō.

Pit 1 is much bigger than Pit 2.

雨晨

看，那边新出土的士兵刚刚下来。

Kàn, nàbiān xīn chūtǔ de shìbīng gānggāng xià lái.

Look — the newly excavated soldiers have just come down over there.

马克

我拍了很多照片。等我回去，我要给孩子看。

Wǒ pāile hěn duō zhàopiàn. děng wǒ huíqù, wǒ yào gěi háizi kàn.

I took lots of photos. When I get back I'll show the kids.

雨晨

你来过几次了？

Nǐ láiguo jǐ cì le?

How many times have you come now?

Grammar: directional complements

Attach上/下/进/出/回/过+来/去to a verb to say where the action moves, relative to where you are.来(come) moves

toward the speaker;去(go) moves away. The compound forms are the backbone of vivid narration:

B	1
上去	shàngqù
上来	shànglái
下去	xiàqù
下来	xiàlái
进去	jìnqù
出来	chūlái
回去	huíqù
回来	huílái
拿出来	náchūlái

Frequency with次(cì):三次“three times”,几次“how many times”. The order is verb + object-phrase +次:去过三次北

京or去北京去过三次. Multple times in general:多次, or一次又一次“time after again”.

Reading: the Terracotta Army (adapted, glossed)

一九七四年三月，西安附近的农民在打井的时候，发现了几个陶制的士兵。考古学家后来挖出了几千个陶俑，

还有陶马和铜车。这些陶俑是秦始皇的陵墓的一部分，两千多年前做的。每个士兵的脸都不一样，服装也不同

。秦始皇十三岁成为秦王，后来统一了六国，是中国历史上第一个皇帝。他下令建造陵墓，用了几十万人力，

建了几十年。今天，兵马俑是“世界第八奇迹”之一，也是联合国教科文组织的世界遗产。

Gloss:陶制táozhì pottery-made ·俑yǒng figurine ·考古学家kǎogǔ xuéjiā archaeologist ·挖wā dig ·秦始皇Qínshǐhuáng First Emperor of Qin ·陵墓língmù mausoleum ·统一tǒngyī unify ·六国liù guó the six states ·皇帝huángdì emperor · 下令xiàlìng order ·建造jiànzào build · 人力rénlì labour force ·奇迹qíjì miracle/wonder ·遗产yíchǎn heritage. Facts: the discovery was by farmers digging a well in March 1974; the site was inscribed by UNESCO as a World Heritage Site in 1987;“eighth wonder”is a popular nickname, not a UNESCO title.



You just read real history. The characters俑(figurines) and坑(pits) are not everyday words — but坑、挖、发现、统一and建造are, and you'll meet them in news articles forever. Historical readings are vocabulary goldmines precisely because they repeat the same core verbs.

Vocabulary

B	1
排队	pái duì
坑	kēng
士兵	shìbīng
出土	chūtǔ
照片	zhàopiàn
孩子	háizi
次	cì
刚才	gāngcái
方	fāng
历史	lìshǐ

B	1
皇帝	huángdì
发现	fāxiàn
建造	jiànzào
统一	tǒngyī

Characters



Exercises

1. Choose the directional complement:

1.他在楼上，我叫他___。(come down)

2.我的钱包在家里，我得回去___。(go back and get)

3.她从房间里走出___。(out here)

2. Answer in Chinese:你去过几次西安？你看过兵马俑吗？

3. Translate:

1. I've been to Xi'an three times.

2. He came up half an hour ago.

3. The newly excavated soldiers have just come down.

Communication task

Record a museum-going story: travel there, queue, what you saw (one comparison), one directional-complement moment (“when we came out…”), and how many times you've been. Use次数twice.

UNIT 4

Traditional characters

Recognising traditional forms and where they're used

In this unit you will learn to:

- recognise high-frequency traditional characters
- understand the systematic simplified–traditional correspondences
- know which communities use which script
- read a short passage that mixes both

Two scripts, one language

Simplified characters (简体字) are standard in mainland China and Singapore; traditional characters (繁體字) are standard in Taiwan, Hong Kong, and Macau, and common in overseas communities. The scripts diverged by policy: simplification began in the 1950s in the PRC, drawing on long-existing shorthand forms, and the standard set was fixed in 1964 and revised in 1986. Most characters are identical in both systems; the visible differences concentrate in a few hundred high-frequency characters. Readers of one script generally learn to read the other quickly — writing the other way is harder.

The five systematic correspondences

Most simplifications follow predictable patterns. Learn the patterns, not the list:

B	1
言 → 讠	yán
糸 → 纟	mì
車 → 车	chē
門 → 门	mén
貝/錢 → 贝/钱	bèi/qián

And a handful of “wholesale” simplifications you see constantly:個→个,時→时,長→长,東→东,車→车,馬→马,鳥→鸟,見→见,書→书,學→学,開→开,關→关,葉→叶,龍→龙,廣→广,廠→厂.

Reading: the same news, two scripts

简体：台北的夜市每天晚上都很热闹。游客可以吃小吃，买衣服，还可以看街头表演。

繁體：台北的夜市每天晚上都很熱鬧。遊客可以吃小吃，買衣服，還可以看街頭表演。

Read the traditional line aloud using the simplified line as a key. Notice which characters changed (热→熱,闹→鬧,游→遊,买→買,还→還,头→頭) and which stayed (的、夜、市、每、天、晚、上、都、很、吃、小、可、以、看、街、表、演). The staying ones are the majority — that's why script-switching is easier than it looks.



Strategy: learn simplified seriously, and traditional as recognition only. Spend one focused hour on the five patterns above, then read one Taiwan news article a week with a conversion tool. Recognition grows fast; don't waste beginner energy on writing both forms.

Vocabulary: script and language policy

B	1
简体字	jiǎntǐzì
繁体字	fántǐzì
汉字	Hànzì
书法	shūfǎ
词典	cídiǎn
标准	biāozhǔn

B	1
政策	zhèngcè
社区	shèqū
地区	dìqū
夜市	yèshì
表演	biǎoyǎn

Exercises

1. Convert to simplified:

   1.門2.語3.車4.買5.時6.學

2. Convert to traditional:

   1.说2.红3.们4.长5.东6.见

3. Read the traditional sentence from the reading aloud; then type it in simplified with your keyboard and check your choices.

Communication task

Find one short traditional-script headline from a Taiwanese or Hong Kong news site. Write out its simplified equivalent by hand, then read the traditional one aloud. Bring both to your next self-review.

UNIT 5

我的工作时间太长了

Work, complaints, and the degree complement得

In this unit you will learn to:

- describe how an action is done with得
- complain politely and state consequences
- talk about jobs, schedules, and overtime
- use一…就… for immediate sequence

Dialogue: after a long week

马克

你这几天忙得连饭都没时间吃。

Nǐ zhè jǐ tiān máng de lián fàn dōu méi shíjiān chī.

These days you're so busy you don't even have time to eat.

雨晨

对，项目做得不太好，客户很不满意。

Duì, xiàngmù zuò de bù tài hǎo, kèhù hěn bù mǎnyì.

Right — the project isn't going well and the client is unhappy.

马克

你每天工作到几点?

Nǐ měitiān gōngzuò dào jǐ diǎn?

Until what time do you work each day?

雨晨

常常十一点才下班，回家就十二点了。

Chángcháng shíyī diǎn cái xiàbān, huí jiā jiù shí'èr diǎn le.

Often I don't finish until eleven, and it's midnight when I get home.

马克

这样下去身体会受不了。

Zhèyàng xiàqù shēntǐ huì shòubuliǎo.

If this goes on your body won't take it.

雨晨

所以我一放假就睡觉！

Suǒyǐ wǒ yí fàngjià jiù shuìjiào!

So the moment I have a holiday, I sleep!

Grammar: the degree complement得

To say how an action is performed, put得(de) after the verb and add an adjective: he runs fast, she speaks Chinese well.

The negative goes inside:做得不好“not done well”. This is one of the most useful structures in the language — master it now.

他说得很快。Tā shuō de hěn kuài.

He speaks very fast.

她中文说得很好。Tā Zhōngwén shuō de hěn hǎo.

She speaks Chinese very well.

这个字我写得不好。Zhège zì wǒ xiě de bù hǎo.

你忙得连饭都没时间吃。Nǐ máng de lián fàn dōu méi shíjiān chī.

You're so busy you don't even have time to eat.

Grammar:一…就… and才in time

一…就… means“as soon as… then…” — the second event follows the first immediately:我一到家就睡觉“the moment I get home, I sleep”. With才(not until):十一点才下班. The complaint structure这样下去(“if this continues”) sets up any warning politely.

Culture inside the dialogue:加班culture

加班(“adding work”) — overtime — became a public topic in mainland China in the late 2010s, when the tech industry's informal“996”schedule (9 a.m. to 9 p.m., 6 days a week) drew national criticism and later regulatory attention. Labour law in the PRC sets a standard eight-hour day and caps overtime, but enforcement varies by industry. In 2021 a Shanghai court ruling and state media criticism of“996”marked a visible shift; the topic remains actively debated. In Taiwan and Hong Kong, working hours and culture differ again — office culture in Taipei is generally closer to Japanese norms than to Shenzhen's. Complaining about加班is, across all these places, extremely natural small talk.

Vocabulary: work and complaint

B	1
忙	máng
项目	xiàngmù
客户	kèhù
满意	mǎnyì
下班	xiàbān
加班	jiābān
放假	fàngjià

B	1
受不了	shòubuliǎo
这样下去	zhèyàng xiàqù
连…都…	lián…dōu…
常常	chángcháng
受不了	shòubuliǎo



Complaining is friendship glue in Chinese offices. “忙死了” (“busy to death”) is not a real medical report; it's the Chinese “how are you”. Learn the complaints people actually make — they're the true small talk.

Characters



Exercises

1. Describe with得:

   1. He writes characters (fast)

   2. She sings (well)

   3. I slept (badly) last night

2. Join with一…就…:

   1. I get home. I sleep. → ___

   2. She finished work. She called me. → ___

3. Translate:

1. I've been so busy this week I haven't had time to eat.

2. If this goes on, your health will suffer.

3. I don't finish work until ten.

Communication task

Record a 90-second polite complaint about your workload: how busy (得structure), when you finish (才), what happens as soon as you get home (一…就…), one consequence warning. Then record the same content as a grumble to a close friend and note the register changes.

UNIT 6

我们去看京剧吧

Entertainment,感到/觉得, and “pretty + adjective”得很

In this unit you will learn to:

- discuss films, shows, and performances
- express impressions:有意思/没意思/感动
- use得很and极了for intensity
- book tickets and seats

Dialogue: after the show

马克

昨天的京剧怎么样?

Zuótiān de jīngjù zěnmeyàng?

How was the Peking opera yesterday?

雨晨

好极了！演员唱得非常好，衣服漂亮得很。

Hǎo jíle! Yǎnyuán chàng de fēicháng hǎo, yīfu piàoliang de hěn.

Wonderful! The singers sang superbly and the costumes were gorgeous.

马克

你听得懂吗?

Nǐ tīng de dǒng ma?

Could you understand it?

雨晨

听不太懂，但是有字幕。

Tīng bù tài dǒng, dànshì yǒu zìmù.

Not very well, but there were subtitles.

马克

下次我也要去看。怎么买票?

Xià cì wǒ yě yào qù kàn. Zěnme mǎi piào?

Next time I want to come too. How do you buy tickets?

雨晨

在手机上买，选好座位，扫码进场。

Zài shǒujī shàng mǎi, xuǎn hǎo zuòwèi, sǎomǎ jìn chǎng.

On your phone — choose your seat, scan the code to get in.

Grammar:潜在能力—听得懂/听不懂

Verb +得/不+ result tests whether the result can happen:听得懂“can understand (by listening)”,听不懂“can't”;看得见“can see it”,看不见“can't see”;来得及“there's still time”,来不及“too late”. This is the potential complement — one of the most natural ways Chinese talks about ability.

Grammar: intensity得很/极了/得不得了

B	1
好得很	hǎo de hěn
好极了	hǎo jíle
累得不得了	lèi de bùdéliǎo
有意思	yǒu yìsi
感动	gǎndòng

Culture inside the show: Peking opera

Peking opera (京剧) arose in Beijing in the late 18th century, when Anhui troupes brought their music north and it fused with local styles; it was recognised by UNESCO as intangible cultural heritage in 2010. Its conventions are highly stylised: face paint (脸谱) signals character types, a whip represents a horse, and a circle walked on stage represents a long journey. Audiences traditionally "call out" appreciation mid-performance — a custom that unsettles first-time Western visitors. Younger urban audiences today attend less, and the form is actively reinventing itself through short-video platforms, where young performers have found large followings in the 2020s. If you get the chance, subtitled performances are the standard entry point for learners — exactly what Lin used.

Vocabulary: performance

B	1
京剧	jīngjù
演员	yǎnyuán
唱	chàng
字幕	zìmù
座位	zuòwèi
进场	jìn chǎng
选择	xuǎnzé
感动	gǎndòng
表演	biǎoyǎn

Characters



Exercises

1. Potential complements — make the pairs:

1.听+懂(can/can't) → ___ / ___

2.看+见→ ___ / ___

3.来+及→ ___ / ___

2. Intensify:

1.好(very) → ___

2.累(extremely) → ___

3.漂亮(utterly) → ___

3. Translate:

1. I could understand a little, but not very well.

2. The costumes were gorgeous.

3. Choose your seat on the phone and scan to enter.

Communication task

Recommend a performance or film you love: what it was, one thing done very well (得structure), one potential complement (“you'll understand it”), how to get tickets. 60–90 seconds, recorded.

UNIT 7

租房子的麻烦

Housing, repairs, and要么…要么… choices

In this unit you will learn to:

- describe an apartment and its problems
- use要么…要么… for alternatives
- make arrangements with property or landlords
- use会…的for confident predictions

Dialogue: the leaky tap

马克

我租的房子又出问题了：水龙头坏了。

Wǒ zū de fángzi yòu chū wèntí le: shuǐlóngtóu huài le.

My rented flat has a problem again: the tap is broken.

雨晨

房东知道吗?

Fángdōng zhīdào ma?

Does the landlord know?

马克

我给他发了消息，他还没回。

Wǒ gěi tā fāle xiāoxi, tā hái méi huí.

I messaged him; he hasn't replied yet.

雨晨

要么你自己找师傅修，要么再等等。

Yàome nǐ zìjǐ zhǎo shīfu xiū, yàome zài děng děng.

Either you find a repair person yourself, or you wait a bit more.

马克

等他，水会漏得更厉害的。

Děng tā, shuǐ huì lòu de gèng lìhai de.

If I wait for him, the leak will get worse.

雨晨

那就先找人修，把收据保存好。

Nà jiù xiān zhǎo rén xiū, bǎ shōujù bǎocún hǎo.

Then find someone now — and keep the receipt safe.

Grammar:要么…要么…;会…的;又vs再

要么…要么… presents alternatives: either A or B.会…的wraps a confident prediction:会漏得更厉害的“it WILL get worse (I'm sure)”.又(again, for past) vs再(again, for future):他又来了“he came again”;你再来一次“come again (next time)”. Small words, sharp distinctions — these three pairs carry whole negotiations.

Culture inside the rental: renting in Chinese cities

Renting in mainland cities runs through platforms and agents, with deposits of one to three months' rent and, very often, an agent fee; leases are typically annual. Landlord responsiveness varies as widely as anywhere. Two useful practical words:房东landlord (literally“house-east”; the older opposite,房客tenant, survives in everyday speech) and物业the property management office of a compound — for shared-pipe problems,物业is often faster than the landlord. In Taiwan, the standard

lease runs through a “契约” contract, and a government-backed rental dispute service exists; many young renters in Taipei share flats in a market where buying is out of reach for most. These are generalisations — always read your actual contract.

Vocabulary: housing and repairs

B	1
租	zū
房子	fángzi
房东	fángdōng
水龙头	shuǐlóngtóu
坏	huài
修	xiū
师傅	shīfu
漏	lòu
厉害	lìhai
收据	shōujù
保存	bǎocún
物业	wùyè
契约	qìyuē

Characters



Exercises

1. Join with要么…要么…:

   1. We eat at home. We eat out. → ___

   2. I call the landlord. I find a repair person. → ___

2. Choose又or再:

1.他___迟到了。(again, past)

2.请你___来一次。(again, future)

3.我___想了一遍。

3. Translate:

1. The tap is broken; either you fix it or the leak will get worse.

2. I messaged the landlord but he hasn't replied.

3. Keep the receipt safe.

Communication task

Record a call to a landlord about a repair: state the problem, say what you've done, give the two alternatives with要么…要么…, and predict the consequence with会…的. Play both roles.

UNIT 8

大学申请和个人介绍

Self-presentation: studies, work history, and想要vs想

In this unit you will learn to:

- present your background in connected speech
- narrate your education and work history in order
- use想要/打算/计划for intentions
- handle a simple interview question

Reading: Lin's introduction (new words glossed)

大家好，我叫林雨晨，是西安人。我在北京读的大学，学的是英语翻译。毕业以后，我在一家出版社工作了三年，主要负责儿童读物。后来我去了新加坡，一边工作一边读研究生，研究方向是机器翻译。现在我是自由译者，也给成人学生教中文。我的工作让我可以到处旅行：去年我在大理住了一个月，remote办公。我的计划是明年写一本关于中国茶文化的书。

Gloss:读大学dú dàxué attend university ·毕业的人bìyè graduate ·出版社chūbǎnshè publishing house ·负责fùzé be responsible for ·儿童értóng children ·读物dúwù reading material ·研究生yánjiūshēng postgraduate ·自由译者zìyóu yìzhě freelance translator ·到处dàochù everywhere. (One English word is kept in the text — as you advance, mixed-language realities like this are worth seeing; you'll type messages exactly like this.)

Grammar: intentions —想/想要/打算/希望

B	1
想	xiǎng
想要	xiǎng yào
打算	dǎsuàn
计划	jìhuà
希望	xīwàng
为了	wèile

These form a ladder of commitment:我想去“I'd like to go”;我想要去“I want to go”;我打算去“I intend/plan to go”;我计划明年去“I've scheduled going next year”. In interviews and formal writing,打算and计划sound decisive;想alone can read as dreamy.

Narrating a history in order:先…然后…后来…最后(“first… then… afterwards… finally…”). Use一边…一边… (“while…ing”) for simultaneous actions:一边工作一边读书“worked while studying”.

Interview practice: three questions, model answers

Answer each aloud in 30–45 seconds before reading the model in the answer key.

1. 请介绍一下你自己。(Introduce yourself.)
2. 你为什么想学中文？(Why do you want to learn Chinese?)
3. 你未来五年的计划是什么？(What are your plans for the next five years?)



Interviews reward the same connectives as storytelling:先、然后、后来、最后. Practise your own history as a four-beat story. If you can tell it smoothly in Chinese, you can tell it smoothly in any language — the discipline transfers.

Vocabulary

B	1
介绍	jièshào
毕业	bìyè
大学	dàxué
专业	zhuānyè
负责	fùzé
自由	zìyóu
到处	dàochù
计划	jìhuà
未来	wèilái
一边…一边…	yìbiān…yìbiān…
先…最后…	xiān…zuìhòu…

Characters



Exercises

4. Rank the intention words from softest to most committed and write one sentence for each about your own plans.

5. Narrate your education-to-now in five sentences with先…然后…后来…最后.

Communication task

Record a 2-minute self-introduction for a language-exchange profile: background, work, why Chinese, one concrete plan with为了. Then re-record it in 60 seconds without notes — the short version is the one you'll actually use.

Revision

复习：连接词的走廊

Consolidate Stage B1

The B1 connective corridor

Stage B1's grammar is a corridor of connectives. Walk down it aloud, once per day for a week — each pair with one sentence of your own:

- 因为…所以… because / therefore虽然…但是… although / but
- 如果…就… if / then要么…要么… either / or
- 一边…一边… while…ing一…就… as soon as / then at once
- 先…然后…后来…最后first, then, afterwards, finally
- 就early-soon vs才not-until-only又again (past) vs再again (future)
- 为了in order to这样下去if this continues会…的surely will

The three great complements

得(how the action goes):说得很快。Potential (can it happen):听得懂/听不懂。Directional (where it goes):走出来/送回去。Make one sentence of each type about your own week.

把and被check

Rewrite aloud: (1) I put the keys on the table. (2) The letter was taken by someone. (3) Take this to your teacher. (4) He

was sent to Beijing. If any of these four takes more than five seconds, revisit Unit 2.



This is the stage where learners either consolidate or plateau. The difference is almost always speaking aloud: B1 grammar lives in connectives, and connectives only become automatic in your mouth, not in your eyes. Narrate your day, every day this week, in five connected sentences.

Assessment

Stage B1 Assessment

Closed-book

Part 1 · Listening-style comprehension (script)

房东

你好，房子我已经修好了。

Nǐ hǎo, fángzi wǒ yǐjīng xiū hǎo le.

Hello — I've already fixed the flat.

马克

太好了！水龙头是你自己修的吗?

Tài hǎo le! Shuǐlóngtóu shì nǐ zìjǐ xiū de ma?

Great! Did you fix the tap yourself?

房东

不是，我找师傅修的。一共八十块。

Bù shì, wǒ zhǎo shīfu xiū de. Yígòng bāshí kuài.

No, I got a repair person. 80 yuan in total.

马克

没问题。我把钱转给你。

Méi wèntí. Wǒ bǎ qián zhuǎn gěi nǐ.

No problem. I'll transfer you the money.

房东

下次有问题，你先告诉我，别自己修。

Xià cì yǒu wèntí, nǐ xiān gàosu wǒ, bié zìjǐ xiū.

Next time there's a problem, tell me first — don't fix it yourself.

1. Answer:

1. Who fixed the tap?

2. How much?

3. What does the landlord ask Mark to do next time?

Part 2 · Reading

马克在西安已经住了一年。虽然他的工作很忙，但是他每个周末都去不同的地方。他喜欢历史，所以去看了兵马俑，也去了很多博物馆。他觉得西安人做菜做得又好吃又便宜。他打算明年把父母接来，一起在春节期间旅游。

2. True or false:

1. Mark has lived in Xi'an for two years.

2. He goes somewhere every weekend.

3. He thinks Xi'an food is expensive.

4. He plans to travel with his parents at Spring Festival.

Part 3 · Grammar

3. Rewrite each with the structure in brackets:

1.他很忙。他没时间吃饭。(用…得连…都没…) → ___

2.我到了家。我马上睡觉。(一…就…) → ___

3.这本书我看懂了。(potential, negative) → ___

4. Translate into Chinese:

1. Because I can't eat spicy food, we ordered the clear broth.

2. Either you tell the landlord, or the leak will get worse.

3. Although the performance was long, it was wonderful.

4. As soon as she graduated, she went to Singapore.

Part 4 · Writing and speaking (self-assessed)

Write a page (12–16 sentences) explaining a choice you made: two options, the pros and cons of each with connectives, your decision with打算, and one prediction with会…的. Record it. Model and criteria in the answer key.

Pass guide: Parts 1–3 at 80%+; writing shows connected reasoning, not isolated sentences.

STAGE B2

视角

Perspectives

— discuss social topics — education, cities, generational change — with reasons and nuance

— read real, lightly adapted articles and opinion pieces; pinyin only for hard words

— command the complement system fully and the是…的narrative pattern

— understand chengyu in context and start using the common fifty

— write coherent paragraphs: narrative, descriptive, and simple argumentative

B2 is the long middle climb of Chinese learning. Read more than you study; speak more than you read.

UNIT 1

教育与压力

Education, pressure, and the是…的pattern

In this unit you will learn to:

- discuss education systems and their pressures
- use是…的to highlight circumstances of past events
- read a lightly adapted article with opinion
- express disagreement with evidence

Dialogue: homework at midnight

雨晨

我表姐的孩子今年高三，每天学到半夜。

Wǒ biǎojiě de háizi jīnnián gāosān, měitiān xué dào bànyè.

My cousin's kid is in final-year high school this year; she studies until midnight every day.

马克

是在学校学，还是在家学?

Shì zài xuéxiào xué, háishì zài jiā xué?

Is it at school she studies, or at home?

雨晨

是住校的，两个星期才回一次家。

Shì zhùxiào de, liǎng ge xīngqī cái huí yí cì jiā.

She boards at school — comes home once a fortnight.

马克

为了高考，大家都这样吗?

Wèile gāokǎo, dàjiā dōu zhèyàng ma?

For the gaokao, is everyone like this?

雨晨

不一定，但大城市的高三学生压力确实很大。

Bù yídìng, dàn dà chéngshì de gāosān xuésheng yālì quèshí hěn dà.

Not necessarily, but final-year students in big cities are genuinely under great pressure.

马克

这让我想起我们的考试制度。

Zhè ràng wǒ xiǎngqǐ wǒmen de kǎoshì zhìdù.

It reminds me of our exam system.

Grammar:是…的— highlighting the circumstances

When you narrate a past event and want to stress how, where, when, or by whom it happened, wrap the detail with是…的:是住校的“it's (the case that she) boards”. The event itself is taken as known; the是…的frame spotlights the background detail. This pattern is everywhere in spoken narrative — recognise it and your listening jumps a level.

她是坐高铁来的。Tā shì zuò gāotiě lái de.

She came by high-speed rail (not by plane).

这本书是在台北买的。Zhè běn shū shì zài Táiběi mǎi de.

This book was bought in Taipei (that's the point).

我是2018年开始学中文的。Wǒ shì èr líng yī bā nián kāishǐ xué Zhōngwén de.

Do not confuse this with the ordinary是linking nouns, or with是的(“yes”). A quick test: if you can add“it's the case that…”or“(not…)”in English, Chinese wants是…的.

Reading: the gaokao (adapted news commentary, glossed)

高考，即“普通高等学校招生全国统一考试”，每年六月举行。它被很多人看作人生中最重要的一次考试，因为分数直接决定学生能上哪所大学。考试科目包括语文、数学和外语，另外还有综合科目。近年来，高考报名人数每年超过一千万。支持者认为，高考给了所有学生一个公平竞争的机会；批评者则指出，“一考定终身”会给年轻人带来过大的压力，而且不同地区的录取分数线并不一样。近年来推出的“强基计划”等改革，试图在统一考试之外，为有特殊才能的学生提供另一条路。

Gloss:招生zhāoshēng admissions ·统一tǒngyī unified ·举行jǔxíng to hold ·分数fēnshù score ·录取lùqǔ to admit ·分数线fēnshùxiàn cut-off score line ·公平gōngpíng fair ·竞争jìngzhēng compete ·批评pīpíng criticism ·一考定终身yì kǎo dìng zhōngshēn“one exam decides your whole life”·改革gǎigé reform ·强基计划qiángjī jìhuà Strong Foundation Plan (2020 programme). Figures approximate and changing; current-year numbers should be checked against official announcements.

Discussion: agree or disagree, with evidence

1. Respond to each in 3–4 sentences, spoken, using是…的at least once:

1.一考定终身不公平。

2.压力大的孩子以后更成功。

3.网上课程会代替传统学校。

Vocabulary: education

B	2
教育	jiàoyù
高考	gāokǎo
压力	yālì
高三	gāosān
住校	zhùxiào
确实	quèshí
公平	gōngpíng
竞争	jìngzhēng
录取	lùqǔ
改革	gǎigé
想起	xiǎngqǐ
让	ràng
制度	zhìdù

Characters



Exercises

2. Rewrite with是…的to highlight the bracketed detail:

1.他去年去了日本。(by plane)

2.我在旧书店找到的这本书。(in Beijing)

3.她昨晚回来了。(at midnight)

3. Translate:

1. It was for the gaokao that she studied until midnight.

2. Was it in Shanghai that you bought this?

3. This system genuinely gives everyone a fair chance.

Communication task

Record a 2-minute argument about your own country's exam system: one claim, two reasons, one是…的detail, one concession with虽然…但是…. Then argue the opposite side for 90 seconds.

UNIT 2

大城市，小城市

Urbanisation, cost of living, and越…越…

In this unit you will learn to:

- discuss cities, migration, and cost of living
- use越…越… for correlated change
- use连…都/也for “even”
- read a lightly adapted opinion piece

Dialogue: leave or stay?

马克

你为什么离开北京去了新加坡?

Nǐ wèishénme líkāi Běijīng qùle Xīnjiāpō?

Why did you leave Beijing for Singapore?

雨晨

房租越涨越高，通勤时间越来越长。

Fángzū yuè zhǎng yuè gāo, tōngqín shíjiān yuèláiyuè cháng.

Rent kept rising, commuting ever longer.

马克

可是大城市机会多啊。

Kěshì dà chéngshì jīhuì duō a.

But big cities have more opportunities.

雨晨

对，可是连周末都休息不了，机会多又有什么用?

Duì, kěshì lián zhōumò dōu xiūxi bù liǎo, jīhuì duō yòu yǒu shénme yòng?

True — but if I can't even rest at weekends, what use are the opportunities?

马克

小城市呢？房价便宜得多吧?

Xiǎo chéngshì ne? Fángjià piányi de duō ba?

What about smaller cities? Much cheaper housing?

雨晨

便宜是便宜，但工作机会越少，年轻人越不想留。

Piányi shì piányi, dàn gōngzuò jīhuì yuè shǎo, niánqīngrén yuè bù xiǎng liú.

Cheaper, yes — but the fewer the jobs, the less young people want to stay.

Grammar:越…越…;连…都/也; A是A,但…

越…越… (“the more… the more…”):房租越涨越高“as rent rises, it gets higher and higher” — the two clauses move together.连…都/也(“even”):连周末都休息不了“can't even rest at weekends”. And a beautifully Chinese concession:便宜是便宜，但…“cheap it is cheap, but…” — repeat the adjective with是to concede the point before countering it.

越大越贵。Yuè dà yuè guì.

The bigger, the more expensive.

我忙得连饭都忘了吃。Wǒ máng de lián fàn dōu wàngle chī.

I was so busy I even forgot to eat.

好吃是好吃，就是太贵。Hǎochī shì hǎochī, jiùshì tài guì.

Tasty, granted — just too expensive.

Reading: urban China in numbers (adapted)

中国的城镇化速度是世界历史上少见的：一九七八年，大约百分之十八的人口住在城市；今天，这个比例已经超过百分之六十五。北上广深四大一线城市吸引了大量年轻人，但近十年来，很多人开始重新考虑：房价高、通勤时间长、竞争激烈，让“逃离北上广”成了一个常用说法。同时，成都、杭州、西安这些“新一线”城市，因为生活成本较低、生活质量较高，变得越来越受欢迎。专家指出，远程办公的普及可能进一步改变年轻人选择住在哪里。

Gloss:城镇化chéngzhènhuà urbanisation ·比例bǐlì proportion ·吸引xīyǐn attract ·通勤tōngqín commuting ·激烈jīliè fierce ·逃离táolí to flee ·成本chéngběn cost ·质量zhìliàng quality ·普及pǔjí popularisation ·远程yuǎochéng remote. Statistics approximate; consult the National Bureau of Statistics for current-year figures.

Vocabulary: cities and change

B	2
房租	fángzū
涨	zhǎng
通勤	tōngqín
机会	jīhuì
房价	fángjià
城镇化	chéngzhènhuà
吸引	xīyǐn
竞争	jìngzhēng
激烈	jīliè

B	2
逃离	táolí
成本	chéngběn
生活质量	shēnghuó zhìliàng
远程办公	yuǎnchéng bàngōng

Characters



Exercises

1. Join with越…越…:

   1. He earns more. He spends more. → ___

   2. The city is bigger. Life is lonelier. → ___

2. Add连…都:

   1.我忙得___(even)忘了吃饭。

   2.她___名字都写错了。

3. Concede then counter with A是A，但…:

   1. this phone: fast / battery bad

   2. his plan: cheap / hard to do

Communication task

Record a 2-minute“leave or stay”monologue about a city you know: costs, commute, opportunities, one连…都 complaint, one越…越… observation, and a便宜是便宜-style concession.

UNIT 3

成语里的人生

Chengyu: how four characters carry a story

In this unit you will learn to:

- recognise the fifty most common chengyu
- use five to eight of them naturally
- understand their historical sources
- avoid the classic learner mistake: overusing them

What a chengyu is

成语are mostly four-character idioms, many drawn from historical anecdotes, classical texts, or philosophical works.

They are not decoration: they are the fastest way to say something precise with a built-in story. An educated speaker uses them at a modest rate — a few per conversation — and always exactly right. The classic learner error is scattering them like confetti; it reads as showing off. Learn the core fifty passively, and let a handful become active.

Eight to make your own (with their sources)

B	2
画蛇添足	huà shé tiān zú
井底之蛙	jǐng dǐ zhī wā
一举两得	yì jǔ liǎng dé
半途而废	bàn tú ér fèi
入乡随俗	rù xiāng suí sú
水到渠成	shuǐ dào qú chéng
杯水车薪	bēi shuǐ chē xīn

B	2
卧薪尝胆	wò xīn cháng dǎn

Historical note: the first and last of these come from identifiable ancient sources (the Strategies of the Warring States战国策, and Sima Qian's Records of the Grand Historian史记respectively). When a chengyu's origin is genuinely ancient and documented, sources say so; when a story is a later folk attachment, we mark it as legend.



Chengyu in conversation are like Latin phrases in English legal writing: precise, respected, and exhausting in bulk. One well-placed画蛇添足is charming; five in a paragraph is a lecture. Also — most chengyu are fixed. You cannot swap characters inside them the way you swap words in a sentence. Learn them whole, like stones.

Reading: a paragraph using three of them

学语言最怕半途而废。很多人一开始热情很高，买了书，下了软件，可是三个月以后就放弃了。其实学习不需要“一举两得”的奇迹，只需要每天一点点：读一段，说几句，写两行。坚持下去，水到渠成。

1. Answer:

1. What is the biggest enemy of language learning, according to the text?

2. What does the writer say progress does NOT need?

3. Explain水到渠成in your own words (any language).

Vocabulary: idiom talk

B	2
成语	chéngyǔ
典故	diǎngù
来源	láiyuán
勉强	miǎnqiǎng
热情	rèqíng
坚持	jiānchí
放弃	fàngqì
奇迹	qíjì

Characters



Exercises

2. Match chengyu to situation:

1. A friend edits your message and makes it worse. → ___

2. Someone who has never left their hometown mocks other countries. → ___

3. You started a degree and quit in year two. → ___

3. Write one sentence for each:一举两得,半途而废,入乡随俗.

Communication task

Choose one chengyu and record a 60-second explanation for a learner below your level: the literal image, the story behind it, one modern example. Teaching it is how it becomes yours.

UNIT 4

网络时代的语言

Internet language, new words, and how fast Chinese changes

In this unit you will learn to:

- read contemporary online writing and its abbreviations
- understand how new words are formed in Chinese
- recognise language change without mistaking slang for standard
- discuss technology's effect on language

Dialogue: what does this mean?

马克

我朋友发来一条消息：“绝绝子！”这是什么意思?

Wǒ péngyou fālái yì tiáo xiāoxi:“Juéjuézi!”Zhè shì shénme yìsi?

A friend sent me a message:“juéjuézi!”What does that mean?

雨晨

这是网络用语，意思是“太棒了”。年轻人爱用。

Zhè shì wǎngluò yòngyǔ, yìsi shì“tài bàng le”. Niánqīngrén ài yòng.

That's internet slang — it means“amazing”. Young people love it.

马克

那“yyds”呢？看起来像拼音。

Nà“yyds”ne? Kàn qǐlái xiàng pīnyīn.

And“yyds”? It looks like pinyin.

雨晨

是“永远的神”的缩写——永远的神，意思是“最好的”。

Shì“yǒngyuǎn de shén”de suōxiě — yǒngyuǎn de shén, yìsi shì“zuì hǎo de”.

It's the abbreviation of“forever the god”— meaning“the best”.

马克

网络语言变得太快了。

Wǎngluò yǔyán biàn de tài kuài le.

Internet language changes too fast.

雨晨

所以学标准语就好，网络词看得懂就行，不用都会用。

Suǒyǐ xué biāozhǔnyǔ jiù hǎo, wǎngluò cí kàn de dǒng jiù xíng, bù yòng dōu huì yòng.

So just learn the standard language; being able to understand internet words is enough — no need to use them all.

How Chinese coins words

Chinese builds new words from old morphemes at a speed English can't match:电脑(“electric brain”, computer),手机(“hand machine”, mobile phone),直播(“direct broadcast”, livestreaming),内卷(“inward rolling”, from anthropology's“involution”, now meaning ruinous internal competition),躺平(“lying flat”, opting out of the rat race — a coinage of the early 2020s). Letter-abbreviations (yyds, xswl“笑死我了”“laughing to death”) behave like the pinyin of spoken phrases. Slang generations turn over in two or three years; the standard written language absorbs only a fraction of it.

Reading:内卷and躺平(adapted commentary)

“内卷”本来是人类学的术语，二〇二〇年前后在中国网络上流行起来，用来形容同行之间越来越激烈、却没有增加总价值的竞争。后来又出现了“躺平”——既然竞争的回报越来越少，有人选择降低欲望、少工作、少消费。这两个词很快进入了日常对话，甚至出现在官方媒体的讨论中。语言学家指出，流行词往往是社会心态的镜子：当一个词迅速走红的时候，值得问的是它背后的人在担心什么。

Gloss:术语shùyǔ technical term ·流行liúxíng popular ·形容xíngróng to describe ·激烈jīliè intense ·回报huífào reward ·欲望yùwàng desire ·消费xiāofèi consume ·心态xīntài mindset ·走红zǒuhóng to become popular.

Vocabulary: language and the internet

B	2
网络	wǎngluò
用语	yòngyǔ
缩写	suōxiě
流行	liúxíng
术语	shùyǔ
形容	xíngróng
回报	huíbào
欲望	yùwàng
心态	xīntài
走红	zǒuhóng

Characters

网 语 新

Exercises

1. Explain each coinage's logic in Chinese (or English if needed):电脑、手机、直播、躺平.

2. Answer:为什么流行词值得注意？用“是…的”写一句话。

3. Translate:

1. Slang changes too fast to keep up with.

2. It's enough to be able to read internet words; you don't need to use them.

3.“Lying flat” means lowering your desires and working less.

Communication task

Record a 90-second explainer of one slang term from your own language for a Chinese listener — in Chinese. Use是…的 once and one potential complement.

UNIT 5

健康与生活方式

Health, food systems, and quoting with说

In this unit you will learn to:

- discuss diet, exercise, and lifestyle trade-offs
- report speech with说and问我
- use不仅…而且… for layered claims
- read an adapted science-style article

Dialogue: the health check

马克

体检结果出来了：医生说我不仅要少吃糖，而且要多运动。

Tǐjiǎn jiéguǒ chūlái le: yīshēng shuō wǒ bùjǐn yào shǎo chī táng, érqiě yào duō yùndòng.

The health check is back: the doctor said I should not only eat less sugar but also exercise more.

雨晨

他还说什么了？

Tā hái shuō shénme le?

What else did he say?

马克

他问我平时几点睡觉，我说常常十二点以后。

Tā wèn wǒ píngshí jǐ diǎn shuìjiào, wǒ shuō chángcháng shí'èr diǎn yǐhòu.

He asked what time I usually sleep; I said often after midnight.

雨晨

难怪你最近总是累。

Nánguài nǐ zuìjìn zǒngshì lèi.

No wonder you're always tired lately.

马克

所以我打算每天走一万步，先把睡眠调好。

Suǒyǐ wǒ dǎsuàn měitiān zǒu yí wàn bù, xiān bǎ shuìmián tiáo hǎo.

So I plan to walk ten thousand steps a day and fix my sleep first.

雨晨

一步一步来，别太快。

Yíbù yíbù lái, bié tài kuài.

Step by step — not too fast.

Grammar: reported speech and layered claims

Chinese has no backshifting of tenses in reported speech: you quote with说for statements and问我for questions, and keep the original words:他说他没时间“he said he has no time”. Layered claims stack with不仅…而且… (“not only… but also…”), and难怪(“no wonder”) draws the everyday conclusion.

医生说我应该多喝水。Yīshēng shuō wǒ yīnggāi duō hē shuǐ.

The doctor said I should drink more water.

他问我为什么迟到。Tā wèn wǒ wèishénme chídào.

He asked me why I was late.

这不仅贵，而且没用。Zhè bùjǐn guì, érqiě méi yòng.

Reading: traditional and modern medicine (adapted)

中医在中国有几千年的历史，它的核心思想是“平衡”：身体不舒服，是因为体内的平衡被打乱了。西医大约在十九世纪进入中国，两种医学从此并存。今天，中国的大医院大多设有中医科，很多城市也有专门的中医药大学。有人生病时先看西医，再用中医调理；也有人相反。学术界对某些中药的疗效仍有争论，但针灸等疗法在世界范围内被广泛研究。对学习者来说，更有意思的是语言：中文里很多健康的说法都来自传统医学的思路，比如“上火”（身体里“火”太多了）。

Gloss:体检tǐjiǎn medical check-up ·核心想hésī core idea ·平衡pínghéng balance ·打乱pāluàn to disrupt ·并存bìngcún coexist ·针灸zhēnjiǔ acupuncture ·疗法liáofǎ therapy ·疗效liáoxiào efficacy ·争论zhēnglùn debate ·调理tiáolǐ to nurse/regulate ·上火shànghuǒ“rising fire”. Cultural-linguistic note:上火remains a common everyday self-diagnosis; medicine's view of it is a separate question — we present the term, not a medical endorsement.

Vocabulary: health and habits

B	2
体检	tǐjiǎn
医生	yīshēng
糖	táng
运动	yùndòng
睡眠	shuìmián
难怪	nánguài
总是	zǒngshì
调理	tiáolǐ
平衡	pínghéng
针灸	zhēnjiǔ
疗效	liáoxiào

B	2
争论	zhēnglùn

Characters



Exercises

1. Report each with说or问我:

1. “我很累。”(He said…) → ___
2. “你为什么迟到？”(She asked me…) → ___
3. “少吃糖。”(The doctor told me…) → ___

2. Join with不仅…而且…:

1. This habit is bad. It is expensive. → ___
2. She speaks Chinese. She writes it well. → ___

3. Translate:

1. No wonder you're always tired.
2. The doctor said I should not only eat less sugar but also fix my sleep.
3. Step by step — not too fast.

Communication task

Record a 90-second report of a conversation you really had this week (in any language), reported in Chinese with说/问我, plus one难怪conclusion and one不仅…而且… sentence.

UNIT 6

环境与责任

Environment, choices, and无论…都…

In this unit you will learn to:

- discuss environmental topics with nuance
- use无论/不管…都… for “no matter”
- use除了…以外for “besides”
- read an adapted policy-style text

Dialogue: the takeaway dilemma

马克

现在的外卖太多了，塑料盒一天就是几亿个。

Xiànzài de wàimài tài duō le, sùliào hé yì tiān jiù shì jǐ yì ge.

There's so much food delivery now — hundreds of millions of plastic boxes a day.

雨晨

对，很多城市已经限制塑料袋了。

Duì, hěn duō chéngshì yǐjīng xiànzhì sùliào dài le.

Yes — many cities have already restricted plastic bags.

马克

可是无论政策怎么规定，点外卖还是最方便的。

Kěshì wúlùn zhèngcè zěnme guīdìng, diǎn wàimài háishì zuì fāngbiàn de.

But no matter what the rules say, delivery is still the most convenient.

雨晨

所以除了政策以外，还得靠消费者自己选择。

Suǒyǐ chúle zhèngcè yǐwài, hái děi kào xiāofèizhě zìjǐ xuǎnzé.

So besides policy, it also depends on consumers' own choices.

马克

有的平台现在可以选“无需餐具”。

Yǒu de píngtái xiànzài kěyǐ xuǎn“wúxū cānjù”.

Some platforms now let you choose“no cutlery needed”.

雨晨

这就是一步。不管多小，都是进步。

Zhè jiùshì yí bù. Bùguǎn duō xiǎo, dōu shì jìnbù.

That's a step. However small, it's progress.

Grammar:无论/不管…都… and除了…以外

无论and不管(interchangeable) mean“no matter / regardless”, and the sentence always continues with都or也:无论多贵，我都要买“however expensive, I'll buy it”.除了…(以外) means“besides/in addition”with还/也, or“except”with a bare negative:除了他以外，我们都去了“except him, we all went”.

无论多难，都不放弃。Wúlùn duō nán, dōu bù fàngqì.

However hard, never give up.

不管你去不去，我都要去。Bùguǎn nǐ qù bu qù, wǒ dōu yào qù.

Whether you go or not, I'm going.

除了中文以外，她还学法语。Chúle Zhōngwén yǐwài, tā hái xué Fǎyǔ.

Reading: delivery economy (adapted)

中国的外卖行业是世界上规模最大的之一：数亿人每周点几次外卖。这带来了方便，也带来了新的环境问题——塑料垃圾。二〇二〇年前后，多个城市出台了更严格的限塑规定，比如禁止一次性塑料吸管。与此同时，外卖平台增加了“无需餐具”的选项，一些城市开始试点可回收餐具。环境学者指出，真正的问题不是外卖本身，而是一次性文化：当“方便”成为最重要的价值时，任何环保措施都会遇到阻力。

Gloss:外卖wàimài food delivery ·塑料sùliào plastic ·垃圾lājī rubbish ·限塑xiànsù plastic restriction ·一次性yícìxìng disposable ·吸管xīguǎn straw ·试点shìdiǎn pilot programme ·可回收kě huíshōu recyclable ·措施cuòshī measure ·阻力zǔlì resistance.

Vocabulary: environment

B	2
外卖	wàimài
塑料	sùliào
垃圾	lājī
环境	huánjìng
政策	zhèngcè
限制	xiànzhì
消费者	xiāofèizhě
平台	píngtái
餐具	cānjù
一次性	yícìxìng
回收	huíshōu
措施	cuòshī

Characters

环境绿

Exercises

1. Complete with无论/不管…都:

   1. ___天气怎么样，比赛___要举行。

   2. ___他怎么说，我___不相信。

2. Complete with除了…以外:

   1. ___英语以外，他___会说德语。

   2. ___我以外，大家都到了。

3. Translate:

   1. However small, it's progress.

   2. Besides policy, it depends on consumers' choices.

   3. The real problem is not delivery itself but disposable culture.

Communication task

Record a 2-minute position on one environmental habit (delivery cutlery, fast fashion, food waste): the problem, one policy angle, one无论…都… objection, your personal rule. Use除了…以外once.

UNIT 7

人工智能与翻译

AI, work, and the面对pattern

In this unit you will learn to:

- discuss AI and its effect on work
- use面对and面临for facing situations
- use有可能/恐怕for hedged predictions
- read a technology article

Dialogue: the translator's question

马克

机器翻译越来越好了，你的工作会受影响吗?

Jīqì fānyì yuèláiyuè hǎo le, nǐ de gōngzuò huì shòu yǐngxiǎng ma?

Machine translation keeps improving — will your work be affected?

雨晨

会有影响，但译者面对的不是“机器还是人”的选择。

Huì yǒu yǐngxiǎng, dàn yìzhě miànduì de bù shì“jīqì háishì rén”de xuǎnzé.

There will be an effect, but what translators face isn't a“machine or human”choice.

马克

那是什么?

Nà shì shénme?

Then what is it?

雨晨

是“怎么用机器”的问题。工具变了，职业也变了。

Shì“zěnme yòng jīqì”de wèntí. Gōngjù biàn le, zhíyè yě biàn le.

It's the question of how to use the tools. The tools changed, so the profession changed.

马克

你觉得以后还需要人工翻译吗?

Nǐ juéde yǐhòu hái xūyào réngōng fānyì ma?

Do you think human translation will still be needed?

雨晨

恐怕高难度的文本永远需要人，比如诗歌和法律。

Kǒngpà gāo nándù de wénběn yǒngyuǎn xūyào rén, bǐrú shīgē hé fǎlǜ.

I'm afraid difficult texts will always need humans — poetry and law, for instance.

Grammar:面对/面临; hedging with恐怕/有可能

面对(facing, confronting — often a challenge) and面临(confronted with — often a crisis or choice) take abstract objects:

面对困难，面对问题；面临选择，面临危机. Hedge predictions with恐怕(“I'm afraid…”),有可能(“possibly”), and

大概(“probably”): the academic register of a hedged claim is a mark of maturity in any language.

Reading: machine translation (adapted)

机器翻译的历史比很多人想的要长：二十世纪五十年代就出现了最早的实验系统。二〇一〇年代，深度学习让

翻译质量飞跃式提高，今天的神经网络系统在很多日常文本上已经接近人工水平。但是研究者指出，机器翻译

的弱点也很清楚：文化背景、幽默、诗歌、法律中的微妙差别，都还是难题。更重要的是责任问题：当翻译出

错时，谁来负责？因此，很多专家认为，未来的模式不是“人或者机器”，而是“人加机器”：机器做初稿，人做判断。

Gloss:深度学习shēndù xuéxí deep learning ·飞跃fēiyuè leap ·神经网络shénjīng wǎngluò neural network ·接近jiējìn approach ·微妙wēimiào subtle ·责任zérèn responsibility ·初稿chūgǎo first draft ·判断pànduàn judgement.

Vocabulary: technology and work

B	2
机器	jīqì
翻译	fānyì
影响	yǐngxiǎng
面对	miànduì
面临	miànlín
职业	zhíyè
恐怕	kǒngpà
微妙	wēimiào
责任	zérèn
判断	pànduàn
工具	gōngjù

Characters



Exercises

1. Choose面对or面临:

1.公司___最大的危机。

2.我们要___现实，想办法。

3.毕业生___很多选择。

2. Hedge each:

1.以后没有人需要司机。(恐怕)

2. AI会改变教育。(有可能)

3.他今晚来不了。(大概)

3. Translate:

1. What translators face is not a“machine or human”choice.

2. The tools changed, so the profession changed.

3. I'm afraid poetry will always need humans.

Communication task

Record a 2-minute take on how AI affects your own job or studies: what changed, one面对/面临sentence, one hedged prediction (恐怕/有可能), and one concrete adaptation you are making.

UNIT 8

写信和邮件

Formal register, letters, and emails

In this unit you will learn to:

- write a well-structured Chinese email
- understand formal openings and closings
- adjust register between message and letter
- use敬语and humble forms appropriately

The anatomy of a Chinese formal email

Chinese business email keeps a stricter skeleton than English. Learn this frame; it will carry you through job applications, professor emails, and customer service alike:

称呼：尊敬的王教授：— always a colon, never a comma.

开头：您好！您好，打扰了。State why you are writing in the first line.

正文：…请问…麻烦您…请您… Use您throughout.

结尾请求：非常感谢您的时间。期待您的回复。

署名：此致敬礼！(on separate lines) Your name + date.此致敬礼is the standard letter closing; in email, a simple谢谢/祝好+ name is normal.

禁忌：Don't use哈/啦particles; don't abbreviate the addressee's name; don't open with你(use您or the title).

Model email with notes

尊敬的刘老师：您好！我是您星期三中文课的学生马克。因为下周三我要回国参加家人的婚礼，所以想请假一次。我会自己看录像补课，也会把作业按时交上。给您添麻烦了，非常感谢您的理解。此致敬礼！马克10月23日

Notes:给您添麻烦了(“sorry to trouble you”) is the humble formula that buys goodwill;按时(“on time”) shows reliability before being asked; the request names the absence, the remedy, and the gratitude in four lines. Copy this economy.

Register ladder: same message, three levels

B	2
给朋友	—
给同事	—
给教授	—

Vocabulary: correspondence

B	2
尊敬的	zūnjìng de
打扰	dǎrǎo
请假	qǐngjià
按时	ànshí
回复	huífù
此致敬礼	cǐzhì jìnglǐ
理解	lǐjiě
麻烦您	máfan nín
署名	shǔmíng

Characters



Exercises

1. Rewrite this casual message at the formal level:“老师，我不能来上课，生病了。”(structure: salutation, greeting, reason, remedy, closing, sign-off)
2. Label each line of the model email with its function (salutation / reason / remedy / closing / signature).
3. Write a formal email requesting an extension on a deadline, in six lines.

Communication task

Record yourself reading your formal email aloud — reading formal register aloud is how it enters your speaking. Then rewrite it as a two-line text to a close friend and record that too; listen to the register difference.

Revision

复习：从对话到篇章

Consolidate Stage B2

The B2 pattern inventory

- 是…的— highlight the circumstances of a known past event.
- 越…越… — correlated change;越来越… — ongoing change.
- 连…都/也—“even”; A是A，但… — concede then counter.
- 不仅…而且… — layered claims;难怪— everyday inference.
- 无论/不管…都… —“no matter”;除了…(以外) —“besides/except”.
- 面对/面临— facing challenges;恐怕/有可能/大概— hedged claims.
- Reported speech with说/问我; formal register:您,请,麻烦您,此致敬礼.

Reading discipline at B2

You should now read a page of adapted Chinese with a dictionary and finish with the main point in your head without translating. Test: take this book's own Unit 6 reading (delivery economy) and summarise it aloud in four sentences — from memory, book closed. If you can, you're reading; if you can't, you're decoding. Both are fine, but only one is B2.



The single biggest B2 habit: daily reading outside the textbook. Ten minutes of a real article, a news app, or a Chinese social feed — with a dictionary — outperforms another hour of exercises. From here on, the world is your textbook; I'm just your guide.

Assessment

Stage B2 Assessment

Closed-book

Part 1 · Listening-style comprehension (script)

记者

请问您觉得外卖平台该不该为环保负责?

Qǐngwèn nín juéde wàimài píngtái gāi bu gāi wèi huánbǎo fùzé?

Excuse me — do you think delivery platforms should be responsible for the environment?

路人

我觉得不仅是平台的问题，消费者也有责任。

Wǒ juéde bùjǐn shì píngtái de wèntí, xiāofèizhě yě yǒu zérèn.

I think it's not only a platform question; consumers have responsibility too.

记者

但是无论平台怎么做，点外卖的人还是越来越多。

Dànshì wúlùn píngtái zěnme zuò, diǎn wàimài de rén háishì yuèláiyuè duō.

But no matter what platforms do, more and more people order delivery.

路人

对，所以除了政策以外，教育也很重要。

Duì, suǒyǐ chúle zhèngcè yǐwài, jiàoyù yě hěn zhòngyào.

Right — so besides policy, education matters too.

记者

谢谢您接受采访。

Xièxie nín jiēshòu cǎifǎng.

Thank you for accepting the interview.

1.

Answer:

1. Who does the interviewee say bears responsibility?

2. What does the reporter point out about delivery's growth?

3. What third factor does the interviewee add?

Part 2 · Reading

有一位译者说过，她的工作不是“翻译词语”，而是“翻译文化”。她认为，机器可以处理一般的句子，但是面对诗歌和法律的时候，恐怕还需要人来判断。她的观点是：工具改变了职业，但不会取消职业。那些说“翻译会消失”的人，往往是井底之蛙：他们只看到今天的软件，没看到明天的需求。

2.

Answer:

1. What does the translator say her job really is?

2. Which two text types does she mention as needing humans?

3. What does井底之蛙imply about people who say translation will vanish?

Part 3 · Grammar

3. Rewrite with the pattern in brackets:

1.她是2019年来北京的。(是…的, highlight the year) → ___

2.这个城市很大。这个城市很拥挤。(越…越… does not fit; use不仅…而且…) → ___

3.政策怎么变，我都要自己选择。(无论…都…) → ___

4. Translate into Chinese:

1. Not only the platform but also consumers bear responsibility.

2. I'm afraid the difficult texts will always need a human.

3. It was in Singapore that I learned to appreciate Cantonese food.

4. Besides policy, education is also important.

Part 4 · Writing and speaking (self-assessed)

Write a structured opinion piece (15–18 sentences): topic of your choice from this stage (education pressure, cities, AI and work, environment). Structure: situation, two sides with connectives, your position, one concession, one hedged prediction. Record it. Model and criteria in the answer key.

Pass guide: Parts 1–3 at 80%+; the writing argues, not just describes.

STAGE C1

流利

Fluency

— understand authentic articles, essays, and broadcasts on general topics

— argue a position with concessions, evidence, and rebuttals

— command register shifts:从聊天到书面语

— read classical-flavoured modern prose and simple文言fragments

— discuss literature, film, and society with nuance; write structured essays

At C1, pinyin disappears except for rare readings. You should be reading Chinese as Chinese.

UNIT 1

郑和下西洋

A historical narrative; classical particles in modern prose

In this unit you will learn to:

- read a full historical narrative with literary vocabulary
- understand之、其、所in classical-flavoured prose
- summarise a long passage in your own words
- discuss exploration and exchange

Reading: Zheng He's voyages (adapted, glossed)

一四〇五年，明朝的船队从南京出发，开始了第一次远航。带领船队的，是一位名叫郑和的宦官。在之后的二十八年里，他先后七次出海，最远到达了东非海岸。船队的规模在当时的世界上无出其右：大船数百艘，人员两万七千余人。他们带去的是丝绸、瓷器和茶叶，带回来的是香料、宝石，以及沿途各国的使节。

历史学家对郑和远航的目的有不同的看法：有人强调外交——“宣威于海外”；有人强调贸易；也有人指出，寻找失势的建文帝可能是原因之一。但无论目的如何，其结果之一是明确的：十五世纪的中国，一度掌握了世界上最大的海上力量，却选择了在远航之后逐渐收缩。几十年后，欧洲的小船队绕过好望角，历史走向了另一条路。

Gloss:宦官huànguān eunuch ·远航yuǎnháng long voyage ·先后xiānhòu successively ·东非Dōngfēi East Africa ·无出其右wú chū qí yòu “none surpassed it” ·瓷器cíqì porcelain ·香料xiāngliào spices ·使节shǐjié envoys ·宣威xuānwēi to display power abroad ·失势shīshì to lose power ·收缩shōusuō to contract ·好望角Hǎowàngjiǎo Cape of Good Hope. Historical facts: voyages 1405–1433, seven in total; reaches included the East African coast; the “search for the deposed Jianwen emperor” is one traditional explanation recorded in Ming documents and debated by historians.

Classical particles in modern prose

Even in modern writing, a classical flavour survives in function words you must recognise:之(a formal的),其(formal他的/它的/their),者(the one who),所(marks the object of the verb before的),与(formal和). The reading above uses其twice.

Spot them in these pairs:

C	1
远航的目的	…的目的
他的结果	…的结果
看到的人	看到的人
和/与	和(spoken)

Summarising at C1

The skill this stage demands: read a page, then say the argument back in three sentences — your words, not the author's.

Practice now: summarise the passage above aloud in three sentences: scale, debated purposes, historical consequence.

Record it, then check against the key.

Vocabulary: history and navigation

C	1
航海	hánghǎi
船队	chuánduì
出发	chūfā
规模	guīmó
人员	rényuán
丝绸	sīchóu
瓷器	cíqì
香料	xiāngliào
使节	shǐjié
外交	wàijiāo
收缩	shōusuō
海岸	hǎi'àn

Characters



Exercises

1. Rewrite each phrase in the formal register with the classical particle given:

   1.船队的目的(之) → ___

   2.船队的规模(其) → ___

   3.看到的风景(所…者) → ___

2. Answer in Chinese, in full sentences:郑和的船队和后来欧洲的船队有什么不同？历史学家为什么对远航的目的有争论?

3. Summarise the passage in three written Chinese sentences.

Communication task

Record a 3-minute mini-lecture on a historical journey you know well (Chinese or not): the traveller, the scale, the purposes, one debated question, one consequence. Use one formal-register phrase and one chengyu.

UNIT 2

茶馆里的社会

Literature: Lao She's Teahouse and reading fiction

In this unit you will learn to:

- read an adapted literary extract with dialect notes
- discuss character and social change
- understand潜台词(subtext) in dialogue
- use随着for gradual change

Reading: Teahouse, Act One (adapted, glossed)

老舍的《茶馆》写于一九五六年，三幕戏写了一个茶馆和它的三个时代。第一幕的故事发生在一八九八年的“裕泰茶馆”。掌柜王利发精明、圆滑，对每个人都能笑脸相迎；但他心里明白，这年月做买卖不容易。茶客里有提笼架鸟的旗人，有做买卖的商人，也有主张实业救国的改良者。

台词节选（改编）：王利发：“多说好话，多请安，讨人人的喜欢，就不会出大乱子！”常四爷：“我爱咱们的国呀，可是谁爱我呢？”

Gloss:掌柜zhǎngguì shopkeeper ·精明jīngmíng shrewd ·圆滑yuánhuá slick, worldly ·旗人qírén Manchu bannermen (a historical term) · 改良gǎiliáng reform ·实业shíyè industry ·请安qǐng'ān to pay respects (a Qing-era courtesy). Background: the play (1957) tracks a Beijing teahouse from 1898 through the early Republic to the 1940s; the line by Chang Siye is among the most quoted in modern

Chinese theatre. Lao She died in 1966; the play was revived in 1979 and staged internationally.

The subtext skill

Literary dialogue rarely says what it means.王利发's line — “say nice things, bow often, please everybody, and there'll be no great trouble” — reads as practical advice but plays as tragedy: a decent man surviving by surrendering dignity.常四爷's line says the opposite and is equally doomed. When you read Chinese drama, ask three questions: who is speaking to whom in front of whom; what era's rules press on the words; what the character cannot say.

Grammar:随着— gradual change over time

随着(“along with”) frames a change that unfolds as circumstances change:随着时代的变化，茶馆的命运也改变了“as the times changed, the teahouse's fate changed too”. It anchors essays about society and history.

Vocabulary: literature and society

C	1
戏剧	xìjù
幕	mù
茶馆	cháguǎn
掌柜	zhǎngguì
台词	táicí
时代	shídài
命运	mìngyùn
悲剧	bēijù
改编	gǎibiān
潜台词	qiántáicí
随着	suízhe

Characters

戏剧文□□

Exercises

1. Explain in Chinese what王利发's strategy is, and why the playwright presents it as tragic rather than wise.

2. Use随着in two sentences about changes in your own city over twenty years.

3. Translate:

   1. As the times changed, the teahouse's customers changed too.

   2. He is shrewd but not unkind.

   3. The most quoted line in modern Chinese theatre comes from this play.

Communication task

Record a 3-minute discussion of a play, film, or novel you know: setting, one character's strategy, one line of dialogue and its subtext, why it matters. Use随着and one chengyu.

UNIT 3

方言与普通话

Chinese varieties, accents, and identity

In this unit you will learn to:

- discuss dialects, accents, and standard language policy
- understand claims about language and identity
- read an interview-format article
- use倒and却for contrastive turns

Reading: an interview about dialect (adapted)

记者：很多人说，现在的年轻人不太会说方言了。您怎么看？语言学者：这个观察基本是对的。随着普通话的推广，大城市的年轻人确实更多使用普通话。但是“不会说”和“不说”是两回事：有些人听得懂，只是选择不说；有些人是真的不会了。记者：方言会消失吗？语言学者：这要看我们怎么做。语言的活力不在于保护政策，而在于有没有人愿意在真实的场合用它——在家里，在市场，在相声里，在歌里。政策可以给时间，但救不了一门语言。

Gloss:方言fāngyán regional variety ·推广tuīguǎng promotion ·场合chǎnghé occasion ·相声xiàngsheng crosstalk comedy ·活力huólì vitality. Background: the PRC has promoted Putonghua since the 1950s; at the same time it runs a large-scale documentation project

for endangered Chinese languages and dialects. In Taiwan, a Hakka-language revival movement and indigenous-language revitalisation are active policy areas; Hong Kong sees ongoing public debate about Cantonese's role. All are contemporary, evolving situations.

Grammar: contrastive turns with倒and却

倒(dào) marks a turn against expectation, often subjective (“actually, surprisingly”):他倒不生气“he actually isn't angry”.却(què) is the written-flavoured“yet/however”placed before the verb:他很累，却继续工作“he was exhausted, yet kept working”. They are not interchangeable with但是in these flavour-roles; learn the feel, not just the rule.

他倒不着急。Tā dào bù zháojí.

> He, surprisingly, isn't worried.

她很累，却坚持下来。Tā hěn lèi, què jiānchí xiàlái.

> She was exhausted, yet persisted.

保护政策倒是有，但是没用。Bǎohù zhèngcè dào shì yǒu, dànshì méi yòng.

> There are protection policies, as it happens — but they don't work.

Vocabulary: language and identity

C	1
方言	fāngyán
口音	kǒuyīn
母语	mǔyǔ
推广	tuīguǎng
消失	xiāoshī
保护	bǎohù
活力	huólì

C	1
身份	shēnfèn
场合	chǎnghé
观察	guānchá

Characters



Exercises

1. Choose倒or却:

   1.他很有钱，___不快乐。

   2.你___提醒我了，我差点忘了。

   3.很多人说方言要消失了，___有人在写方言歌。

2. Answer in Chinese:学者认为什么才能真正救一门语言？政策的作用是什么？

3. Translate:

   1.“Can't speak”and“doesn't speak”are two different things.

   2. Policy can buy time, but it cannot save a language.

   3. With Putonghua's spread, dialect use has genuinely declined in big cities.

Communication task

Record a 3-minute reflection on a language or dialect you have a connection to: its status, one thing being done to keep it

alive, your view with one例/却turn. Interview yourself, both roles.

UNIT 4

丝绸之路上的食物

Food history, and writing descriptive exposition

In this unit you will learn to:

- read a food-history exposition
- write descriptive passages with texture
- use由…组成and构成for composition
- handle时而…时而… variation

Reading: how the tomato got to China (adapted)

今天的中国菜里，番茄炒蛋几乎是一道“国菜”。但番茄并不是中国原产的植物。它原产于南美洲，十六世纪前后经由海路传入中国，最初被当作观赏植物，被称为“番茄”——“外来的茄子”。把它端上餐桌，是很晚的事：清代的文献里才逐渐出现食用的记载，而番茄炒蛋真正成为家常菜，是二十世纪中叶以后的事了。

类似的故事还有很多：辣椒从美洲传入，先在贵州生根，替代了昂贵的盐，然后才有了今天的川菜和湘菜；花生和玉米从海外到来，改变了中国南方的山地农业。一部中国饮食史，半部是交流史。食物沿着商路和海路移动，比人更早到达，比文字更容易留下痕迹。

Gloss:原产yuánchǎn indigenous to ·经由jīngyóu via ·观赏guānshǎng ornamental ·记载jìzǎi written record ·家常菜jiāchángcài

home-style dish ·辣椒làjiāo chilli ·生根shēnggēn take root ·山地shāndì mountain land ·痕迹hénjì trace. Historical notes: the chilli reached China around the late 16th century; Guizhou's use of chilli as a salt substitute in poor households is documented in Qing-era local gazetteers — a well-known example in food history.

Grammar: composition and variation

由…组成(“is composed of”):一顿家常菜由三四个菜组成.构成(“constitute”) is its formal twin.时而…时而… (“now… now…”):菜谱时而清淡，时而辛辣— for fluctuation, not for change over time.

Writing workshop: the descriptive exposition

Write one paragraph (6–8 sentences) about a dish's history: where it came from, what it displaced or joined, how it became ordinary. Rules: no adverb stronger than很, at least one由…组成, one时而…时而…, and a final sentence that turns from food to people — the way the model reading does (“食物…比文字更容易留下痕迹”).



The last-sentence turn is the essay move that separates C1 writing from B2 writing: gather your facts, then lift your eyes.练习方法：每次写完一段，删掉最后一句，重写一句更有重量的。

Vocabulary: food history

C	1
番茄	fānqié
原产	yuánchǎn
传入	chuánrù
观赏	guānshǎng
记载	jìzǎi
家常菜	jiāchángcài
辣椒	làjiāo
代替	dàitì
痕迹	hénjì
交流	jiāoliú

Characters



Exercises

1. Use由…组成to describe: a family dinner; a company's team; a classical orchestra.

2. Use时而…时而… about: your city's weather; a teacher's moods; stock prices.

3. Translate:

   1. Chilli was first adopted as a substitute for expensive salt.

   2. A history of Chinese food is half a history of exchange.

   3. It took centuries before the tomato reached the dinner table.

Communication task

Record your descriptive-exposition paragraph aloud. Then deliver it again in 60% of the time, keeping every fact.

Compression is the final polish.

UNIT 5

电影《活着》

Film discussion: narrating, evaluating, and the“since/because”cluster

In this unit you will learn to:

- discuss a film's story, theme, and craft
- narrate plot compactly with将and把
- evaluate with值得/不愧/在于
- use归根结底for final analysis

Reading: a film review (adapted, glossed)

张艺谋的《活着》（1994）改编自余华的小说，讲述了福贵一家在几十年动荡中的命运。影片的价值不在于控诉，而在于呈现：一个普通家庭如何在时代的浪潮里，一次一次失去，又一次一次活下去。有人说这是张艺谋最好的作品之一，因为它把宏大的历史压进了一个家庭的饭桌。

值得注意的是影片的叙事方式：福贵从不分析自己的遭遇，他只是继续活着。这恰恰是主题所在——正如片名所暗示的，活着本身就是答案。

Gloss:改编自gǎibiān zì adapted from ·动荡dòngdàng upheaval ·控诉kòngsù to denounce ·呈现chéngxiàn to present ·浪潮làngcháo wave ·饭桌fànzhuō dinner table ·宏大hóngdà grand ·叙事xùshì narrative ·遭遇zāoyù ordeals ·暗示ànshì to hint. Background: the film, based on Yu Hua's 1993 novel, was completed in 1994 and won the Grand Prix at Cannes; it was not released theatrically in mainland

China. Where you can lawfully watch it in your region is your call; for study purposes, knowing the film's place in Chinese cinema is itself worthwhile.

Grammar: worth, essence, and final analysis

Evaluation language at C1:值得(“worth doing”:值得一看“worth watching”),不愧为(“lives up to the name”:不愧为经典“truly a classic”), (价值)在于… (“the value lies in…”),归根结底(“in the final analysis”). These four carry a whole review's argument.

Narrating plot:将and compact storytelling

In written retellings,将often replaces把:影片将几十年的动荡压进两个小时的画面. Also useful:一…又… (“one… then another…”):一次一次失去，又一次一次活下去— repetition structures carry the rhythm of a life.

Vocabulary: film and evaluation

C	1
影片	yǐngpiàn
命运	mìngyùn
动荡	dòngdàng
控诉	kòngsù
呈现	chéngxiàn
浪潮	làngcháo
宏大	hóngdà
叙事	xùshì
遭遇	zāoyù
值得	zhídé
不愧	bùkuì
归根结底	guīgēn jiédǐ

Characters



Exercises

1. Evaluate with the four tools:

   1. a film you admire (值得)

   2. a book called a classic (不愧为)

   3. the value of learning history (在于)

   4. your view of a trend (归根结底)

2. Retell a film's plot in four sentences, using将once.

3. Translate:

   1. The film's value lies not in accusation but in presentation.

   2. It compressed decades of upheaval into one family's dinner table.

   3. Living on, as the title hints, is itself the answer.

Communication task

Record a 3-minute film review: one-sentence plot, two craft observations, one theme with归根结底, one reservation. No spoilers in the first 30 seconds.

UNIT 6

书法与设计

Calligraphy and design: aesthetics in language

Reading: why calligraphy still matters (adapted)

在数字化时代，写字的机会越来越少，但书法反而越来越受关注。这看起来矛盾，其实不然：正因为键盘替代了手，人们才开始重新思考“手写”的意义。书法不是把字写好看，而是用时间、力气和呼吸去组织空间——一个字的结构，是几千年来无数人审美判断的总和。

设计师也早就发现了这一点。中文字体设计的难度在于：每一个字都要单独设计，几千个字又要保持统一的气质。一款好的中文字体，往往要做五六年。从某种意义上说，每一个用中文写作的人，都在享受几千年审美劳动的成果。

Gloss:数字化shùzìhuà digitisation ·矛盾máodùn contradiction ·结构jiégòu structure ·审美shěnměi aesthetic ·气质qìzhì temperament, character ·统一tǒngyī unified. Note: the typefaces used in the book you are holding (Source Sans 3 and Noto Serif SC) are themselves the products of multi-year type-design projects — living examples of the reading's point.

Grammar:并不矛盾—“it is not that…”structures

C1 argumentation often needs to reject a surface contradiction:看起来…其实不然(“looks like… but actually not”),并不是…而是…(“not… but…”),正因为…才…(“precisely because… therefore”). These keep an essay from flat

statement into actual reasoning.

Vocabulary: aesthetics

C	1
书法	shūfǎ
设计	shèjì
矛盾	máodùn
结构	jiégòu
审美	shěnměi
气质	qìzhì
字体	zìtǐ
统一	tǒngyī
成果	chéngguǒ
呼吸	hūxī

Characters



Exercises

1. Argue with the reasoning structures:

   1. e-books vs paper books (看起来…其实不然)

   2. handwritten vs typed notes (并不是…而是…)

   3. why difficulty can attract learners (正因为…才…)

2. Translate:

1. Calligraphy is not making characters pretty; it is organising space with time, strength, and breath.

2. Precisely because keyboards replaced hands, people began to rethink handwriting.

3. Every writer in Chinese enjoys the fruit of millennia of aesthetic labour.

Communication task

Record a 3-minute talk: one traditional art (calligraphy, guqin, paper-cutting, tea ceremony…) and its modern fate, using all three reasoning structures.

UNIT 7

老龄化社会

Demographics, policy, and the concessive essay

In this unit you will learn to:

- read a data-driven feature article
- write concessive essays (让步与转折)
- use未必and并非for gentle negation
- cite numbers naturally in speech

Reading: the ageing society (adapted)

中国的老龄化速度在人类历史上是少见的。二十年前，人们讨论的是“人口太多”；今天，讨论的已经是“老龄化”和“少子化”。劳动人口在减少，养老金的压力在增加，与此同时，年轻人的生育意愿却在下降。

各国给出的答案并不相同：有的依靠移民，有的依靠技术，有的依靠延迟退休。但任何政策都无法改变一个事实：一个社会可以在二十年内变富，却无法在二十年内变老得慢。归根结底，老龄化不是问题，而是成就——人类第一次让大多数人活到了老年。我们需要回答的，不是“怎么办”，而是“怎样办得好”。

Gloss:老龄化lǎolínghuà ageing (of a population) ·少子化shàozǐhuà declining birth rate ·养老金yǎnglǎojīn pension ·生育意愿shēngyù yìyuàn fertility intention ·延迟退休yánchí tuìxiū later retirement ·移民yímín immigration. Statistics intentionally not quoted here: demographic figures change yearly and are contested; for study purposes, read the most recent official and UN projections.

Grammar: gentle negation未必/并非

未必(“not necessarily”) and并非(“is not, in fact”) soften or correct a claim without blunt denial:政策未必有效“policies are not necessarily effective”;老龄化并非危机“ageing is not, in fact, a crisis”. These are the essayist's scalpel — use them when you respect the other side.

Essay pattern: concession to reversal

The strongest C1 essay move: concede fully, then reverse. Model skeleton:诚然，…。但值得注意的是，…。归根结底，…。Write one paragraph on a topic of your choice with this skeleton; the model in the answer key uses the reading's own ending as its reversal.

Vocabulary: demographics

C	1
人口	rénkǒu
老龄化	lǎolínghuà
劳动人口	láodòng rénkǒu
养老金	yǎnglǎojīn
生育	shēngyù
延迟	yánchí
退休	tuìxiū
依靠	yīkào
事实	shìshí
成就	chéngjiù

Characters

老人口□□

Exercises

1. Rewrite bluntly negative sentences with未必/并非:

   1.这个政策没用。→这个政策未必…

   2.老龄化是危机。→老龄化并非…

   3.技术解决不了一切。→技术未必…

2. Write the concession-to-reversal paragraph on: remote work, electric cars, or social media.

3. Translate:

   1. A society can grow rich in twenty years but cannot age more slowly in twenty.

   2. Ageing is not a problem but an achievement.

   3. The question is not what to do, but how to do it well.

Communication task

Record a 3-minute debate with yourself on a demographic or social trend: 60 seconds for, 60 seconds against, 60 seconds of your real position using未必and the concession skeleton.

UNIT 8

申请信与演讲稿

Formal writing: applications and speech drafts

In this unit you will learn to:

- write a formal application letter
- write a short speech draft
- control tone: confident without arrogance
- edit your own Chinese at length

Reading: a grant application (adapted)

尊敬的评审委员会：您好！本人马克·安德森，拟申请贵会二〇二六年度“青年研究者”资助。研究方向为机器翻译在文学文本中的边界，计划在十二个月内完成三项工作：文献综述、实验设计与一篇会议论文。本人曾于二〇二三年发表相关论文一篇，并主持过一个小型翻译语料库项目。若蒙资助，本人将按计划推进，并在项目结束后提交完整报告。随信附上研究计划与简历。恳请审阅，盼复。此致敬礼！马克·安德森2025年10月23日

Notes:贵会(“your esteemed committee”) and恳请(“respectfully request”) are fixed humble forms;若蒙资助(“should I be granted…”) is the classical-flavoured conditional that formal applications still use;盼复replaces the blunt请回复. Note how

the applicant names deliverables and dates — formal Chinese rewards concreteness even more than English does.

Speech drafts

A speech opens with address and a hook, not with thanks (thanks come second):各位老师、各位同学：大家好。今天我想从一个很小的问题开始… Then one thesis sentence early, evidence in the middle, and a closing that returns to the hook. Avoid the陷阱of ending with谢谢大家followed by nothing — end with the idea, then thank.

Self-editing checklist

Register check: no啊/呢/吧particles in formal text;您for any addressee you don't know personally.

Sentence length: vary. A long sentence followed by a four-character punchline is the rhythm of good Chinese prose.

Delete得很and非常where the verb is already strong.

Check every是…的you wrote: is it the highlight pattern or a plain copula?

Read aloud once. Anything you stumble on, the reader stumbles on too.



C1 editing is not fixing errors — you make fewer of those now. C1 editing is cutting. Write 400 characters, then find the 320 that were doing the work.

Vocabulary: formal writing

C	1
申请	shēnqǐng
评审	píngshěn
拟	nǐ
恳请	kěnqǐng
若蒙	ruò méng
随信	suíxìn
盼复	pànfù
各位	gèwèi
主持	zhǔchí

Characters



Exercises

1. Rewrite the casual into formal:“老师你好，我想申请这个项目，麻烦看一下我的材料，谢谢。”(use尊敬的…,拟,恳请,盼复)

2. Write a 150-character speech opening on“为什么学外语永远不会过时”.

3. Edit your Unit 7 concession paragraph with the checklist; write down three changes you made.

Communication task

Deliver your speech opening aloud three times: once reading, once with notes, once free. Record all three and compare — the third version is your C1 speaking level.

Revision

复习：成熟的读者和作者

Consolidate Stage C1

The C1 toolkit

- Formal particles:之(的)、其(his/its)、者(the one who)、所(object marker)、与(和).
- Reasoning moves:并不是…而是…;看起来…其实不然;正因为…才…;诚然…但…;归根结底.
- Gentle negation:未必/并非— correcting without blunt denial.
- Evaluation:值得一看/不愧为经典/价值在于…
- Contrastive turns:倒(surprisingly) vs却(yet, before the verb).
- Composition & variation:由…组成/构成;时而…时而…;随着… (change over time).
- Formal correspondence:拟,恳请,随信附上,盼复,此致敬礼.

The C1 reading habit

Long-form reading, three times a week: one essay or long article read twice — once with a dictionary for structure, once fast for flow — then a three-sentence spoken summary, recorded. This single loop teaches vocabulary, structure, and speaking together; it is the whole method in one paragraph.



At C1 you stop“learning Chinese”and start“doing things in Chinese”. Cook from a Chinese recipe. Follow a Chinese chess channel. Argue with a Chinese newspaper columnist, out loud, in your kitchen. I'll still be here in C2, but the map is mostly yours now.

Assessment

Stage C1 Assessment

Closed-book; allow 90 minutes

Part 1 · Listening-style comprehension (script; use TTS)

主持人

今天我们请到了一位字体设计师。您的作品我们都用过——能先讲讲中文字体设计的难点吗?

Jīntiān wǒmen qǐngdàole yí wèi zìtǐ shèjìshī. Nín de zuòpǐn wǒmen dōu yòngguo — néng xiān jiǎngjiang Zhōngwén zìtǐ shèjì de nándiǎn ma?

Today we have a typeface designer. We've all used your work — can you start with what makes Chinese type design hard?

设计师

最大的难点是数量。拉丁字母二十六个，中文字常用字就要几千个。所以中文字体项目往往要做五六年。

Zuì dà de nándiǎn shì shùliàng. Lādīng zìmǔ èrshíliù ge, Zhōngwén zì chángyòng zì jiù yào jǐ qiān ge. Suǒyǐ Zhōngwén zìtǐ xiàngmù wǎngwǎng yào zuò wǔ liù nián.

The hardest thing is sheer quantity. Latin has 26 letters; Chinese needs several thousand common characters. So Chinese type projects often take five or six years.

主持人

正因为如此，好的中文字体才更值得尊敬?

Zhèng yīnwèi rúcǐ, hǎo de Zhōngwén zìtǐ cái gèng zhídé zūnjìng?

Precisely because of that, good Chinese typefaces deserve even more respect?

设计师

可以这么说。但字体设计不是为了被尊敬，而是为了被忘记——读者只应该看到内容，不该看到字。

Kěyǐ zhème shuō. Dàn zìtǐ shèjì bù shì wèile bèi zūnjìng, ér shì wèile bèi wàngjì — dúzhě zhǐ yīnggāi kàndào nèiróng, bù gāi kàndào zì.

You could say so. But type design isn't made to be respected; it's made to be forgotten — the reader should see only the content, never the characters.

1.

Answer:

1. What is the designer's stated hardest problem?

2. What does the designer say type design is made for, and what does that mean?

3. Explain the presenter's主持人line's structure (正因为如此…才…).

Part 2 · Reading

有人说，方言注定要消失，因为在学校、在职场，普通话都更有用。这种说法并非全错，但它忽略了语言的功能不只是沟通。一个人愿意用什么语言跟孩子说话，往往不是由“有用”决定的，而是由“我是谁”决定的。

方言未必会完全消失，但它的未来不在政策文件里，而在餐桌上、在歌里、在一个人决定开口的那个瞬间。

2. Answer:

1. What claim does the author reject, and with which structure?

2. According to the author, what really decides whether a dialect survives?

3. Paraphrase the final sentence in plain Chinese, then in English.

Part 3 · Grammar and register

3. Rewrite formally:

1.他的书翻译成了中文。(用“被”) → ___

2.这个项目的目的(之/其) → ___

3.老师你好，麻烦帮我看看材料，谢谢。(formal email opening and closing) → ___

4. Write one sentence with each, on any topic:

1.未必

2.并非…而是…

3.归根结底

4.值得

Part 4 · Writing and speaking (self-assessed)

Write a 400–500 character essay on one of: the value of handwriting; whether every child should learn a second language; cities and loneliness. Requirements: one concession (诚然…但…), one gentle negation (未必/并非), one evaluation (在

于/值得), a final归根结底 sentence. Record it. Model and criteria in the answer key.

Pass guide: Parts 1–3 at 80%+; the essay argues with a recognisable spine, not a list of opinions.

STAGE C2

精通

Mastery

— read demanding texts: literary prose, formal essays, and classical fragments

— argue and write with stylistic control: tone, rhythm, and register at will

— understand satire, irony, and understatement in Chinese

— handle 文言 basics and the classical inheritance in modern writing

— negotiate, persuade, and disagree elegantly under pressure

C2 is not a level you finish. It is a level you maintain — and the units here are written to be re-read.

UNIT 1

文言入门

Classical Chinese: the first fifty grammar particles

In this unit you will learn to:

- read short classical fragments with glosses
- command the core particles:之乎者也、以、于、而
- understand how文言lives inside modern writing
- translate a classical sentence into modern Chinese

Reading 1:论语fragment (glossed)

子曰：“学而时习之，不亦说乎？有朋自远方来，不亦乐乎？”

Modern rendering:孔子说：“学了以后按时温习它，不也很愉快吗？有朋友从远方来，不也很快乐吗？”Gloss:子zǐ Master (here Confucius) ·曰yuē said ·而and then (sequential) ·时shí at the proper time ·习xí to practise (originally“to rehearse”; later “review”) ·之it (object pronoun) ·不亦…乎“is it not…?”(rhetorical) ·说yuè =悦, pleased (a borrowed-character usage of the period) ·朋péng like-minded friends. Source: Analects, Book 1, opening passage — among the most-quoted sentences in the Chinese tradition.

The particle toolkit

Classical Chinese is not modern Chinese with hard words; it is a compactly different grammar. These are the load-bearing

pieces — learn them as functions, not as dictionary entries:

C	2
之	zhī
乎	hū
者	zhě
以	yǐ
于	yú
而	ér
也	yě
矣	yǐ

Reading 2: how文言lives in modern prose

现代书面语是文言和白话的合金。新闻标题里，“会晤”代替“见面”，“曰”变成了“说”，但“据悉”“此前”“会后”仍然是文言的骨骼。一个证据是成语：几乎每个成语都是一小块文言，被完整地搬进了现代句子。你不需要会写文言，但你需要看得懂它的零件——因为今天的编辑、记者和作者每天都在用。

Gloss:合金héjīn alloy ·会晤huìwù meeting (diplomatic register) ·据悉jùxī“it is reported that” ·此前cǐqián“prior to this” ·骨骼gǔgé skeleton. This passage itself practises what it describes:之appears twice as a formal possessive.

Exercises

1. Translate into modern Chinese, then English:

   1.学而时习之。

   2.有朋自远方来。

   3.不亦乐乎?

2. Identify the function of each particle:

1.生于西安。(于)

2.以文会友。(以)

3.读者(者)

3. Find one文言-derived phrase in a modern news headline this week and explain it.

Communication task

Record a 2-minute explanation, in Chinese, of what文言is and why it still matters, for a B-level learner. Use one classical quotation with your own modern rendering.

UNIT 2

讽刺与分寸

Satire, irony, and the tone control of advanced writing

In this unit you will learn to:

- recognise irony and understatement in Chinese
- write with deliberate tonal control
- understand说反话and the culture of restraint
- critique a text's rhetoric, not just its content

Reading: two kinds of praise (critique exercise)

同一场演出，两篇评论：甲：“这场演出无疑是本年度最重要的文化事件之一，值得每一位观众亲临现场。”

乙：“据主办方介绍，这是本年度最重要的文化事件之一。观众可以亲临现场，也可以在门口看大屏幕。

甲is praise.乙is something else: by attributing the claim to the organiser (据介绍) and then offering the screen option,

the writer has said“this event considers itself important”— a sentence that praises only in appearance. This is

understatement-by-attribution, and it is everywhere in Chinese journalism. The signal words:据说、据介绍、所谓、似

乎。When you see a grand claim wearing these coats, look twice.

The rhetoric of restraint

Chinese formal writing tends to understate where English stresses:不是不行(“it's not that it doesn't work”— often:“it

barely works”),还可以(“it's all right” — often: “it's fine, don't ask”),有待改进(“awaits improvement” — “it's bad

”). Reading tone in these registers is a C2 skill; using them is the second half. When you write, decide deliberately where

you will be warm, where cool, where silent.

Critique vocabulary

C	2
讽刺	fěngcì
反话	fǎnhuà
语气	yǔqì
克制	kèzhì
夸张	kuāzhāng
据…介绍	jù…jièshào
所谓	suǒwèi
有待	yǒudài
不言而喻	bù yán ér yù
适得其反	shì dé qí fǎn

Characters



Exercises

1. Read each sentence twice — once sincere, once ironic — and explain the signal:

   1.据说这家餐厅是城里最好吃的。

   2.这个方案也不是不行。

   3.所谓的“高科技”，就是多了一个按钮。

2. Rewrite a blunt criticism (of a film, a policy) as restrained understatement.

3. Translate:

    1. This is not that it won't work — it just barely will.

    2. The so-called innovation adds one button.

    3. Restraint, not exaggeration, is the register of this newspaper.

Communication task

Record a 3-minute review of something you disliked — written to sound measured, not angry. Then record 30 seconds explaining to a learner which choices created the restraint.

UNIT 3

科学与公众

Science communication and precise claim-making

In this unit you will learn to:

- read science journalism in Chinese
- use hedging language precisely:或许、在某种程度上、有待验证
- structure an explanation for a general audience
- handle numbers, units, and uncertainty

Reading: what a statistic does not say (adapted)

一项研究登上了新闻：“常喝咖啡的人寿命更长。”标题很吸引人，但它说了三件没说清的事：多长算“常”？“寿命更长”是相关还是因果？研究控制了别的变量吗？科学传播的困难在于，真实的研究结论往往带着一串限定词，而标题的长度只够放结论本身。

严谨的记者会写：“在控制了吸烟与运动等因素后，该研究发现，每天饮用两到三杯咖啡的人群的全因死亡率略低于不饮用者。”注意这句话里的每一个限定词——它们不是懦弱，而是诚实。读者应当学会的第一件事，就是看见限定词；第二件事，是尊敬它们。

Gloss:相关xiāngguān correlation ·因果yīnguǒ causation ·变量biànliàng variable ·限定词xiàndìngcí qualifier ·全因死亡率quányīn

sǐwánglǜ all-cause mortality ·懦弱nuòruò cowardly. The coffee-mortality literature is real but complex and evolving; the passage is

about reading science, not about coffee.

The hedge ladder, precisely

C	2
或	huò
或许	huòxǔ
在一定程度上	zài yídìng chéngdù shàng
有待验证	yǒudài yànzhèng
并不显著	bìng bù xiǎnzhù
因…而异	yīn…ér yì

Explanation structure for a general audience

The move that works in every language and doubly so in Chinese:先讲现象，再讲机制，最后讲限度— phenomenon, mechanism, limits. Try it now: explain why the sky is blue, in Chinese, in three sentences with that skeleton, ending with one因…而异.

Vocabulary: science communication

C	2
研究	yánjiū
结论	jiélùn
统计	tǒngjì
概率	gàilǜ
样本	yàngběn
显著	xiǎnzhù
机制	jīzhì
现象	xiànxiàng

Characters

科学证

Exercises

1. Add precise hedges to these overclaims:

   1.咖啡让你长寿。

   2. AI将取代所有翻译。

   3.这个城市不堵车。

2. Explain, in spoken Chinese: correlation vs causation, with one everyday example.

3. Translate:

   1. The headline left out three things the study never said.

   2. Qualifiers are not weakness; they are honesty.

   3. The finding was modest and varied by age and region.

Communication task

Record a 3-minute explainer of a scientific topic you know well: phenomenon, mechanism, limits — with at least three precise hedges. Then compress it to 90 seconds without losing a hedge.

UNIT 4

辩论的艺术

Debate: rebuttal, concession, and the decisive close

In this unit you will learn to:

- debate a motion with structure and courtesy
- rebut without strawmanning
- use诚然…但是and退一步说
- close with a restatement, not a new argument

Reading: a model rebuttal (adapted from a debate transcript)

对方辩友说，电子书必然取代纸质书，因为方便。我想先退一步说：方便是真的。我在地铁上也读电子书。但是“必然取代”不是从“方便”推出来的。雨伞比雨衣方便，可雨衣还在。决定一个媒介命运的，从来不只是效率，还有习惯、礼物和感情——书是可以送的，电子文件没法在扉页上写字。

Notice the anatomy:退一步说concedes with dignity; the umbrella analogy reframes rather than denies; the final three nouns (习惯、礼物和感情) land the point in rhythm. Rebuttal at C2 is not louder disagreement — it is a change of frame.

Debate furniture

C	2
辩题	biàntí
正方/反方	zhèngfāng/fǎnfāng
退一步说	tuì yí bù shuō
诚然	chéngrán
恰恰相反	qiàqià xiāngfǎn
综上所述	zòngshàng suǒshù
偷换概念	tōuhuàn gàiniàn
以偏概全	yǐ piān gài quán

The courteous blow

Chinese debate culture prizes the rebuke that leaves the opponent's face intact. Formulas:恕我直言(“permit my bluntness”),对方辩友的观点值得尊敬，但是…,我明白对方的意思，可是问题在于…. Learn these frames; then earn the right to drop them among friends.

Characters



Exercises

1. Build rebuttals with the frame:退一步说+ reframe + rhythmic close, on:

    1. “人工智能会消灭外语学习。”
    2. “大城市对年轻人不公平。”
    3. “纸质书已经过时。”

2. Name the fallacy in each:

1.我的合伙人骗过我，所以合伙人都会骗人。(以偏概全)

2.你反对这个方案，就是不关心效率。(false dilemma)

3. Translate:

1. Granting that convenience is real, necessity does not follow from it.

2. What decides a medium's fate is never efficiency alone.

3. To sum up the above, we oppose the motion — for reasons of habit, gifts, and feeling.

Communication task

Debate yourself on a motion you actually believe in: 2 minutes pro (with诚然and综上所述), then 90 seconds rebutting yourself with the model anatomy. Record both and listen to whether your rebuttal reframed or merely denied.

UNIT 5

谈判桌上的中文

Negotiation: hedged firmness and the face-saving exit

In this unit you will learn to:

- negotiate price, terms, and time without hostility
- use与其…不如… and除非for conditional leverage
- offer face-saving exits
- hold a line politely under pressure

Dialogue: a licensing negotiation (no pinyin — you no longer need it)

马克 我们希望首年的授权费能再谈一谈。目前的报价，坦白说，超出了我们的预算。

对方 预算我们理解。但您也清楚，这个价格在市场上并不算高。

马克 市场上或许不高，但对我们的读者来说偏高。与其提高价格，不如我们把范围缩小一点——只授权简体版。这样对双方都更容易接受。

对方 缩小范围可以谈。但除非首年印数有保证，否则授权费很难降。

马克 那我们各退一步：首年印数保证五千册，授权费降一成。如果达不到印数，差额由我们补。这样贵方的利益有保障，我们的预算也过得去。

对方

这个方案，恕我直言，比刚才的更可行。我需要和同事确认，明天给您答复。

From C2 onward, dialogues appear without pinyin: you should read them directly. Annotated negotiation moves follow.

The anatomy of the negotiation

Opening honesty framed as safety:坦白说，超出了我们的预算— reveal a constraint early; it builds credibility.

Reject the comparison, not the number:市场上或许不高，但对我们的读者来说偏高— concede the fact, split the frame.

与其…不如… (“rather than… better to…”): proposes a change of terms instead of a fight over one term.

除非states the real condition:除非首年印数有保证，否则… — every negotiation has one; name it.

那我们各退一步(“then let's each step back”) + a concrete package: meet on a new number with a self-imposed penalty (差额由我们补) that shows you will bear risk yourself.

The face-saving close:恕我直言，比刚才的更可行+明天给您答复— never force an on-the-spot yes; give the other side a graceful door.

Grammar: conditional leverage

除非…否则… (“unless… otherwise…”):除非有保证，否则很难降— the condition and consequence in one frame.与其…不如… prefers an alternative by comparison.都/也in各退一步(“each side steps back once”) is the idiom of compromise.

Vocabulary: negotiation

C	2
授权	shòuquán
报价	bàojià
预算	yùsuán
印数	yìnshù
保证	bǎozhèng
差额	chā'é
一成	yī chéng
与其…不如…	yǔqí…bùrú…
除非…否则…	chúfēi…fǒuzé…
各退一步	gè tuì yí bù
恕我直言	shù wǒ zhíyán

Characters



Exercises

1. Rebuild each blunder into a negotiation move:

   1. “太贵了。”(concede the market, split the frame)
   2. “不行。”(state a condition with除非)
   3. “你决定吧。”(offer a face-saving exit with a deadline)

2. Write the next two turns of the licensing negotiation: the other side's reply and your close.

3. Translate:

1. Rather than raising the price, let's narrow the scope.

2. Unless the first-year print run is guaranteed, the fee can hardly come down.

3. Pardon my bluntness — this is more workable than the last proposal.

Communication task

Role-play a real negotiation from your life (salary, rent, a purchase): three rounds, using与其…不如…,除非…否则…, and a face-saving close. Record both sides.

UNIT 6

翻译的边界

Translation at the edge: untranslatables and the translator's oath

In this unit you will learn to:

- handle culturally loaded terms:江湖、缘分、面子、孝
- translate humour and register
- understand what cannot be translated, and what must be
- write a translator's note

Reading: four words that resist (glossed)

每一个语言都有一批“最后一批才肯交出去”的词。中文的名单上，至少有这四个：江湖——“rivers and lakes”，一个不受朝廷管辖的侠义世界，现在指任何圈子的灰色地带；缘分——把相遇解释成一种命中注定的“分”；面子——社会形象的货币，可以给、可以丢、可以借；孝——不是“服从”，也不是“爱”，而是一种以父母为中心的伦理秩序。

好的译者不是把这些词交出去，而是给它们盖一座小房子：第一次出现的时候，用一个短短的解释让读者住进去；以后再用，读者就有了自己的钥匙。翻译的誓言不是“逐字忠实”，而是“不让读者迷路”。

Gloss:侠义xiáyì chivalric righteousness ·灰色地带huīsè dìdài grey area ·命中注定mìngzhōng zhùdìng fated ·伦理lúnlǐ ethics ·誓言

shìyán oath ·逐字zhúzì word-for-word. These four words have a large scholarly literature in translation studies; the treatment here is practical, not exhaustive.

Writing workshop: the translator's note

Write a 100-character translator's note for one untranslatable word from your own language, aimed at Chinese readers.

Structure: the word; what it is not; one everyday example; what you will do with it going forward (“以下均译作…并保留原文”). The model in the answer key does this for缘分.

Vocabulary: translation

C	2
忠实	zhōngshí
直译	zhíyì
意译	yìyì
读者	dúzhě
注释	zhùshì
文化	wénhuà
伦理	lúnlǐ
迷路	mí lù

Characters

翻 译 忠

Exercises

1. Give your working translation for each, with a first-occurrence gloss:

   1.面子in“他给了我一个面子”

   2.缘分in“我们真有缘分”

   3.孝in“孝不是服从”

2. Translate the pun and then explain the loss:“为什么不能给拿破仑做毯子？因为他有拿破仑（毯）症。”(a constructed bilingual joke — discuss what a translator does with jokes that cannot cross.)

3. Translate:

   1. The good translator does not hand these words over; she builds them a small house.

   2. The oath of translation is not word-for-word fidelity but not letting the reader get lost.

   3. Filial piety is neither obedience nor love, but an ethical order centred on the parents.

Communication task

Record your translator's note as a spoken explanation to a Chinese friend: the word, the trap, your solution. Then have the friend (played by you) push back once, and answer.

UNIT 7

书写系统的未来

The future of the writing system: input, AI, and what changes

In this unit you will learn to:

- read a speculative feature article
- argue about technology and tradition with evidence
- understand预测vs推断
- write a balanced column-style piece

Reading: will Chinese always be typed? (adapted)

有一种预测说，语音输入将取代打字，中文的“输入难”问题将随之消失。这个预测值得认真对待，但它混淆了两件事：输入的效率和书写系统的地位。打字解决的是“怎么写”，而正在到来的问题是“还写不写”。

历史上，汉字经历过三次大的技术挑战：打字机时代，人们说汉字会被废除；计算机时代，人们说汉字进不了屏幕；两次都错了。今天没有人再说这些。但这次的挑战不同——它不是“能不能写”，而是“还需不需要写”。当机器可以替你写邮件、写报告、甚至写情书的时候，一个人还愿意提笔，是因为什么呢？这个问题，技术回答不了。

Gloss:语音输入yǔyīn shūrù voice input ·混淆hùnxiáo to confuse ·打字机dǎzìjī typewriter ·废除fèichú to abolish ·屏幕píngmù screen ·

提笔tí bǐ to take up the pen. Historical note: the typewriter-era debate about script reform (including romanisation proposals and the

“Latinisation” movement of the 1930s) and the 1970s–80s challenge of rendering characters on computers are both well

documented; the second was solved by encoding and input methods.

Prediction vs inference

预测(“prediction”) names a future claim;推断(“inference”) reasons from evidence to a conclusion. Columns earn

trust by doing the second while labelling the first. Notice the reading does this: it names the prediction (语音输入将取代

打字), then splits it (混淆了两件事), then reframes the question (还写不写), and ends where evidence runs out (这个问

题，技术回答不了).

Vocabulary: technology and writing

C	2
预测	yùcè
推断	tuīduàn
废除	fèichú
混淆	hùnxiáo
屏幕	píngmù
输入	shūrù
随之	suízhī
挑战	tiǎozhàn

Characters



Exercises

1. Label each sentence预测or推断and justify:

1.语音输入会取代打字。

2.汉字两次战胜了技术挑战，所以第三次也可能。

3.这次的挑战不是“能不能”，而是“要不要”。

2. Write a 200-character column paragraph on“AI替我写作之后，写作还是我的吗？”with one concession and one reframing.

3. Translate:

1. It confuses two things: the efficiency of input and the standing of the writing system.

2. Typing answered“how to write”; the coming question is“whether to write at all”.

3. That question, technology cannot answer.

Communication task

Record a 3-minute column-style talk: a prediction you hear often, the two things it confuses, your reframe, and where the evidence runs out. End with the unanswered question, not with an answer.

UNIT 8

毕业，与开始

Graduation, and the beginning: your own Chinese life

In this unit you will learn to:

- assess your own level honestly
- build a five-year maintenance plan
- read one unadapted text end to end
- write a letter to your future self, in Chinese

Reading: what C2 means (and does not)

读完这本书，你已经能读散文、能写有条理的文章、能在会议上礼貌地反驳一个人，也能在饭桌上讲一个完整的笑话。这就是C2：不是“什么都会”，而是“遇到不会的时候，知道怎么办”。

C2之后没有更高的教材，只有更宽的生活。你需要的不再是一本书，而是一个生态：一两个中国朋友，一份每周读的东西，一部追的剧，一个愿意用中文写东西的地方。语言不是一门课，它是一种需要经常回去看的老朋友——好久不见，也别不好意思。

The last word belongs to the language itself, and to you:学而时习之。If you began this book unable to hold a chopstick of a sentence together, you have now read classical Chinese, negotiated a licensing deal, and argued about the future of

writing.时习之— keep going.

The five-year maintenance plan

Weekly: read one substantial article or essay chapter; note five new words in your own sentences.

Weekly: 30 minutes of spoken Chinese with a real person (language exchange, tutor, or friend). No cancel.

Monthly: watch one film or series without subtitles you've already seen with subtitles — the reverse ladder.

Quarterly: write one 500-character piece on anything, then edit it down by 20%.

Yearly: take on one hard project in Chinese — a course, a translation, a talk, a trip with real stakes.

Standing rule: never let two weeks pass with zero Chinese. The habit matters more than the intensity.

Final writing task: a letter to your future self

Write a letter, in Chinese, to yourself five years from now: where you hope your Chinese is, what you will have read and watched and argued about, one thing you promise to keep doing, one thing you forgive yourself for possibly dropping.

Address it formally, close it formally (此致敬礼is for letters; but this is your letter — you may close it however you like).

Seal it in an envelope with the date. The answer key offers a model with annotations.



I have one last confession.林雨晨doesn't exist — I was written for this book, drawn in vectors, and set in a typeface that took years to design. But the two thousand pages between us were real: your time, your voice, your marginal notes. That part is yours, and no one can take it.好久不见的时候，翻开任何一页，我都在。

Vocabulary: reflection

C	2
生态	shēngtài
维护	wéihù
原谅	yuánliàng
承诺	chéngnuò
很久不见	hěn jiǔ bú jiàn
终于	zhōngyú

Characters



Exercises

1. Assess yourself: pick three units from this book at random and do their exercises cold. Anything under 80% marks the topic to revisit this quarter.

2. Write your maintenance plan in Chinese, in six sentences, with dates.

3. Write the letter. Seal it. Then — one more time — 学而时习之.

Revision

复习：登顶前的清点

Consolidate Stage C2

The C2 inventory

- Classical particles:之乎者也以于而— function first, translation second.
- Irony signals:据说、据介绍、所谓、似乎— praise in appearance, blade underneath.
- Understatement register:不是不行/还可以/有待改进— read the temperature, not the words.
- Precise hedging:或许、在一定程度上、有待验证、并不显著、因…而异.
- Debate anatomy:退一步说→ reframe → rhythmic close; fallacy names以偏概全、偷换概念.
- Negotiation furniture:与其…不如…、除非…否则…、各退一步、恕我直言.
- Translator's oath: build the small house for untranslatables; never let the reader get lost.

Final reading (unadapted)

一篇好的散文，不负责给你答案；它负责把问题擦亮。汉字经过了一百年的技术挑战，没有一次是靠“守”赢的——每一次都是靠“用”赢的。所以，中文的未来不在于保护它的人有多少，而在于用它做事的人有多少：用它谈恋爱，用它吵架，用它签合同，用它给孩子起名字。你今天合上这本书，就是它的未来的一部分。

1.

Answer in Chinese:

1.作者是说汉字从未被挑战过吗？(不；指出作者的真正观点)

2.“把问题擦亮”是一种什么修辞？用英文解释。

3.最后一句的逻辑是什么？



One last drill, for the road: take this very paragraph and read it aloud three times. First for the argument, second for the rhythm (注意四字结构：签合同、起名字), third with your own closing sentence replacing the author's. If you can do the third, you are no longer studying Chinese.你在用它。

Assessment

Final Assessment

Closed-book; allow 2 hours

Part 1 · Listening-style comprehension (script; use TTS)

主持人

最后一个问题：如果请您对学中文的外国朋友说一句话，您会说什么？

嘉宾

我大概会说：别把中文当成一门“难的”语言。说一门语言难，往往只是因为它陌生。

我见过太多人被“汉字难”这句话吓退——他们不是学不会，是还没开始就信了别人说他们学不会。

主持人

所以信心比方法重要？

嘉宾

不完全是。信心让你开始，方法让你走得快，但让你走到底的，是把中文变成生活的一部分。学语言最忌半途而废，而半途而废的人，多数不是输在难度，而是输在没有把学习放进自己的日子里。

1.

Answer:

1. What does the guest say the phrase“Chinese is hard”actually does to learners?

2. What is the guest's three-part chain (what starts you, what speeds you, what keeps you)?

3. Paraphrase the final sentence in English, then in simpler Chinese.

Part 2 · Reading

有一种观点认为，机器翻译成熟以后，人类就再也不需要学外语了。这个推论比它看起来弱得多：它假设翻译只是信息的搬运，而语言的作用远不止信息。一个只翻译“内容”的机器，翻译不了“我们”：它能把菜单译得完美，却没法在敬酒的时候替你举杯。归根结底，学外语从来不是为了听懂别人，而是为了变成一个更大的自己。机器可以替你工作，但没法替你成长。

2.

Answer:

1. Name the structure the author uses to weaken the prediction (它假设…而…).

2. Explain the toast example in your own Chinese.

3. State the essay's final claim and give one objection to it, fairly.

Part 3 · Language control

3. Rewrite each with the named structure:

1. “太贵了！”(understatement:不是不贵)

2. “我不相信这个预测。”(gentle:未必)

3. “你说得对，但是…”(formal concession:诚然)

4. Summarise your Part 2 reading in one sentence starting综上所述.

4. Translate into Chinese:

1. Pardon my bluntness — this proposal confuses two things.

2. Rather than protecting the language, we should live in it.

3. Confidence starts you; method speeds you; but only making it part of your life keeps you going.

Part 4 · Extended writing (self-assessed)

Write an 800–1000 character essay on one of:语言与身份;技术时代的慢;学习的意义. Requirements: a formal register with one deliberately casual sentence for contrast; one classical quotation with your own rendering; one concession (诚然…但…); one hedge set (未必/在一定程度上); a closing that reframes rather than repeats. Then record it as a spoken lecture. Full model, annotations, and marking criteria are in the answer key.

Pass guide: Parts 1–3 at 85%+; the extended essay shows register control, a spine, and at least one moment that is genuinely yours.

Reference 1 · The Complete Pinyin Chart

Initials (声母) — 23. Finals (韵母) — 39, of which the most useful 34 are listed. The spelling rules that matter most follow the tables.

Initials

Initials	Group	Notes
b p m f	labial stops and f	as in English, unaspirated b/p
d t n l	alveolar	t aspirated, d not
g k h	velar	h like English h, raspier
j q x	palatals	only before i/ü; j as in“jeep”, q like“cheep”strong, x like“she”soft
zh ch sh r	retroflex	tongue curled back; r as in English“r”
z c s	dental sibilants	z as“ds”, c as“ts”aspirated, s as s
y w	glides	count as initials in spelling

Simple finals

Final	Notes
a o e i u ü	the six basic vowels; ü is a front rounded u (say“ee”then round your lips)
-i (zhi/chi/shi/ri)	a buzzed retroflex vowel, not the“i”of xi
-i (zi/ci/si)	a buzzed dental vowel
er	the rhotic of二,儿

Compound and nasal finals

Finals	Examples
ai ei ui (uei)	as in海hǎi,给gěi,对duì
ao ou iu (iou)	好hǎo,头tóu,六liù
an en in un ün	天tiān,人rén,心xīn,春chūn
ang eng ing ong	帮bāng,生shēng,明míng,中zhōng
ia ie iao iu(iou) ian iang iong	家jiā,街jiē,叫jiào,九jiǔ,见jiàn,讲jiǎng,穷qióng
ua uo uai ui(uei) uan uang	瓜guā,国guó,快kuài,对duì,弯wān,光guāng
üe üan ün	月yuè,远yuǎn,云yún

Spelling rules you must know

ü loses its dots after j, q, x, y:去qù (not qü),需xū,举jǔ,月yuè. After n and l it keeps them:女nǚ,绿lǜ.

iou and uei shorten in spelling to iu and ui when an initial precedes:六liù,对duì.

The apostrophe separates syllables that would otherwise merge:西安Xī'ān (not Xīān),皮袄pí'ǎo.

Tone marks go on the main vowel: a > o > e > i/u/ü, with i's dot removed: nǐ, lǜ. Mark on the second vowel when the final has two: hǎo, duì.

Neutral-tone syllables carry no mark:妈妈māma,谢谢xièxie.

Tone changes (full list)

Context	Change	Example
Third + third	first becomes second	你好ní hǎo,很好hén hǎo
不 + fourth	不 becomes second	不是bú shì,不对bú duì
一 + fourth	一 becomes second	一样yíyàng,一共yígòng
一 + other tones	一 becomes fourth	一天yì tiān,一年yì nián,一碗yì wǎn
一 in counting	一 stays first	一、二、三；第一dì-yī
A/A+B reduplication	second syllable neutral	姐姐jiějie (A→B),看看kànkan (verb reduplication)

Reference 2 · Grammar Index

Structure	Taught	Core use
是 copula	A1 U1	X是Y links nouns only; no tense
吗 questions	A1 U2	statement +吗?
呢 return questions	A1 U2	topic +呢?
Measure words 个	A1 U3	number + MW + noun
的 possessive	A1 U4	X的Y
有/没有	A1 U4	有negates with没
了 (completion)	A1 U5	completed action or new situation
Time words first	A1 U5	我七点起床
Specific measure words	A1 U6	碗杯瓶本件条块位
也/都/很 slots	A1 U7	adverbs before the verb
Dates, biggest first	A1 U8	year → month → day → weekday
过 experiential	A2 U1	have done at least once
比 comparisons	A2 U2	A比B + adj
一样 equality	A2 U2	A跟B一样
越来越	A2 U2	more and more
会/能/可以	A2 U3	learned skill / ability / permission
吧 suggestions	A2 U3	statement +吧
快…了 / 就要…了	A2 U5	about to
的时候/以前/以后	A2 U5	time relations before the clause
在 + place + verb	A2 U6	where an activity happens
在 + place + position	A2 U6	on/under/beside/across
就 vs 才	A2 U8	early/soon vs not-until/only
因为…所以…	B1 U1	cause and effect
虽然…但是…	B1 U1	concession
如果…就…	B1 U1	condition
把 disposal	B1 U2	S +把+ O + V + result
被/叫/让 passive	B1 U2	mainly for consequences
Directional complements	B1 U3	上来/下去/出去/回来
次 frequency	B1 U3	verb + (object) +次
得 degree complement	B1 U5	V +得+ adjective
一…就…	B1 U5	as soon as
Potential complements	B1 U6	看得懂/听不懂
要么…要么…	B1 U7	either… or…
会…的 confident prediction	B1 U7	surely will
又 vs 再	B1 U7	again past vs again future
一边…一边…	B1 U8	while…ing

Structure	Taught	Core use
先…然后…最后	B1 U8	narrative order
想/想要/打算/计划	B1 U8	ladder of intention
是…的	B2 U1	highlight circumstances of a past event
越…越…	B2 U2	the more… the more…
连…都/也	B2 U2	even
A是A，但…	B2 U2	concede then counter
不仅…而且…	B2 U5	not only… but also
Reported speech	B2 U5	说/问我, no backshifting
无论/不管…都…	B2 U6	no matter
除了…以外	B2 U6	besides / except
面对/面临	B2 U7	facing
恐怕/有可能 hedges	B2 U7	hedged claims
Formal letter frame	B2 U8	尊敬的…您好…此致敬礼
随着	C1 U2	as (times) change
倒 vs 却	C1 U3	surprisingly / yet
由…组成	C1 U4	composed of
时而…时而…	C1 U4	now… now…
将 (written 把)	C1 U5	formal disposal in narration
值得/不愧/在于/归根结底	C1 U5,7	evaluation set
诚然…但…	C1 U7	formal concession
未必/并非	C1 U7	gentle negation
之/其/者/所/与	C1 U1	classical particles in modern prose
不亦…乎	C2 U1	classical rhetorical question
与其…不如…	C2 U5	rather than… better to…
除非…否则…	C2 U5	unless… otherwise…
恕我直言	C2 U5	pardon my bluntness

Reference 3 · Measure Word Guide

Measure words are not optional decoration: number + measure word + noun is the law. This guide lists the measure words used in this book, grouped by what they count.

MW	Counts	Example
个	the default; people, general things	一个人,三个问题
位	people, polite	这位老师,两位客人
名	people, formal/written	三名学生
只	animals, one of a pair	一只猫,两只鞋
条	long things; fish	一条鱼,一条路
根	long thin things	一根筷子
张	flat things	一张纸,一张桌子
本	books, notebooks	一本书
件	tops, events, matters	一件衬衫,一件事
杯	cups	一杯茶
碗	bowls	一碗面
瓶	bottles	一瓶水
盒	boxes	一盒月饼
块	pieces; yuan (money)	一块钱,三块面包
斤	500 grams	三斤苹果
次	occurrences of events	去过三次
趟	trips (there and back)	去了一趟北京
句	sentences, lines	说了一句话
场	events, performances	一场电影,一场雨
阵	bursts, short spells	一阵风
辆	vehicles	一辆车
家	families, companies	一家餐厅
所	schools, institutes	一所大学
层	floors, layers	三层楼
篇	articles, essays	一篇文章
首	poems, songs	一首诗

Reference 4 · Simplified–Traditional Quick Guide

A recognition guide, not a conversion course. The five patterns from B1 U4 first, then the 60 most common character pairs, then where each script is used.

The five patterns

Pattern	Examples
言→讠	語→语,說→说,課→课
糸→纟	紅→红,給→给,綠→绿
車→车	軍→军,轉→转,輕→轻
門→门	問→问,們→们,聞→闻
貝→贝	買→买,賣→卖,錢→钱

60 high-frequency pairs (traditional → simplified)

愛→爱萬→万與→与歸→归邊→边運→运

過→过還→还這→这裡→里後→后時→时

間→间長→长開→开開开閱→阅關→关電→电

東→东車→车馬→马鳥→鸟魚→鱼見→见

書→书學→学習→习樂→乐圓→圆國→国

圖→图億→亿會→会來→来對→对專→专

業→业東→东豐→丰禮→礼種→种稱→称

筆→笔節→节級→级約→约紅→红紙→纸

級→级絕→绝給→给統→统經→经綠→绿

網→网練→练繼→继義→义習→习聽→听

藝→艺藥→药蘭→兰處→处蟲→虫術→术

補→补規→规記→记設→设許→许詞→词

課→课談→谈請→请諸→诸讀→读議→议

讓→让質→质車→车較→较辦→办辭→辞

達→达選→选錢→钱錄→录鐘→钟長→长

門→门陽→阳難→难雲→云頂→顶頭→头

領→领飛→飞飯→饭養→养館→馆驚→惊

骨→骨體→体齊→齐

Where each script is standard

Simplified: mainland China (since the 1950s–60s reform), Singapore (adopted 1976), Malaysia's Chinese education system.

Traditional: Taiwan (official standard), Hong Kong, Macau, and many overseas communities.

Both appear in practice: mainland calligraphy and shop signs often use traditional forms for aesthetics; Taiwan technical writing sometimes uses simplified in imported texts.

Most characters (~80% of common text) are identical in both systems; the visible differences concentrate in a few hundred high-frequency characters.

Reference 5 · Core Vocabulary Glossary (by stage)

Every word taught in the unit vocabulary tables, in pinyin order per stage. Use it as a revision sweep: read each stage's list aloud once a month; anything you cannot say in a sentence gets restudied. (A full bilingual dictionary is not attempted — this is your active vocabulary, not the language.)

Stage A1 — 基础

Chinese	Pinyin	English
变化	biànhuà	change
辩题	biàntí	motion (debate topic)
别	bié	don't
鞭炮	biānpào	firecrackers
标准	biāozhǔn	standard
表演	biǎoyǎn	performance
爸爸	bàba	dad
半途而废	bàn tú ér fèi	to give up halfway. From the Book of Rites, on learning.
报价	bàojià	quoted price
被	bèi	passive marker
并不显著	bìng bù xiǎnzhù	not statistically significant
毕业	bìyè	to graduate
不	bù	not
不喜欢	bù xǐhuan	to dislike
不言而喻	bù yán ér yù	goes without saying
不愧	bùkuì	worthy of the name
八	bā	8
杯水车薪	bēi shuǐ chē xīn	a cup of water on a cartload of firewood — hopelessly inadequate. From Mencius.
悲剧	bēijù	tragedy
把	bǎ	disposal marker
保存	bǎocún	to keep, preserve
保护	bǎohù	to protect
保证	bǎozhèng	guarantee
船队	chuánduì	fleet
传入	chuánrù	to be introduced (from elsewhere)

Chinese	Pinyin	English
唱	chàng	to sing
茶馆	cháguǎn	teahouse
常常	chángcháng	often
潮湿	cháoshī	humid
成本	chéngběn	cost
成果	chéngguǒ	achievement, fruit
成就	chéngjiù	achievement
承诺	chéngnuò	promise
诚然	chéngrán	it is true that…
呈现	chéngxiàn	to present
成语	chéngyǔ	idiom, set phrase
城镇化	chéngzhènhuà	urbanisation
除非…否则…	chúfēi…fǒuzé…	unless… otherwise…
差额	chā'é	the difference (in money)
超市	chāoshì	supermarket
吃早饭	chī zǎofàn	to eat breakfast
出发	chūfā	to set off
出来	chūlái	come out
春节	chūnjié	Spring Festival
春联	chūnlián	spring couplet
春天	chūntiān	spring
出土	chūtǔ	to be unearthed
出租车	chūzūchē	taxi
场合	chǎnghé	occasion
措施	cuòshī	measure
菜市场	càishìchǎng	food market
次	cì	times, occurrences
词典	cídiǎn	dictionary
瓷器	cíqì	porcelain
餐具	cānjù	cutlery
聪明	cōngming	clever
此致敬礼	cǐzhì jìnglǐ	formal letter closing
的	de	possessive/attributive particle
的时候	de shíhou	at the time when
电影	diànyǐng	film, movie
点	diǎn	o'clock
典故	diǎngù	allusion, classical source
对面	duìmiàn	opposite, across from

Chinese	Pinyin	English
多喝水	duō hē shuǐ	drink more water
多少	duōshao	how much/how many (numbers > 10)
代替	dàitì	to replace
蛋黄	dànhuáng	egg yolk
但是	dànshì	but
到处	dàochù	everywhere
大学	dàxué	university
递	dì	to pass, hand over
弟弟	dìdi	younger brother
地区	dìqū	region
地铁	dìtiě	metro, subway
动荡	dòngdàng	upheaval
豆沙	dòushā	red bean paste
肚子疼	dùzi téng	stomachache
读者	dúzhě	reader
冬天	dōngtiān	winter
都	dōu	all, both
打扰	dǎrǎo	to disturb, trouble
打算	dǎsuàn	to plan, intend
放假	fàngjià	to have a holiday
放弃	fàngqì	to give up
房东	fángdōng	landlord
房价	fángjià	housing price
房子	fángzi	house, flat
房租	fángzū	rent
繁体字	fántǐzì	traditional characters
废除	fèichú	to abolish
附近	fùjìn	nearby
负责	fùzé	to be in charge of
方	fāng	side, direction
方言	fāngyán	dialect, regional variety
番茄	fānqié	tomato
翻译	fānyì	to translate; translation
发票	fāpiào	receipt, invoice
发烧	fāshāo	to have a fever
发现	fāxiàn	to discover
非常	fēicháng	extremely
飞机	fēijī	airplane

Chinese	Pinyin	English
分钟	fēnzhōng	minute
讽刺	fěngcì	satire, to satirise
反话	fǎnhuà	words meaning the opposite
个	ge	general measure word
过	guo	experiential marker
贵	guì	expensive
刮风	guāfēng	windy
观察	guānchá	observation
观赏	guānshǎng	ornamental
归根结底	guīgēn jiédǐ	in the final analysis
规模	guīmó	scale
概率	gàilǜ	probability
各退一步	gè tuì yí bù	each side concedes a step
各位	gèwèi	everybody (address)
刚才	gāngcái	just now
干燥	gānzào	dry
高	gāo	tall
高考	gāokǎo	university entrance exam
高三	gāosān	final year of high school
高铁	gāotiě	high-speed rail
哥哥	gēge	older brother
工具	gōngjù	tool
公平	gōngpíng	fair
工作	gōngzuò	to work
改编	gǎibiān	adaptation
改革	gǎigé	reform
感动	gǎndòng	moved (emotionally)
感冒	gǎnmào	common cold
画蛇添足	huà shé tiān zú	to overdo it. From a story in the Strategies of the Warring States: contestants drawing snakes; the one
坏	huài	broken
皇帝	huángdì	emperor
环境	huánjìng	environment
会	huì	learned skill; also“will”for predictions:明天会下雨
回家	huí jiā	to return home
回报	huíbào	reward, return

Chinese	Pinyin	English
回复	huífù	reply
回来	huílái	come back
回去	huíqù	go back
回收	huíshōu	to recycle
或	huò	perhaps, or (written hedge)
或许	huòxǔ	perhaps
活力	huólì	vitality
欢迎	huānyíng	to welcome
火车	huǒchē	train
火车票	huǒchēpiào	train ticket
火锅	huǒguō	hotpot
汉字	Hànzì	Chinese characters
号	hào	day of the month (spoken)
还没	hái méi	not yet
还是	háishì	or (in questions)
孩子	háizi	child
航海	hánghǎi	navigation
盒	hé	box (measure word)
痕迹	hénjì	trace, mark
后面	hòumiàn	behind
红包	hóngbāo	red envelope of money
宏大	hóngdà	grand, epic
红绿灯	hónglǜdēng	traffic lights
混淆	hùnxiáo	to confuse
喝茶	hē chá	to drink tea
很	hěn	very
很多	hěn duō	many, a lot
很久	hěn jiǔ	a very long time
很久不见	hěn jiǔ bú jiàn	long time no see
呼吸	hūxī	breath
海岸	hǎi'àn	coast
好得很	hǎo de hěn	really good
好极了	hǎo jíle	wonderful
好像	hǎoxiàng	it seems
降温	jiàngwēn	temperature drop
健康	jiànkāng	healthy
建造	jiànzào	to build
教育	jiàoyù	education

Chinese	Pinyin	English
介绍	jièshào	to introduce
结构	jiégòu	structure
结论	jiélùn	conclusion
加班	jiābān	to work overtime
家常菜	jiāchángcài	home-style dish
坚持	jiānchí	to persist
交流	jiāoliú	exchange
姐姐	jiějie	older sister
简体字	jiǎntǐzì	simplified characters
九	jiǔ	9
觉得	juéde	to think, feel
计划	jìhuà	to plan; a plan (noun)
进场	jìn chǎng	to enter the venue
竞争	jìngzhēng	competition
进去	jìnqù	go in
记载	jìzǎi	written record
聚餐	jùcān	group meal, dinner together
据…介绍	jù…jièshào	according to (an interested party)
机会	jīhuì	opportunity
激烈	jīliè	fierce, intense
斤	jīn	500 g
京剧	jīngjù	Peking opera
今天	jīntiān	today
机器	jīqì	machine
机制	jīzhì	mechanism
几	jǐ	how many
井底之蛙	jǐng dǐ zhī wā	a person with a narrow view. From Zhuangzi: a frog in a well thinks the sky is the well's mouth.
快乐	kuàilè	happy
夸张	kuāzhāng	exaggeration
看书	kàn shū	to read
客户	kèhù	client
克制	kèzhì	restraint
咳嗽	késou	to cough
控诉	kòngsù	to denounce
坑	kēng	pit
恳请	kěnqǐng	to respectfully request
可能	kěnéng	possibly, maybe

Chinese	Pinyin	English
可是	kěshì	but, however
可以	kěyǐ	can, may
恐怕	kǒngpà	I'm afraid; presumably
口	kǒu	mouth —吃、喝、吗
口音	kǒuyīn	accent
凉快	liángkuai	nice and cool
连…都…	lián…dōu…	even…
疗效	liáoxiào	efficacy
六	liù	6
流行	liúxíng	popular, trending
两个星期	liǎng ge xīngqī	two weeks
辣椒	làjiāo	chilli
浪潮	làngcháo	wave, tide
来源	láiyuán	origin, source
劳动人口	láodòng rénkǒu	working population
累得不得了	lèi de bùdéliǎo	utterly exhausted
厉害	lìhai	severe; formidable
历史	lìshǐ	history
零	líng	0
漏	lòu	to leak
路	lù	road, way
录取	lùqǔ	to admit (to university)
伦理	lúnlǐ	ethics
垃圾	lājī	rubbish
冷	lěng	cold
老龄化	lǎolínghuà	ageing of society
老师	lǎoshī	teacher
里	lǐ	inside
理解	lǐjiě	understanding
吗	ma	question particle
面对	miànduì	to face
面临	miànlín	to be confronted with
宀	mián	roof —家、安
勉强	miǎnqiǎng	to force; barely adequate
麻烦您	máfan nín	sorry to trouble you
忙	máng	busy
矛盾	máodùn	contradiction
妹妹	mèimei	younger sister

Chinese	Pinyin	English
没关系	méi guānxi	it doesn't matter
没有	méiyǒu	to not have
糸 → 纟	mì	silk radical:紅→红結→结給→给綠→绿
命运	mìngyùn	fate
迷路	mí lù	to lose one's way
明天	míngtiān	tomorrow
木	mù	tree/wood —林、校、桌
幕	mù	act (of a play)
妈妈	māma	mum
每天	měitiān	every day
满意	mǎnyì	satisfied
米线	mǐxiàn	rice noodles
母语	mǔyǔ	mother tongue
年	nián	year
暖和	nuǎnhuo	warm
那	nà	that
拿走	ná zǒu	to take away
拿出来	náchūlái	take out (toward you)
难怪	nánguài	no wonder
能	néng	physical ability or circumstance
您	nín	you (polite)
你	nǐ	you
拟	nǐ	to intend to (formal)
你好	nǐ hǎo	hello
女	nǚ	woman —好、她、妹
漂亮	piàoliang	pretty, handsome
便宜	piányi	cheap
判断	pànduàn	judgement
盼复	pànfù	awaiting your reply
胖	pàng	fat
排队	pái duì	to queue
旁边	pángbiān	beside
爬山	páshān	to hike, climb a mountain
平衡	pínghéng	balance
屏幕	píngmù	screen
平时	píngshí	usually
评审	píngshěn	review, assessment
平台	píngtái	platform

Chinese	Pinyin	English
恰恰相反	qiàqià xiāngfǎn	quite the opposite
钱包	qiánbāo	wallet
前面	qiánmiàn	in front
潜台词	qiántáicí	subtext
秋天	qiūtiān	autumn
确实	quèshí	indeed
契约	qìyuē	contract (TW)
气质	qìzhì	temperament, style
奇迹	qíjì	miracle
晴	qíng	sunny, clear
去	qù	to go
去年	qùnián	last year
七	qī	7
清淡	qīngdàn	light (of food)
起床	qǐchuáng	to get up
请	qǐng	to treat (someone)
请假	qǐngjià	to ask for leave
请客	qǐngkè	to treat, host and pay
请问	qǐngwèn	excuse me (to ask)
若蒙	ruò méng	should (I) be granted (archaic-flavoured)
让	ràng	to make (someone do)
然后	ránhòu	then, afterwards
热	rè	hot
热情	rèqíng	warm, enthusiastic
亻	rén	person —你、他、位
人口	rénkǒu	population
人员	rényuán	personnel
日	rì	day of the month (written/formal)
入乡随俗	rù xiāng suí sú	when in Rome. An old travellers' maxim.
如果	rúguǒ	if
如果…，就…	rúguǒ…, jiù…	if…, then…
扔	rēng	to throw
帅	shuài	handsome (men)
睡觉	shuìjiào	to sleep, go to bed
睡眠	shuìmián	sleep
氵	shuǐ	water —海、清、洗
水到渠成	shuǐ dào qú chéng	when conditions are ready, results follow naturally. Song-dynasty usage.
水龙头	shuǐlóngtóu	tap, faucet

Chinese	Pinyin	English
上	shàng	on, above
上来	shànglái	come up
上去	shàngqù	go up
设计	shèjì	design
社区	shèqū	community
谁	shéi	who
是	shì	to be
适得其反	shì dé qí fǎn	achieves the opposite of the intent
士兵	shìbīng	soldier
事实	shìshí	fact
十	shí	10
饣	shí	food/eat —饭、馆
时代	shídài	era
十一	shíyī	11
瘦	shòu	thin
受不了	shòubuliǎo	can't bear it
授权	shòuquán	licensing; to authorise
恕我直言	shù wǒ zhíyán	pardon my bluntness
术语	shùyǔ	technical term
身份	shēnfèn	identity
生活质量	shēnghuó zhìliàng	quality of life
生态	shēngtài	ecosystem
生育	shēngyù	to give birth; fertility
申请	shēnqǐng	to apply; application
身体	shēntǐ	body, health
审美	shěnměi	aesthetic (adj/n)
师傅	shīfu	skilled worker; a respectful address
收据	shōujù	receipt
收缩	shōusuō	to contract
书法	shūfǎ	calligraphy
输入	shūrù	input
使节	shǐjié	envoy
署名	shǔmíng	signature
随信	suíxìn	enclosed with this letter
随着	suízhe	along with
随之	suízhī	along with it
虽然	suīrán	although
虽然…，但是…	suīrán…, dànshì…	although…, but…

Chinese	Pinyin	English
缩写	suōxiě	abbreviation
所谓	suǒwèi	the so-called
所以	suǒyǐ	so, therefore
四	sì	4
塑料	sùliào	plastic
三	sān	3
丝绸	sīchóu	silk
扫码	sǎomǎ	to scan a QR code
甜	tián	sweet
调理	tiáolǐ	to nurse, regulate
天气	tiānqì	weather
挑战	tiǎozhàn	challenge
团圆	tuányuán	reunion
退一步说	tuì yí bù shuō	to take a step back; granting for argument's sake
退休	tuìxiū	to retire
推断	tuīduàn	inference
推广	tuīguǎng	to promote, spread
太…了	tài…le	extremely…
台词	táicí	lines (of a play)
糖	táng	sugar
逃离	táolí	to flee, escape
头疼	tóuténg	headache
他	tā	he
她	tā	she
通勤	tōngqín	commuting
偷	tōu	to steal
偷换概念	tōuhuàn gàiniàn	to covertly change the concept (a fallacy)
体检	tǐjiǎn	medical check-up
统计	tǒngjì	statistics
统一	tǒngyī	to unify
外交	wàijiāo	diplomacy
外卖	wàimài	food delivery
忘	wàng	to forget
玩儿	wánr	to have fun, travel for pleasure
为了	wèile	in order to, for the sake of
未来	wèilái	future
维护	wéihù	maintenance

Chinese	Pinyin	English
文化	wénhuà	culture
卧薪尝胆	wò xīn cháng dǎn	to endure hardship to achieve revenge. From the Wu-Yue wars of the Spring and Autumn period.
物业	wùyè	property management
微妙	wēimiào	subtle
温度	wēndù	temperature
往前走	wǎng qián zǒu	go straight ahead
网络	wǎngluò	internet
晚上	wǎnshang	evening
我	wǒ	I, me
我看过那个电影。	Wǒ kànguo nàge diànyǐng.	experiential: I've seen that film (so no need to see it again)
我看了那个电影。	Wǒ kànle nàge diànyǐng.	completed: I watched that film (last night, say)
我去过云南。	Wǒ qùguo Yúnnán.	experiential:“I've been to Yunnan (before, at least once)”
我去了云南。	Wǒ qùle Yúnnán.	completed:“I went to Yunnan (that trip, done)”
五	wǔ	5
五十五	wǔshíwǔ	55
下	xià	under, below
下雪	xià xuě	to snow
下雨	xià yǔ	to rain
下班	xiàbān	to finish work
下来	xiàlái	come down
项目	xiàngmù	project
现金	xiànjīn	cash
现象	xiànxiàng	phenomenon
限制	xiànzhì	to restrict
现在	xiànzài	now
下去	xiàqù	go down
夏天	xiàtiān	summer
下午	xiàwǔ	afternoon
香料	xiāngliào	spices
先…最后…	xiān…zuìhòu…	first… finally…
先…再…	xiān…zài…	first…then…
消费者	xiāofèizhě	consumer
消失	xiāoshī	to disappear
修	xiū	to repair

Chinese	Pinyin	English
休息	xiūxi	to rest
想	xiǎng	to want (softer: I'd like)
想要	xiǎng yào	to want (more definite)
想起	xiǎngqǐ	to recall, think of
显著	xiǎnzhù	significant
学	xué	to learn
学生	xuésheng	student
学习	xuéxí	to study
选择	xuǎnzé	to choose
戏剧	xìjù	drama, theatre
形容	xíngróng	to describe
叙事	xùshì	narrative
星期六	xīngqīliù	Saturday
星期四	xīngqīsì	Thursday
星期三	xīngqīsān	Wednesday
星期天	xīngqītiān	Sunday
星期五	xīngqīwǔ	Friday
星期一	xīngqīyī	Monday
星期二	xīngqīèr	Tuesday
新年	xīnnián	new year
心态	xīntài	mindset, attitude
希望	xīwàng	to hope (for outcomes)
吸引	xīyǐn	to attract
喜欢	xǐhuan	to like
原产	yuánchǎn	indigenous, native to
原谅	yuánliàng	to forgive
月	yuè	month
月饼	yuèbǐng	mooncake
粤菜	Yuècài	Cantonese cuisine
月亮	yuèliang	the moon
远	yuǎn	far
远程办公	yuǎnchéng bàngōng	remote work
样本	yàngběn	sample
药	yào	medicine
药店	yàodiàn	pharmacy
延迟	yánchí	to delay
研究	yánjiū	research
夜市	yèshì	night market

Chinese	Pinyin	English
一举两得	yì jǔ liǎng dé	one action, two gains. Used since the Han histories.
一边…一边…	yìbiān…yìbiān…	while… also…
一百	yìbǎi	100
一点儿	yìdiǎnr	a little
印数	yìnshù	print run
意译	yìyì	free/meaning translation
一次性	yícìxìng	disposable, one-off
银行	yínháng	bank
用语	yòngyǔ	expression, term
右转	yòu zhuǎn	turn right
预测	yùcè	prediction
运动	yùndòng	exercise, sport
预算	yùsuán	budget
欲望	yùwàng	desire
压力	yālì	pressure, stress
也	yě	also
一	yī	1
一成	yī chéng	ten percent
依靠	yīkào	to rely on
阴	yīn	overcast
应该	yīnggāi	should
因为	yīnwèi	because
因为…，所以…	yīnwèi…, suǒyǐ…	because…, therefore…
因…而异	yīn…ér yì	varies according to…
医生	yīshēng	doctor
医院	yīyuàn	hospital
养老金	yǎnglǎojīn	pension
演员	yǎnyuán	actor, performer
以偏概全	yǐ piān gài quán	to generalise from a part (a fallacy)
以后	yǐhòu	after
影片	yǐngpiàn	film
影响	yǐngxiǎng	influence, effect
以前	yǐqián	before
有	yǒu	to have; there is
有空	yǒu kòng	to have free time
有意思	yǒu yìsi	interesting, fun
有待	yǒudài	awaits, remains to be
有待验证	yǒudài yànzhèng	remains to be verified

Chinese	Pinyin	English
语气	yǔqì	tone (of writing/speech)
与其…不如…	yǔqí…bùrú…	rather than… better to…
专业	zhuānyè	major, specialty
照片	zhàopiàn	photo
这	zhè	this
政策	zhèngcè	policy
正方/反方	zhèngfāng/fǎnfāng	pro/con side
这样下去	zhèyàng xiàqù	if this continues
制度	zhìdù	system, institution
值得	zhídé	worth (doing)
职业	zhíyè	profession
直译	zhíyì	literal translation
注释	zhùshì	annotation, note
住校	zhùxiào	to board at school
争论	zhēnglùn	debate, dispute
针灸	zhēnjiǔ	acupuncture
中秋节	Zhōngqiūjié	Mid-Autumn Festival
忠实	zhōngshí	faithful
中文	Zhōngwén	Chinese (language)
中午	zhōngwǔ	noon
终于	zhōngyú	finally
周末	zhōumò	weekend
涨	zhǎng	to rise (price)
掌柜	zhǎngguì	shopkeeper
主持	zhǔchí	to preside over; lead
座位	zuòwèi	seat
昨天	zuótiān	yesterday
左转	zuǒ zhuǎn	turn left
左/右	zuǒ/yòu	left / right
在一定程度上	zài yídìng chéngdù shàng	to a certain extent
责任	zérèn	responsibility
字幕	zìmù	subtitles
字体	zìtǐ	typeface
自由	zìyóu	freedom; freelance
综上所述	zòngshàng suǒshù	to sum up the above
糟糕	zāogāo	oh no, disaster
遭遇	zāoyù	ordeals
怎么办	zěnme bàn	what to do?

Chinese	Pinyin	English
怎么卖	zěnme mài	how is it sold?
怎么走	zěnme zǒu	how does one walk there?
租	zū	to rent
尊敬的	zūnjìng de	respected (salutation)
早上	zǎoshang	morning
总是	zǒngshì	always
走红	zǒuhóng	to become popular
按时	ànshí	on time
二	èr	2
二十	èrshí	20
二十一	èrshíyī	21
安静	ānjìng	quiet
矮	ǎi	short (height)
远航的目的	…的目的	远航之目的(formal/written)
他的结果	…的结果	其结果(formal/written)
和/与	和 (spoken)	与(written)
看到的人	看到的人	所见者(formal/written)

Stage A2 —生活

Chinese	Pinyin	English

Stage B1 —交流

Chinese	Pinyin	English

Stage B2 —视角

Chinese	Pinyin	English

Stage C1 —流利

Chinese	Pinyin	English

Stage C2 —精通

Chinese	Pinyin	English

Answer Key and Model Responses

Answers to every closed-answer exercise in the book, by stage and unit. For open tasks (communication tasks, extended writing), annotated model responses and marking criteria follow the closed answers for that stage. Pinyin is given for A-stage answers where it helps, dropped from C-stage answers where it would patronise.

Stage A1

Unit 1

Ex1: nǐ hǎo · Wǒ shì Mǎkè · xué Zhōngwén

Ex2: 1.他2.我3.你

Ex3: 1.你好！Nǐ hǎo! 2.我是学生。Wǒ shì xuésheng. 3.她是老师。Tā shì lǎoshī.

Unit 2

Ex1: 1.他是老师吗？2.你学中文吗？3.她在新加坡工作吗？

Ex2:美国c；英国d；France a；韩国b

Ex3:三sān ·五wǔ ·十shí

Ex4: 1.你是哪国人？2.你是学生吗？3.我是英国人，你呢？

Unit 3

Ex1: 1. yíyàng 2. bù hǎo 3. hén hǎo (third-tone sandhi;很hěn written) 4. yì nián

Ex2:十五shíwǔ ·四十sìshí ·九十九jiǔshíjiǔ

Ex3: 1.三个2.五个3.两个

Unit 4

Ex1: 1.有2.没有3.有…吗（你有中文书吗？）

Ex2:我的老师·马克的手机·我妈妈的朋友

Ex3: 1.这是我妹妹。2.你有哥哥吗？3.我没有手机。

Unit 5

Ex1: 1.昨天我工作了。2.我每天学中文。3.今天他休息。

Ex2: 1.昨天我休息了。2.我昨天吃了早饭。3.今天我工作了。(completed-sense context)

Ex3:七点qī diǎn ·七点半qī diǎn bàn ·八点一刻bā diǎn yíkè ·差五分九chà wǔ fēn jiǔ

Unit 6

Ex1:杯本件瓶条

Ex2:我要一碗面。/请给我两瓶水。/一共多少钱?

Ex3: 2 and 3 true; 1 false (Lin ordered paomo).

Unit 7

Ex1:很都不也（灵活，意思要通）

Ex3: 1.我们都喜欢茶。2.我不太喜欢电影。3.她也可以翻译。

Unit 8

Ex1:十月二十三号，星期四·下星期六·下午两点

Ex2:氵water ·木wood ·口mouth ·女woman

Ex3: (own answer; check date format year→month→day)

Stage A1 Assessment

Part 1: 1. Two people. 2. Two bowls of noodles and one tea. 3. 26 yuan. 4. Sunday.

Part 2: 1F 2T 3T 4F

Part 3: 1.我七点起床。2.他很高。3.我没有中文书。4.三个学生来。5.昨天我看书了。

Part 4: model —大家好！我叫马克，是美国人。我有两个妹妹。我在一家公司工作。我每天七点起床，晚上十一点睡觉。我很喜欢中文，也喜欢喝茶。我不太喜欢爬山。你好！

Criteria (10 pts): names+self-ID 2 · family 2 · routine with time words 3 · likes with也/都2 · tones legible without rereading

1. Pass ≥7.

Stage A2

Unit 1

Ex1: 1.去了2.吃过3.看了4.去过

Ex3: 1.你坐过高铁吗？2.我去年十月去了大理，住了两个星期。3.我没吃过过桥米线。

Unit 2

Ex1: 1.西安的历史比北京（的）长。2.飞机比火车快。3.今天比昨天冷一点儿。

Ex2:天气越来越冷了·中文越来越有意思了·他越来越高了

Ex3: (own; must contain比twice,跟…一样once)

Unit 3

Ex1:会可以会能

Ex2:今天天气怎么样？·明天会下雪。·我们改去博物馆吧。

Ex3: (own; one sentence per season)

Unit 4

Ex1: 1.太贵了！2.不能再少了。3.西红柿五块一斤，怎么卖？/要多少？

Ex2:这么那么斤

Ex3:这个一斤多少钱？·麻烦您给我半斤茶叶。·给我现金，谢谢。

Unit 5

Ex1:快到了·的时候·的时候/小的时候

Ex2:中秋节快到了。·吃饭以后我们看月亮。·我买了两盒月饼：一盒豆沙的，一盒蛋黄的。

Ex3: (own; needs greeting + wish)

Unit 6

Ex1: 1.猫在桌子下。2.银行在超市旁边。3.我家在学校对面。

Ex3:请问，银行在哪儿？·就在超市旁边，茶馆对面。·不远，走路十分钟。

Unit 7

Ex1:多喝水·少熬夜/多睡觉·少吃糖/别吃太多糖

Ex2:我头疼，还有一点儿发烧。·多喝热水，多休息。·先吃药，再去医院。

Ex3: (role-play; check先…再… sequence)

Unit 8

Ex1:就才才

Ex2:生日快乐—生日·新年快乐/恭喜发财—lunar new year ·中秋快乐—mid-autumn

Ex3: (own; four sentences retelling)

Stage A2 Assessment

Part 1: 1. 8 a.m. 2. Coach, two hours. 3. Much cooler than Beijing.

Part 2: 1F 2T 3T 4F

Part 3: 1.过/过2.就3.才4.比5.越来越

Part 4: 1.我去过大理，但是没去过丽江。2.地铁比公共汽车快得多。3.快下雨了，我们进去吧。4.请问，最近的药店在哪儿?

Part 4 model —去年我去了西安。我坐高铁去的，玩了五天。我看了兵马俑，也逛了菜市场。西安的面比我家那边的好吃得多。城市的变化越来越快，但是老城区还是很安静。

Criteria (10): order of events 3 · 了/过correct 3 · one comparison 2 · one越来越1 · understood without gloss 1. Pass ≥7.

Stage B1

Unit 1

Ex1:因为他不能吃辣，所以我们吃粤菜。·虽然火锅很好吃，但是太辣了。·如果明天下雨，我们就不去公园。

Ex2:好像有点儿贵。·我觉得不行。·可能不行吧。

Ex3:我觉得火锅更好，但是小王不能吃辣。·虽然很贵，但是我请客。·如果大家都同意，我们就订粤菜馆。

Unit 2

Ex1:我把手机忘在出租车里了。·请把书放在桌子上。·他把发票扔了。

Ex2:我的自行车被人/叫人偷了。·他被公司派去（了）上海。

Ex3:请把那个杯子递给我。·我把旧手机扔了。·行李被别人拿走了怎么办?

Unit 3

Ex1:下来·回去拿·出来

Ex3:我去过三次西安。·他半个小时前上来的。·新出土的士兵刚刚下来。

Unit 4

Ex1:门语车买时学

Ex2:說紅們長東見

Ex3: (check against reading)

Unit 5

Ex1:他写字写得很快。·她歌唱得很好。·我昨天睡得不好。

Ex2:我一到家就睡觉。·她一下班就给我打电话。

Ex3:我这个星期忙得连吃饭的时间都没有。·这样下去身体会受不了的。·我十点才下班。

Unit 6

Ex1:听得懂/听不懂·看得见/看不见·来得及/来不及

Ex2:好得很·累极了·漂亮得不得了

Ex3:我能听懂一点儿，但是不太懂。·衣服漂亮得很。·在手机上选好座位，扫码进场。

Unit 7

Ex1:我们要么在家吃，要么出去吃。·我要么给房东打电话，要么自己找师傅。

Ex2:又再又

Ex3:水龙头坏了；你要么修，要么漏得更厉害。·我给房东发了消息，但他还没回。·把收据保存好。

Unit 8 — interview model answers

Q1 model:我叫马克，是美国人。我在大学学的是工程，毕业以后在一家公司工作了五年。现在我一边工作一边学中文。我学中文是为了明年的旅行，也是为了认识更多的朋友。

Q2 model:我学中文，因为我觉得中国的历史很有意思。虽然汉字很难，但是很有意思。我希望有一天可以自己在中国旅行，用中文跟人聊天。

Q3 model:未来五年，我打算继续学中文，先达到可以看新闻的水平，然后去中国旅行。如果可能，我想在公司里找

跟中国有关的工作。为了这个目标，我每天至少学习一个小时。

Stage B1 Assessment

Part 1: 1. A repair person found by the landlord. 2. 80 yuan. 3. Tell him first, don't fix it himself.

Part 2: 1F 2T 3F 4T

Part 3: 1.他忙得连饭都没时间吃。2.我一到家就睡觉。3.这本书我看不懂。

Part 4:因为我不能吃辣，所以我们点了清汤。·你要么告诉房东，要么漏得更厉害。·虽然演出很长，但是好极了。·她一毕业就去了新加坡。

Part 4 criteria (10): connectives used correctly 4 ·把or被used once 2 · both sides presented 2 · conclusion clear 2. Pass ≥7.

Stage B2

Unit 1

Ex2:他是坐飞机去日本的。·这本书是我在北京（的旧书店）找到的。·她是半夜回来的。

Ex3:是为了高考，她才学到半夜的。·这是在上海买的吗？·这个制度确实给了每个人公平的机会。

Unit 2

Ex1:他越赚越多，也花得越多。·城市越大，生活越孤独。

Ex2:我忙得连饭都忘了吃。·她连名字都写错了。

Ex3:这手机快是快，但是电池不行。·他的计划便宜是便宜，但是很难做。

Unit 3

Ex1:最大的敌人是半途而废。·学习不需要“一举两得”的奇迹。·条件成熟了，事情自然成。

Ex2:画蛇添足·井底之蛙·半途而废

Unit 4

Ex1:电脑=electric brain；手机=hand machine；直播=direct broadcast；躺平=lying flat (opting out).

Ex2: (check是…的structure present)

Ex3:网络语言变得跟不上。·网络词看得懂就行，不用都会用。·“躺平”就是降低欲望、少工作的意思。

Unit 5

Ex1:他说他很累。·她问我为什么迟到。·医生让我少吃糖。

Ex2:这个习惯不仅不好，而且很贵。·她不仅会说中文，而且写得很好。

Ex3:难怪你总是累。·医生说我不仅要少吃糖，而且要睡好。·一步一步来，别太快。

Unit 6

Ex1:无论天气怎么样，比赛都要举行。·无论他怎么说，我都不相信。

Ex2:除了英语以外，他还会说德语。·除了我以外，大家都到了。

Ex3:不管多小，都是进步。·除了政策以外，还得靠消费者的选择。·真正的问题不是外卖本身，而是一次性文化。

Unit 7

Ex1:面临面对面临

Ex2:恐怕以后没有人需要司机。· AI有可能改变教育。·他大概今晚来不了。

Ex3:译者面对的不是“机器还是人”的选择。·工具变了，职业也变了。·恐怕诗歌永远需要人。

Unit 8

Ex1:尊敬的老师：您好！我因为生病，不能来上课。我会自己看录像补课，按时交作业。给您添麻烦了，非常感谢。此致敬礼！

Ex2: salutation / greeting / reason+remedy / humble closing /此致敬礼/ name+date

Ex3: (check six-line structure and您throughout)

Stage B2 Assessment

Part 1: 1. Both platform and consumers. 2. Delivery orders keep growing. 3. Education.

Part 2: 1. Translating culture, not words. 2. Poetry and law. 3. They only see today's software, not tomorrow's needs.

Part 3:她是2019年来北京的。·这个城市不仅很大，而且很拥挤。·无论政策怎么变，我都要自己选择。

Part 4:不仅是平台，消费者也有责任。·恐怕难的文本永远需要人。·我是在新加坡学会欣赏粤菜的。·除了政策以外，教育也很重要。

Criteria (10): claim stated 2 · two sides with connectives 3 ·是…的used correctly 2 · hedged prediction 1 · closes with position 2. Pass ≥7.

Stage C1

Unit 1

Ex1:学了以后按时温习它/ Having learned, to practise it at the proper time ·有朋友从远方来/ A friend comes from afar ·不也很快乐吗/ Is it not also a joy?

Ex2:于=at/in (born in) ·以=by means of (through writing) ·者=the one who (reader)

Ex3: (check headline finds a文言phrase such as据悉/会后/此前)

Unit 2

Ex1: 1.据(说)—信号词让赞美变成“别人说的”2.不是不行—让步式肯定3.所谓—引号式否认

Ex2: (check restraint:据介绍/有待/似乎)

Ex3:这个不是不行，只是勉强。·所谓的创新就是多了一个按钮。·这家报纸的文体是克制，不是夸张。

Unit 3

Ex1: (倒/却)却·倒·却

Ex2:语言活在真实的使用里；政策只能给时间。

Ex3:“不会说”和“不说”是两回事。·政策可以给时间，但救不了一门语言。·随着普通话的推广，大城市里方言确实用得少了。

Unit 4

Ex1: (由…组成models)年夜饭由四五个菜组成。·我们小组由五个人组成。

Ex2:天气时而下雨，时而放晴。·老师时而严肃，时而幽默。·股价时而涨，时而跌。

Ex3:辣椒最初是作为昂贵盐的替代品被接受的。·一部中国饮食史，半部是交流史。·番茄用了几百年才上餐桌。

Unit 5

Ex1: (models)这部纪录片值得一看。·《红楼梦》不愧为经典。·学历史的价值在于理解现在。·归根结底，习惯决定一切。

Ex2: (check将appears once)

Ex3:影片的价值不在于控诉，而在于呈现。·影片将几十年的动荡压进了一张饭桌。·正如片名所暗示的，活着本身就是答案。

Unit 6

Ex1: (models)电子书看起来要取代纸书，其实不然：纸书变成了礼物。·手写并不是为了效率，而是为了记住。·正因为难，学的人才觉得有意思。

Ex2:书法不是把字写好看，而是用时间、力气和呼吸去组织空间。·正因为键盘替代了手，人们才重新思考手写。·每个用中文写作的人，都在享受几千年审美劳动的成果。

Unit 7

Ex1:这个政策未必有效。·老龄化并非危机。·技术未必能解决一切。

Ex2: (check诚然…但… and final归根结底)

Ex3:一个社会可以在二十年内变富，却无法在二十年内变老得慢。·老龄化不是问题，而是成就。·问题不是“怎么办”，而是“怎样办得好”。

Unit 8

Ex1:尊敬的老师：您好！本人拟申请该项目，恳请您审阅随信附上的材料。盼复。此致敬礼！

Ex2: (check hook before thanks, thesis early)

Ex3: (own; look for three concrete edits)

Stage C1 Assessment

Part 1: 1. Quantity — several thousand characters vs 26 letters. 2. To be forgotten — reader sees content, not characters. 3. 正因为如此…才…: cause emphasised, not just sequence.

Part 2: 1.并非全错rejects“方言注定消失”with并非. 2. Identity (“我是谁”), not usefulness. 3. Open paraphrase.

Part 3:他的书被翻译成了中文。·该项目之目的/其目的· (formal email with拟/恳请/盼复)

Part 4 model —手写的价值：有人说，在键盘时代，手写已经没有用了。这种说法并非全错，却忽略了一件事：写字从来不只是传递信息。诚然，打字更快，也更清楚；但是手写把时间放进了字里——一封信的重量，一半是纸的，一半是写字人的。归根结底，我们写的不是字，是我们自己。值得一看的，从来都是这样的东西。

Criteria (10): concession with诚然2 · gentle negation并非/未必2 · evaluation在于/值得2 · formal particles used 2 · final turn 2. Pass ≥7.

Stage C2

Unit 1

Ex1:学了以后按时温习它/ learn and duly practise it · a friend comes from afar · is it not also a joy?

Ex2:于=preposition at ·以=by means of ·者=nominaliser (the one who)

Ex3: (own; must explain a modern descendant like据悉)

Unit 2

Ex1: 1.据说—把断言推给“别人”2.不是不行—让步式贬低3.所谓—引号式否认

Ex2: (check understatement:有待/据…介绍)

Ex3:这个不是不行，只是勉强能用。·所谓的创新，就是多了一个按钮。·这家报纸的文体是克制，不是夸张。

Unit 3

Ex1: (models)或许，常喝咖啡的人寿命可能更长，但有待验证。·在一定程度上，AI会改变翻译，但未必取代所有翻译。·这个城市在很大程度上不堵车，但因时段而异。

Ex2: (check因果vs相关distinction)

Ex3:标题漏掉了研究没说的三件事。·限定词不是懦弱，而是诚实。·这个发现不大，而且因年龄和地区而异。

Unit 4

Ex1: (models)退一步说，方便是真的。但“必然取代”不能从“方便”推出来。雨伞比雨衣方便，可雨衣还在。

Ex2:以偏概全· false dilemma (非黑即白)

Ex3:与其提高价格，不如缩小范围。·除非首年印数有保证，否则授权费很难降。·恕我直言，这个方案比刚才的更可行。

Unit 5

Ex1: (own; check frame: concede → reframe → close)

Ex2: (check与其…不如… appears)

Ex3:与其提高价格，不如缩小范围。·除非首年印数有保证，否则授权费很难降。·恕我直言，这个方案比刚才的更可行。

Unit 6 —缘分translator's note (model)

“缘分”指的是一种命中注定的相遇——“分”是注定的那一份。它不是英语的“fate”，因为它总是关于两个人之间的事。比如老朋友在别的国家偶遇，中国人会说“真有缘分”。以下均译作“a bond of fate”，并在第一次出现时保留原文。

Ex3:好的译者不是把这些词交出去，而是给它们盖一座小房子。·翻译的誓言不是逐字忠实，而是不让读者迷路。·孝不是服从，也不是爱，而是一种以父母为中心的伦理秩序。

Unit 7

Ex1: 1预测2推断3推断（且是重述问题）

Ex3:它混淆了两件事：输入的效率和书写系统的地位。·打字解决“怎么写”；要来的问题是“还写不写”。·这个问题，技术回答不了。

Final Assessment

Part 1: 1. It convinces beginners they cannot learn before they start. 2. Confidence starts, method speeds, integration (making it part of life) keeps. 3. Open paraphrase.

Part 2: 1.它假设翻译只是信息的搬运，而语言的作用远不止信息。2. Open (the machine translates content, not“us”). 3. Open, fairness required.

Part 3: 1.呃，不是不贵…… 2.这个预测未必成立。3.诚然，您说得有道理，但…… 4.综上所述，机器可以替你工作，但没法替你成长。

Part 4: 1.恕我直言，这个方案混淆了两件事。2.与其保护语言，不如活在语言里。3.信心让你开始，方法让你走得快

，但只有把学习变成生活的一部分，你才走得远。

Extended model —语言与身份：有一种预测说，机器翻译成熟以后，外语就没有用了。恕我直言，这个预测混淆了两件事：信息的搬运和一个人的扩展。诚然，机器可以把菜单译得完美；但机器没法替你在敬酒的时候举杯，也没法替你在吵架的时候心疼。在我看来，学外语的价值未必在于听懂别人——在一定程度上，它更像是在变成一个更大的自己。古人说，“学而时习之，不亦说乎？”我想补一句：学外语而时用之，不亦大乎？归根结底，机器可以替你工作，但没法替你成长。

Criteria (12): register control incl. one deliberate casual sentence 3 · classical quotation with rendering 2 · concession诚然 2 · hedge set 2 · final reframe 2 · overall spine 1. Pass ≥9.